From Committee to Mutual Aid: A Path Forward for Bear Creek Friends Meeting

A working document for discernment, prepared for Bear Creek Friends Meeting

"We must truly have faith in each other, and our spiritual faith."

Preface

This document exists because Bear Creek Friends Meeting is already changing, and change deserves to be named, examined, and held up to the Light together rather than left to happen to us piecemeal.

Over the past several months, conversations among Friends — in business meeting, in the margins of committee reports, in a role-interest survey now beginning to circulate — have been circling around the same recognition from several directions at once. A small number of Friends are carrying most of the weight of the meeting's institutional life: its clerking, its correspondence, its property, its finances, its pastoral care, its record-keeping, its hosting of Midyear Meeting, its relationship to the Yearly Meeting above and to the worship groups under its care. Meanwhile, a wider circle of Friends — some who gather in the meetinghouse on Bear Creek Road, many more who join by Zoom from Minnesota, from town, from wherever life has taken them — hold real gifts, real convictions, and in some cases real frustration that the meeting has not found a way to put those gifts to use or to engage the justice work many of them consider inseparable from their faith.

These are not two different problems. They are one problem seen from two sides: a structure built for a different era, straining to hold a meeting that has already become something else — smaller in the room, larger on the screen, carrying more history than any one person can be the steward of, and facing a world outside its doors that is less stable than the world in which that structure was built.

This document does not propose solving that strain by working harder inside the existing structure. It proposes a different structure: one built on **interest groups** rather than standing committees, on **mutual aid** rather than hierarchical oversight, and on **trust** rather than **approval**. None of this is proposed as a theory borrowed from outside Bear Creek. Nearly every piece of it is already present somewhere in Bear Creek's own practice — in the fact that Peace and Social Concerns functions today with no standing committee at all, simply as reports "to the meeting as a whole"; in the fact that Laughing Waters Friends Worship Group meets faithfully by Zoom under Bear Creek's care without ever having been staffed like a committee; in the fact that Jeff Kisling and Jenny Cisar once served as Co-Clerks, proving that the Clerk's work can be shared without being diminished; in the fact that *Faith and Practice* itself allows committees to be "appointed when need arises... laid down once the need has been met" (p. 55), rather than insisting that every function be permanent and every permanence be hierarchical.

What follows, then, is less an invention than a naming — an attempt to take seriously what Bear Creek has already begun to discover about itself, and to follow that discovery all the way through: into how the meeting makes decisions, how it communicates, how it handles money, how it cares for its own history, how it prepares for a harder future, and how it remains faithful to the larger body of Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) even as its internal life changes shape.

Who this is for. This is written for every Friend who holds any relationship to Bear Creek — those who attend in person most First Days, those who join by Zoom from a kitchen table two states away, those who have drifted to the edges of the meeting's active life but have never let go of it, and those who are reading this for the first time because someone finally thought to ask what they might want to do. If you fall into that last group especially: this document is, among other things, an invitation. The interest-group model it describes is built to make room for you — not as a volunteer slotted into someone else's committee, but as someone whose own leading, named and followed, becomes one more channel through which this meeting's life flows.

How to read this. The document moves from the spiritual ground of the proposal (Part II) through an honest accounting of where the meeting stands right now (Part III), into a diagnosis of why the inherited structure no longer fits (Part IV), a grounding of mutual aid in lived experience rather than theory (Part V), the interest-group model itself (Part VI), and what actually replaces "approval" once a central gatekeeper is no longer the mechanism of trust (Part VII). From there it works outward into practical machinery — communication (Part VIII), money (Part IX), the newly reopened safe and Bear Creek's own history (Part X), preparation for a harder world (Part XI), the meeting's continuing obligations to Iowa Yearly Meeting (Part XII), and the possibility that Bear Creek's experiment might serve other small meetings facing the same strain (Part XIII) — before closing with a roadmap (Part XIV) that is deliberately staged, deliberately reversible, and deliberately not a five-year plan handed down from on high, because a document about trusting the Spirit's movement in each interest group cannot itself pretend to know, in advance, exactly where that movement will lead.

An extended word on invitation. Among everything this document proposes, the invitation to Friends with loose ties to Bear Creek deserves to be named as more than a secondary benefit of structural change — it is one of this document's central purposes, and it is worth dwelling on directly here rather than leaving it implicit in the structural proposals that follow.

Every meeting accumulates, over years, a circle of people whose connection to it has thinned without ever quite breaking: a Friend who moved away and stopped attending but still feels Bear Creek as part of who they are; someone who came for a season during a hard time in their life and found real welcome, then drifted as life moved on; a family member of a longtime Friend

who grew up half in and half out of the meeting's life; someone who found Bear Creek through Prairie Awakening, through Jeff's own blog, through a wedding or a memorial service held in the meetinghouse, and never quite found a next step back in. These are not people who rejected Bear Creek. They are people for whom no door happened to be standing open at the moment they might have walked through it.

The interest-group model this document proposes is built, in part, specifically for these Friends. A standing committee asks for a level of commitment — regular attendance, an ongoing seat, a multi-year expectation — that can feel like too large a step for someone whose relationship to the meeting has become occasional or uncertain. An interest group asks something much smaller and more specific: help with one bounded task, for as long as it holds your interest, with no implied obligation beyond that. This is a genuinely different kind of invitation, and this document recommends Bear Creek extend it directly and personally — not through a general announcement, but through the kind of individual outreach that actually reaches people who have drifted: a phone call, a personal note, a direct and specific ask ("we're cataloguing the old records, and I thought of you because I remember you mentioning you loved history — would you want to help?") rather than a general call for volunteers that a Friend on the margins may not feel is really meant for them.

This is also where the role-interest survey, still in its early stages, has a purpose beyond Bear Creek's current active membership. As it continues to circulate, this document recommends it reach beyond the Friends currently gathering or attending by Zoom regularly, to exactly this wider circle — former attenders, family members, Friends who have transferred their membership but kept real affection for Bear Creek, anyone whose name a current Friend might think to add to the list. Re-engagement, under this model, does not require someone to recommit to regular attendance before they are welcome to contribute. It only requires a genuine task, honestly offered, and a door actually held open long enough for them to notice it.

A note on names: this document names specific Friends in their current roles, drawing on Bear Creek's own records. This is done deliberately, not carelessly. Abstraction is comfortable but it is also where institutional change goes to die — a plan that only ever talks about "the Clerk" in the abstract never has to reckon with what it would actually mean for Jackie Leckband to set down three of her four roles, or what it would mean for Osa Bricker to no longer be the only person who knows where the accounts are. Naming names is a way of keeping this document honest about whose actual lives it is proposing to change, and in whose actual hands its ideas would have to take root.

On how deep change should arrive. What this document proposes is substantial — touching nearly every part of how Bear Creek organizes its shared life — and that scope deserves an honest word about the manner in which it should unfold. This is closer to what Friends have historically called a leading followed faithfully than to any kind of break with what came before: change arrived at through the same patient, tested, consent-based process Quaker discernment has always required, taken one tested step at a time, and reversible wherever the meeting's own experience shows it is needed. Depth of change and speed of change are different things, and this document asks only for the first. The pace remains, throughout, gradual, tested, and entirely subject to Bear Creek's own gathered sense of right timing — not a plan handed down to be enacted, but a leading to be discerned, tried, and grown into as the meeting itself is ready.

A note on length and purpose. This document is long — longer than most things Bear Creek will read together — and that length deserves a word of explanation rather than an apology. It is written not to be read aloud at a single business meeting, but to be lived with: picked up over weeks, read a part at a time, returned to as particular questions arise ("what does this actually say about money?" "what happens to the Treasurer's role in all this?"), and used as a reference as the meeting's own discernment unfolds. Every part is written to stand largely on its own, so that a Friend who wants to go straight to the finance proposal, or straight to the archive project, or straight to the roadmap at the end, can do so without needing to have read everything that comes before. The length is an attempt at thoroughness and honesty, not an attempt to overwhelm; nothing here asks to be accepted whole, or quickly, or without the meeting's own testing.

What this document is not. It is not a minute. It carries no authority of its own, and nothing in it becomes Bear Creek's practice simply because it is written down here. It is not a finished blueprint meant to be adopted wholesale and then left alone; the roadmap in Part XIV is explicitly staged and reversible, built to be adjusted as the meeting actually lives with each piece. And it is not a criticism of any Friend currently serving in any role — quite the opposite. Every recommendation here is offered in gratitude for the faithfulness that has carried Bear Creek this far, and in the conviction that this same faithfulness deserves a structure that asks less of a few and makes room for more.

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Executive Summary

For any Friend who wants the whole of this document's argument before working through its full length, or who wants a short account to carry into conversation with others: this is what the document proposes, in brief.

The problem. Bear Creek's committee structure, inherited largely intact from an earlier, more co-located era, now strains under the meeting's actual shape — a hybrid community, roughly half gathering at the meetinghouse and half joining by Zoom from as far as Minnesota, with a small number of Friends (Jackie Leckband above all, alongside Russ Leckband, Osa Bricker, Win Standing, Liz Oppenheimer, and others) carrying most of its institutional weight, including gaps *Faith and Practice* itself anticipates being filled — no Assistant Clerk, no Assistant Treasurer — that Bear Creek has left open. At the same time, many Friends, including a wider circle who connect only by Zoom, hold real gifts and real convictions about justice work that the current structure gives them no easy door into.

The proposal. Replace most standing committees with **interest groups**: small, task-bound gatherings of Friends that form around a specific need, report openly to the whole meeting, and dissolve when their work is done, rather than requiring standing appointment. Keep only **Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, and Trustees** as formally named, continuity-bearing roles — and even these, structured for sharing (an Assistant Clerk, an Assistant Treasurer) rather than solitary carrying. Replace **central approval** with **trust tested through transparency**: interest groups act and report, rather than seeking permission first, with the gathered meeting's ongoing discernment — not a single gatekeeper's advance sign-off — doing the work of accountability.

Why this is more than an efficiency measure. The proposal is grounded in Quaker testimony — community, equality, simplicity, integrity — and in the conviction that trust extended before the fact, tested after, is actually closer to historic Quaker practice (waiting worship, the meeting for sufferings, clearness committees) than the committee-approval model it would replace. It is also grounded in lived experience: Jeff Kisling's three years with Des Moines Mutual Aid, the 2018 First Nation-Farmer Climate Unity March, and ongoing relationship with Great Plains Action Society's Urban Resilience Hub all demonstrate, in practice rather than theory, that resources and trust can circulate without gatekeeping.

What it touches. Beyond governance itself: a **communication network** built for a dispersed, hybrid meeting; a **finance model** in which any interest group can draw modest funds on trust, memorial gifts circulate rather than sit in reserve, and urgent need can be met with same-day digital distribution; a plan for the newly reopened **safe and historical archive**, proposed as the

model's first proving ground; **survival and resilience** work on water, food, medicine, and energy, grounded in realistic but hopeful engagement with environmental and economic strain; continued, unchanged faithfulness to **Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative)**'s reporting obligations; and the possibility that Bear Creek's own honest experience becomes a **gift to other small meetings** facing the same strain.

How it would happen. Staged, not all at once: closing the Assistant Clerk and Assistant Treasurer gaps and launching the archive project as a pilot first; naming the interest-group model explicitly only once that pilot has shown real results; building the finance mechanism with real care; and checking in at regular intervals to ask honestly whether the model is relieving overload and opening doors, or needs adjustment — with nothing in this roadmap treated as irreversible.

What it asks of Bear Creek. Faith — in each other, and in the Spirit's movement in each small gathering of Friends taking up a piece of this meeting's life — extended as the operating assumption behind how Bear Creek actually works, not merely as a sentiment affirmed at worship and set aside for the week's business.

Part II: Spiritual Grounding — Why This Is a Faith Question Before a Structural One

It would be a mistake to read what follows as primarily an exercise in organizational redesign — a kind of institutional efficiency project dressed in Quaker language. The argument of this document is the reverse: that the structure Bear Creek inherited, a structure of standing committees reporting upward through a Clerk who holds final responsibility for discerning "the sense of the meeting," was never simply administrative machinery. It encoded a set of assumptions about where trust lives, how the Spirit moves, and what a community owes its members — and those assumptions are worth examining directly, in the light, rather than inheriting them by default because they are what we have always done.

The testimony of community. Quaker practice has always held that the Spirit speaks to the gathered body, not only to its officers. Meeting for worship with attention to business is not a hearing before a judge; it is a shared listening in which the Clerk's role is to discern and articulate what the meeting has already, together, come to see — not to decide on the meeting's behalf and then seek its ratification. If this is true in the hour of business meeting, there is no obvious reason it stops being true the moment the meeting disperses into the work of the week. An interest group of three Friends discerning together how to catalog the contents of a newly opened safe, or how fast to release memorial funds to a family in need, is engaged in exactly the same kind of gathered listening that happens on the third First Day of the month — only smaller, more frequent, and closer to the actual texture of the work. If we trust the testimony of community enough to let a dozen people in a room discern the meeting's mind on a query, we should be able to trust three or four people, led to a particular task, to discern rightly within that task without first routing their judgment through a central approval.

The testimony of equality. Quakers have never believed that spiritual authority is a scarce resource held by a few and rationed out through office. Every Friend is held to carry a measure of the Light; every Friend's leading deserves to be tested, not dismissed, by the discernment of others. A committee structure that funnels decision-making through named officeholders — however devotedly those Friends serve — risks treating institutional position as a proxy for spiritual authority it was never meant to represent. Jackie Leckband's faithfulness as Clerk is not in question anywhere in this document; what is in question is whether a structure that asks one person to also clerk Religious Education and Spiritual Enrichment, co-clerk Funeral and Memorial, and co-clerk Hospitality is itself consistent with a testimony that no single Friend's gifts should be asked to stand in for the whole meeting's.

The testimony of simplicity. Simplicity is often reduced to a matter of possessions, but its older and more exacting meaning concerns the removal of everything that stands between a person and their direct relationship with the Divine and with their neighbor. A structure in which an interest group cannot act on its own discernment until it clears a central approval is, in this older sense, an unsimplified structure: it interposes a procedural step between a leading and its fruit. This is not a claim that all process is spiritually suspect — the testing of leadings in community is itself a Quaker discipline, not an obstacle to it. It is a claim that the *particular* form that testing has taken at Bear Creek, centralized in a small number of officeholders because that is how committees have always worked, is one choice among several, and perhaps no longer the choice best suited to a dispersed, hybrid, thinly staffed meeting.

The testimony of peace. Peace is often understood narrowly, as the absence of war or violence, but Quaker practice has always held a fuller meaning: right relationship, held without coercion, in which conflict is addressed through truth and love rather than through power exercised over another. A structure built on central approval is, in this fuller sense, a structure that keeps a small measure of coercive power in reserve at all times — the power to say no, to withhold, to require justification before allowing action — even when that power is exercised gently and in good faith by Friends acting with real care. A structure built on trust, tested through transparency rather than enforced through advance control, is more fully consonant with the testimony of peace in this deeper sense: it asks Bear Creek to relate to its own members, and to the Friends and interest groups doing its work, without holding coercive power over them in reserve, trusting instead that truth spoken openly and tested in community will do the work that power held in reserve was meant to do. This is not a minor point. A meeting whose peace testimony extends outward toward the world's violence, as Bear Creek's own history of engagement with conscientious objection demonstrates, is rightly asked to examine whether that same testimony is fully present in its own internal life as well — in how it holds its own members accountable to one another, not only in how it bears witness to the wider world.

The testimony of integrity. Integrity asks that our structures actually be what we say they are. If Bear Creek says it trusts the movement of the Spirit in each of its members, but builds a decision-making structure that requires most initiative to be approved by a small number of standing committees before it can proceed, there is a gap between what is professed and what is practiced. Closing that gap — not by abandoning accountability, but by relocating it from central approval to mutual trust and open reporting — is itself a work of integrity.

On "approval" and why it cannot be the mechanism of a mutual aid meeting. It is worth being direct about the hardest claim this document makes: that central approval, as a gatekeeping mechanism, is incompatible with genuine mutual aid. Approval assumes that someone at the

center knows better, in advance, than the people closest to a need or a leading — that a Finance interest group discerning how quickly to release memorial funds to a family facing an emergency needs its judgment checked by a treasurer or a trustee before it can act, rather than needing its judgment *tested* through transparency after the fact, the way any Friend's leading is tested in community. Those are not the same thing, and the difference matters enormously in practice. Testing-after-the-fact, through open books and shared reporting, preserves accountability without recreating the bottleneck that currently exhausts the handful of Friends who presently occupy the approval seats. Approval-in-advance preserves control, but at the cost of exactly the overload this document is trying to name and address. A meeting that wants genuine mutual aid has to be willing to trade the comfort of control for the discipline of trust — tested, examined, accountable trust, but trust nonetheless, extended before the fact rather than withheld until it.

Faith in each other, faith in the Spirit. Jeff's own language for this, in the conversation that gave rise to this document, is simple and exact: *we must truly have faith in each other, and in our spiritual faith.* That sentence is the theological center of everything that follows. Every structural recommendation in this document is an attempt to build a meeting whose everyday workings actually embody that faith — not as a sentiment expressed at business meeting, but as the operating assumption behind who gets to act, how quickly, and with how much is asked of them before they are trusted to begin.

This does not mean the absence of discipline. Friends have never confused faith with carelessness. The testing of leadings, the keeping of records, the honest reporting of what was done and why — all of this remains, and in some respects becomes *more* important, not less, as central approval recedes. What changes is where the testing happens: not before action, in a gatekeeper's judgment, but around action, in the ordinary Quaker discipline of transparency, query, and the gathered meeting's continuing oversight of its own spiritual condition.

A theology of smallness

It would be easy for this entire document to read, despite its best intentions, as a response to decline — a meeting shrinking, straining, adapting because it must, rather than because smallness itself might carry its own spiritual gift worth claiming rather than merely accommodating. This deserves direct address, because the posture a meeting brings to its own smallness shapes everything built on top of it.

Early Friends were themselves a small, often persecuted minority, meeting in small rooms, trusting that the Spirit's presence did not require numbers to be real or sufficient. Bear Creek's own smallness, whatever losses it represents against an earlier, fuller season of its life, is not evidence of spiritual failure — it is simply the actual size of the community the Spirit has gathered

here, now, and this document's entire proposal rests on taking that actual community seriously rather than organizing around the ghost of a larger one. A structure built for a bigger meeting, imposed on a smaller one out of nostalgia or obligation, serves neither the meeting's present reality nor its members' actual capacity. A structure built honestly for twenty-some actively engaged Friends, trusting each other directly rather than through layers of committee hierarchy meant for a different scale, can be more genuinely intimate, more genuinely responsive, and in some ways more genuinely faithful than a larger meeting's necessarily more impersonal machinery ever could be. Smallness, held rightly, is not only a constraint this document is working around; it is part of what makes the trust-based model proposed here actually possible — a gift smaller meetings have access to that larger ones, with their inevitably greater institutional distance between members, often do not.

Waiting worship as the oldest model this document has

It is worth pausing on a form of Quaker practice so familiar it can be easy to stop noticing what it actually demonstrates: unprogrammed waiting worship itself. Bear Creek gathers at eleven on First Day with no order of service, no officiant directing what happens next, no approval required before a Friend rises to speak. What holds that hour together is not structure in the administrative sense — it is shared discipline, mutual trust, and a common practice of listening for the Spirit's movement, tested in real time by the gathered body's own sense of whether a given word was rightly given. Friends do not submit vocal ministry for advance approval. They trust the same Spirit that moves in them to move, or not move, in the Friend who rises — and when ministry misses the mark, the meeting's response is not a gatekeeping mechanism invoked beforehand but a quiet, patient, communal process of discernment afterward, sometimes spoken directly to the Friend in love, sometimes simply held and absorbed by a seasoned meeting's own maturity.

This document's central claim — that trust, tested after the fact through transparency, can rightly replace approval sought before it — is not a novel import into Quaker practice. It is already how Bear Creek conducts the most sacred hour of its week. The proposal here is to let that same trust extend further into the meeting's life: into its committee work, its finances, its care for its own history and its own future, rather than cordoning it off as a practice reserved for worship alone, as if the Spirit that can be trusted to move rightly in open worship cannot also be trusted to move rightly in three Friends gathered to catalog a box of old records or decide how quickly to help a family facing an emergency.

A formation that already points this way

It is worth noting, too, that this document's emphasis on trust, shared labor, and communal accountability over hierarchical oversight is not an idea arriving at Bear Creek from nowhere. Jeff's own formation at Scattergood Friends School — a working farm school in Iowa, from which he graduated in 1970 — integrated physical labor and communal accountability as a matter of daily practice, not abstract teaching: students and staff together responsible for the farm's actual work, accountable to each other through the direct, visible consequences of shared labor rather than through a distant supervisory structure checking their work in advance. That formation, and the earlier grounding in Bear Creek's own rural Iowa Quaker community at Bear Creek Meeting itself, where Jeff grew up, planted something that this document's proposal makes explicit decades later: that a community bound by shared, visible, mutually accountable work does not need the same apparatus of advance approval that a community of strangers, or a community organized around distant hierarchy, might reasonably feel it requires. Bear Creek's Friends already know each other in something closer to the way a working farm school's students and staff knew each other — through long, accumulated, shared presence — even if the meeting's formal committee structure has not always reflected that underlying reality back to itself.

Precedent from the wider tradition

Early Friends did not generally organize their communal life through standing committees exercising approval authority over individual members' leadings. The meeting for sufferings — a body formed in seventeenth-century England to respond to Friends' persecution — was itself closer to what this document calls an interest group than to a modern standing committee: formed around an urgent, specific need, empowered to act with real latitude because the need demanded responsiveness no slow-moving approval process could provide, and never treated as a permanent fixture whose existence was separate from the need that called it into being. Quaker business process more broadly has always rested on the conviction that the Spirit speaks through the gathered body as a whole — the Clerk's historic function is to *discern and articulate* the sense of the meeting, not to possess independent authority to grant or withhold approval over what individual Friends or small groups of Friends do between gatherings. Where more hierarchical, approval-based committee structures became entrenched in later Quaker practice, including in corners of Iowa Yearly Meeting's own long history, this document suggests they reflect later institutional accretion more than a necessary feature of Quaker faith and practice itself — accretion that a small, strained, geographically dispersed meeting like Bear Creek now has good reason, and real permission within its own tradition, to reconsider.

Part III: Honoring Where We Are — Two Truths Held Together

Any proposal for change that does not begin by telling the truth about the present will be received, rightly, as naive. Two truths need to be held at once in this document, and neither should be allowed to cancel the other out.

The first truth: a small number of Friends are carrying an unsustainable load, and have been for some time.

Bear Creek's own 2021/2022 Nominating Committee record, read plainly, tells this story without needing commentary. Jackie Leckband serves as Clerk, as co-clerk of Religious Education/Spiritual Enrichment with Liz Oppenheimer, as a member of the Funeral and Memorial Committee, and as co-clerk of the Hospitality Committee. Russ Leckband serves on House and Grounds, on Ministry and Counsel, and as a Trustee. Stan Sanders serves on House and Grounds and on Ministry and Counsel. Win Standing serves as Recorder, on the Funeral and Memorial Committee, and on Hospitality. Osa Bricker serves as Treasurer and as a Trustee. Liz Oppenheimer serves on Religious Education/Spiritual Enrichment and holds Bear Creek's seat on the Yearly Meeting's own Ministry and Counsel Committee — a three-year term, staggered, carrying obligations beyond Bear Creek itself. Historically, Jeff Kisling carried Peace and Social Concerns and Outreach simultaneously, and continues Outreach and Website work today with Jennie Cisar.

Two structural gaps compound this. *Faith and Practice* assumes a Clerk working alongside an Assistant or Recording Clerk (p. 50) — a deputy positioned to take a piece of business off the Clerk's hands, or to step in when the Clerk needs to step back from clerking a particular item because of a personal interest in its outcome. Bear Creek currently has no one in that position. The same is true of the Treasurer's office: *Faith and Practice* (p. 76) envisions an Assistant Treasurer who at minimum knows "the location of records and bank accounts" as a backstop; Bear Creek has no Assistant Treasurer, which means the knowledge of the meeting's financial life currently runs, in practice, through one person.

None of this is a criticism of the Friends who hold these roles. It is the opposite: it is a precise naming of how much is currently being asked of a few people, out of faithfulness, without the structural support *Faith and Practice* itself assumes should exist alongside them. A meeting that wants to honor the Friends currently carrying this load has an obligation to change the structure that is asking too much of them — not simply to thank them for their service and leave the structure as it is.

The second truth: other Friends experience the meeting as stagnant, and some of that stagnation is a justice problem, not only a capacity problem.

It would be dishonest to frame the meeting's strain purely as a matter of too few hands for too many tasks. Some Friends — including some who join faithfully by Zoom from Minnesota or elsewhere, and some whose attendance has become occasional precisely because of this — experience Bear Creek's current rhythm of life as having drifted away from engagement with the justice work many of them consider central to Quaker faith. Peace and Social Concerns, which Jeff clerked decades ago and under whose authority his own 1972 correspondence regarding Selective Service was written, has no standing committee today; its business now surfaces only as occasional reports "as the meeting as a whole." That is, on one reading, exactly the kind of flexible, unburdened structure this document recommends generalizing. On another reading, held by other Friends, it is a sign that peace and justice concerns have quietly receded from the meeting's active life rather than simply changed form.

Both readings can be true in different parts of the same meeting at the same time, and this document does not attempt to adjudicate between them. What it does claim is that an interest-group structure, properly built, is capable of answering *both* truths at once in a way the current structure cannot. It can relieve the handful of Friends currently overextended by distributing specific, bounded tasks to a much wider circle of willing hands — including the growing number of Friends who connect by Zoom (Karen Morey, Jenny Cisar, Doug Mankins, August Kalinosky, Jon Tesdell, Nat Case, Osa Bricker, Greg Blumhagen, Kate Moos, Alan Blakestad, Marion Love, Sonja Sponheim, Randy Kisling, and others), many of whom have real gifts and interest that have simply never been matched to a task. And it can simultaneously reopen space for justice work by making it structurally easy — easier than forming a standing committee ever was — for Friends moved by a leading toward peace work, mutual aid, or solidarity organizing to simply begin, name what they are doing, and invite others in, the way Jeff's own Peace Committee work once did and the way his ongoing relationships with Great Plains Action Society and the old channel built through Des Moines Mutual Aid continue to do outside any formal Bear Creek structure at all.

Grace for the transition itself. It is worth saying plainly, before the rest of this document moves into recommendation and roadmap: *the Friends carrying Bear Creek's institutional load right now are not the obstacle to this change, and should not be made to feel that they are.* A structure built on trust rather than approval is, if anything, easier on exactly these Friends — it does not ask Jackie to personally approve every interest group's action, or Osa to personally sign off on every expenditure before it happens. It asks something different and, properly supported, lighter: that the roles genuinely requiring continuity (Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, Trustees) remain named and honored, while everything else currently piled onto those same few shoulders is set free to become the work of a much wider circle. This document's roadmap (Part XIV) is built around

exactly this sequencing: relief first, for the Friends already carrying the weight, before anything more ambitious is attempted.

What the load actually looks like, Friend by Friend

It is easy to speak of "overload" in the abstract and harder, but more honest, to look at it in specific lives. Jackie Leckband clerks the meeting, co-clerks Religious Education and Spiritual Enrichment, serves on the Funeral and Memorial Committee, and co-clerks Hospitality — meaning that in a single ordinary month, Jackie may be guiding business meeting, helping plan a memorial service, thinking through the meeting's religious education offerings, and coordinating the use of the meetinghouse and cottage, often in the same week, with no Assistant Clerk positioned to take any piece of this off her hands when it becomes too much at once. Osa Bricker holds the meeting's entire financial picture as Treasurer and carries legal responsibility for its property as a Trustee, with no Assistant Treasurer who could, in *Faith and Practice*'s own words, simply know "the location of records and bank accounts" if Osa were unavailable for any reason — illness, travel, the ordinary interruptions of a full life. Russ Leckband divides his attention across House and Grounds, Ministry and Counsel, and Trustees — property, pastoral care, and legal stewardship all at once. Win Standing holds the Recorder's role alongside Funeral and Memorial and Hospitality. Liz Oppenheimer carries Religious Education and Spiritual Enrichment at Bear Creek while also representing the meeting on Iowa Yearly Meeting's own Ministry and Counsel Committee — a three-year commitment extending beyond Bear Creek's own walls.

None of these Friends has complained, in any record available to this document, about what they carry — and that itself is worth sitting with rather than passing over. Friends who serve this faithfully rarely raise their own overload as a grievance; they simply keep serving, which is precisely why a structure depending on their continued willingness to absorb more than *Faith and Practice* itself anticipates any one person carrying is a structure quietly running on borrowed time. A meeting that waits for these Friends to name their own limits before acting is a meeting asking its most faithful members to do one more piece of difficult work — advocating for their own relief — on top of everything else already asked of them.

Several voices, held together

Because no single account can speak for everyone touched by this proposal, it may help to imagine, briefly and honestly, how several different Friends might reasonably receive it — not as a survey of actual opinions, which this document does not have, but as an exercise in holding multiple legitimate responses in view at once, rather than writing as though only one reaction is possible.

A Friend who has served faithfully for decades, carrying real institutional weight, might read this document with a mixture of relief and uncertainty — grateful for the prospect of lighter load, but wary of trusting work she has long held closely to Friends she does not yet know as well as she knows the structure itself. A newer Friend, drawn to Bear Creek recently by its peace witness or its welcome, might read it with real excitement — finally, a door that does not require years of accumulated trust before it opens — tempered by uncertainty about whether she yet knows the meeting well enough to find her own footing inside a looser structure. A remote Friend joining faithfully from Minnesota might feel, reading this, genuinely seen for the first time in a planning document — and might also feel a flicker of grief that it took this long, that doors like this were not opened sooner. A Friend skeptical of change for its own sake might read this and feel, not unreasonably, that something real and valuable in Bear Creek's settled rhythms is being put at risk for the sake of an idea not yet proven — a response this document has tried to take seriously throughout, in Part XV above all, rather than dismiss as mere resistance to the new.

None of these responses is wrong, and this document does not ask any of them to be set aside in favor of the others. It asks only that each be brought honestly into the meeting's shared discernment, tested there as every leading is tested, rather than any one of them — including the document's own evident enthusiasm for its own proposal — being allowed to stand in for what the whole gathered meeting actually senses together.

Grief, change, and what a shrinking feeling actually means

It is worth naming one more thing honestly before moving further into diagnosis and proposal: for some Friends, the sense that Bear Creek has grown smaller, older, and more strained is not simply an administrative observation — it carries real grief. A meeting that once filled more pews, staffed more committees without strain, and held a more obviously central place in the lives of more families is, for Friends who remember that earlier season, a loss as well as a fact. This document's proposal should not be read, and should not be presented, as implying that grief is misplaced or that the earlier shape of Bear Creek's life does not deserve to be mourned even while the meeting moves toward something new. Quaker practice has never asked grief to be resolved quickly or set aside in favor of forward motion; it asks that grief be held honestly, in community, alongside whatever comes next. A structural proposal arriving without acknowledging this risks landing as a dismissal of what has been lost, rather than as what it is actually meant to be: an attempt to help what remains — still real, still faithful, still capable of real spiritual depth — carry its own life well, in the shape it has actually become rather than the shape it once was.

The arithmetic of overload

It may help to see the strain documented above in simple numbers, drawn directly from Bear Creek's own roster in Appendix A. Nine named Friends — Jackie, Russ, Stan, Win, Osa, Liz, Nancy, Jeff, and Jennie — currently hold the roughly fifteen formally named role-slots across Bear Creek's committee structure, an average of well over one and a half roles per officeholder, with several Friends carrying three or four at once. Against this, Bear Creek's actively engaged circle — Friends gathering in person most First Days plus the growing list of Friends joining reliably by Zoom — numbers roughly twenty-three to twenty-five people. That means somewhat more than a third of Bear Creek's actively engaged Friends currently hold a formal role, while nearly two-thirds do not hold any — not necessarily because they lack interest, as the early survey signal already suggests, but because the current structure offers them no obvious door in.

This is not a criticism of any individual's level of engagement; many Friends without a formal role contribute in real, if informal, ways already. It is simply an arithmetic fact worth sitting with: the meeting's institutional weight is currently held by well under half its actively engaged members, several of them several times over, while the clear majority remain structurally uninvited into carrying any piece of it. An interest-group model succeeds, in the most literal and measurable sense, if it narrows this gap — if more of that two-thirds come to hold some piece of the meeting's shared work, in whatever small, bounded form suits them, so that the one-third currently carrying everything can set some of it down.

What the early survey signal already suggests

Though the role-interest survey has only just begun circulating, with Jeff Kisling and Nat Case among its first respondents, even this earliest signal is worth noting rather than dismissed as too small to matter. Both of the first two respondents indicated interest in roles beyond what they currently hold — Jeff in Query Response Coordination, correspondence and deadlines, and safe/archive transcription alongside his existing work; Nat Case in Zoom hosting, Query response and discussion leadership, and a "tell me more" flag on both Website support and Presiding Clerk training. Neither response constitutes proof of anything at scale, and this document has been careful throughout not to treat two responses as a dataset. But even this small beginning illustrates exactly the pattern the interest-group model is built to find and use: real, specific willingness, sitting unmatched to any current structural door, waiting only to be asked the right question in the right way. The survey's real value will grow as more Friends respond — and the roadmap in Part XIV treats that growing response, not this document's own guesses, as the actual source for which interest groups Bear Creek names first.

Part IV: Diagnosis — Why the Inherited Structure No Longer Fits

Bear Creek's committee structure, inherited largely intact from a template set out in *Faith and Practice* and built for meetings of a certain size, geography, and historical moment, rests on three assumptions that no longer hold.

The assumption of physical co-presence. The template assumes a meeting whose members live near enough to gather in person, serve on committees that meet in person, and be reached by a Clerk who can simply ask around the room. Bear Creek today is a hybrid meeting with roughly eight to ten Friends gathering at the meetinghouse on a typical First Day and roughly eight connecting by Zoom — a group that includes Friends in Minnesota (Nat Case, Karen Morey, August Kalinosky, and Liz Oppenheimer all live there) as well as Friends like Jeff Kisling who moved back to Iowa but remain substantially engaged by screen rather than by physical presence. An entire worship group — Laughing Waters, meeting at 1:30 p.m. on fourth Sundays — exists entirely online, under Bear Creek's care, with no in-person component at all. A structure that assumes co-presence as the default mode of participation is, for a meeting like this, no longer describing reality; it is describing a smaller and older meeting that Bear Creek has already grown beyond.

The assumption of scarcity of trust. Standing committees, nominating processes, and central approval all encode a quiet assumption: that trust is a scarce resource, carefully allocated through formal appointment, and that untested initiative is risky enough to require a gatekeeper. This assumption made more sense when a meeting's business was conducted entirely in person, where informal accountability was constant and ambient — everyone saw everyone, every week, and reputational accountability did real work that no committee structure needed to formalize. In a hybrid meeting where many Friends interact primarily through screens and occasional gatherings, that ambient accountability is thinner, and a structure built to compensate for its absence by *adding* formal gatekeeping is solving the problem backwards. The right response to thinner ambient trust is not more centralized control; it is a more intentional, explicit practice of the transparency and mutual accountability that used to happen for free.

The assumption of permanence as the default. *Faith and Practice* itself does not actually require every function to be a standing, perpetually reappointed committee — it explicitly allows committees "appointed when need arises... laid down once the need has been met" (p. 55) — but Bear Creek's practice has drifted toward treating permanence as the default anyway, with the exception of Peace and Social Concerns, which has simply stopped being staffed as a standing committee without anyone formally deciding that this should become the new model. The effect is a structure with high fixed costs: every named committee, however small its actual workload

in a given season, carries the overhead of nomination, appointment, and the implicit expectation of continuing to exist whether or not its original need remains active. A meeting that wants its structure to flex with the actual, changing shape of its work needs to make temporariness the default for everything except the handful of roles that genuinely require it — and to stop treating the absence of a standing committee, where Bear Creek has already discovered that absence works, as an oversight to be corrected rather than a pattern to be extended.

What these three assumptions produce, together, is overload concentrated in exactly the wrong places. The Friends most committed to institutional continuity — the Clerk, the Treasurer, the Trustees, the small circle serving on Ministry and Counsel — end up absorbing the cost of a structure built for co-presence, centralized trust, and permanent staffing, because they are the ones who show up most reliably to do it. Meanwhile, the wider circle of Friends who might take up bounded, specific, remote-friendly work — cataloging the safe's contents, tracking correspondence deadlines, hosting Zoom, coordinating Query responses — finds no obvious door into a structure built around standing committees they have never been nominated to and may have no wish to join as a multi-year commitment.

The diagnosis, in short: Bear Creek does not have too few willing people. It has a structure that makes it hard for willing people to find a door sized to what they actually want to offer, while placing nearly everything that does not fit that structure onto the small number of Friends already positioned inside it.

A further word on patience

One tension runs under this entire document and deserves to be named directly in its diagnosis: the strain documented in Part III is real and, left unaddressed, carries real cost — and yet the right response to that urgency is not haste. Quaker discernment has always moved at the pace trust and clarity actually require, not the pace anxiety might prefer, and this document's own staged roadmap in Part XIV is an attempt to honor both truths simultaneously: real urgency about the underlying problem, held alongside real patience about how quickly any single meeting can responsibly change its own settled patterns. A meeting that rushes this transition out of anxiety about the overload documented above risks recreating, in a new form, the very pattern of action preceding adequate discernment that Part VII argues against throughout. The correct pace is neither glacial nor hurried — it is simply as fast as genuine unity can be found, honestly tested at each step, which may in practice feel slower than the urgency of the underlying problem would seem to warrant, and this document asks Bear Creek's Friends to trust that slower, well-tested change is more durable than fast change forced past genuine readiness.

The cost of doing nothing

It is worth naming directly what happens if Bear Creek simply continues as it is, making no structural change and trusting instead that the current handful of Friends will continue to hold what they hold. Two outcomes are realistic, and neither is acceptable on its own terms. The first is that one or more of these Friends eventually reaches a genuine limit — illness, exhaustion, a change in life circumstance, or simply the accumulated weight of years of service — and some piece of the meeting's institutional life quietly fails or lapses at exactly the moment it is needed, because no one else was positioned to catch it. A clerk succession crisis arriving without warning rather than through the gradual, deliberate process this document recommends; a financial record no one but the Treasurer can locate, at precisely the moment it is needed; a State of the Meeting Report rushed or skipped because Ministry and Counsel's attention was elsewhere. The second outcome, quieter but no less real, is that Bear Creek's wider circle of Friends — remote members whose engagement is already thinner than that of Friends gathering in the room, Friends who feel the meeting has drifted from justice work they consider central to their faith — continues to drift further from active participation, not from any decision to leave, but simply because no door ever opened for them, until one day the meeting notices it has become smaller than it needs to be, with no single moment at which that shrinking could be pointed to and addressed.

Neither of these outcomes is inevitable, and naming them is not meant as alarm for its own sake — it is meant to make clear that "doing nothing" is not actually a neutral, risk-free option set against the risks of structural change. It carries its own risks, arguably larger ones, simply distributed more quietly across time rather than concentrated in a single visible decision.

A structure built for a different century

It is worth stepping back once more to notice how old some of the assumptions embedded in Bear Creek's inherited structure actually are. The basic template *Faith and Practice* describes — a Clerk, a Treasurer, a Recorder, standing committees covering the meeting's various functions, a Nominating Committee filling seats annually — reflects organizational assumptions common across nineteenth- and twentieth-century American voluntary associations generally, not only Quaker ones: fraternal societies, church denominations, civic organizations of every kind adopted broadly similar committee-and-office structures during a period when a stable, often-growing, largely co-located membership made that structure both workable and, for its time, genuinely effective. Bear Creek's own structure is, in this light, not a uniquely Quaker invention so much as a particular application of a very widespread organizational form from a particular historical moment — a moment whose basic conditions (growing membership, physical co-presence, a cultural assumption that formal office was the primary legitimate channel for communal responsibility) no longer describe Bear Creek's actual circumstances. This document's proposal,

then, is not a departure from some timeless Quaker essence so much as a return to older and more adaptable Quaker practice — the waiting worship and the task-bound sufferings-meeting pattern described in Part II — after a detour through a specific historical organizational form that served its purpose for a season and, for a meeting Bear Creek's current size and shape, no longer does.

Why committees persist even after they stop fitting

It is worth asking directly why a structure already straining, as Part III documents in concrete detail, has nonetheless persisted largely unchanged — not because Bear Creek's Friends lack the wisdom to see the strain, many clearly do, but because committee structures carry a particular kind of institutional inertia worth naming. A standing committee, once established, becomes part of how a meeting understands its own shape; dissolving or restructuring it can feel, even when no one intends this meaning, like a judgment on the Friends who have served it faithfully, or like an admission that something has been lost rather than simply changed. This document has tried throughout — in Part III's grace for the transition, in the committee-by-committee review in Part VI, in the FAQ's direct engagement with hesitation — to separate those two things clearly: restructuring a committee is not a verdict on the Friends who served it, any more than the 1916 move of the meetinghouse itself was a verdict on the Friends who had worshipped in its earlier location. Structures can change while the service rendered through them remains honored, and this document asks Bear Creek to hold both at once rather than letting inertia masquerade as faithfulness to what has already quietly stopped working as well as it once did.

Bear Creek's situation in a wider context

Bear Creek is not unusual in facing this strain, and it may be a source of some comfort, as well as useful perspective, to recognize that the pattern documented here — a small, faithful core carrying institutional weight built for a larger and more co-located community, a geographically dispersed membership connecting increasingly by Zoom rather than in person, a committee structure inherited from an earlier era straining under current conditions — is common across small rural meetings throughout Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) and across unprogrammed Quaker practice more broadly. This is addressed more fully in Part XIII, but it bears mentioning here as part of the diagnosis itself: Bear Creek's strain is not a sign of particular failure or decline unique to this meeting. It is what happens, predictably and almost mechanically, when a structure built for one set of conditions persists past the point where those conditions still hold. The remedy, correspondingly, is not for Bear Creek's Friends to try harder within the existing structure — many already are, visibly, at real personal cost — but for the structure itself to change to fit the meeting Bear Creek has actually become.

Part V: Mutual Aid as Practice, Not Metaphor

It would be easy for "mutual aid" to function in this document as a pleasant-sounding synonym for "being nicer to each other" — a mood rather than a method. It is worth being specific about what mutual aid actually means, because the specificity is where its real difference from charity, and from committee-based institutional care, becomes visible.

For three years, every Saturday morning, Jeff gathered with about fifteen volunteers in a church basement in inner-city Des Moines, packing boxes of donated food for roughly sixty families, through Des Moines Mutual Aid — an ongoing program with roots going back to a free food giveaway begun by the Des Moines Black Panther Party in the late 1960s, and that Jeff came to through his relationship with its organizer, Ronnie James, after the two met in 2017 at a vigil in solidarity with the Wet'suwet'en people's struggle to stop a pipeline through their territory. Two features of that work are directly relevant here, and neither is incidental.

First: there were no requirements to qualify. No application, no means test, no committee determining worthiness. Food simply moved from those who had it to those who needed it, on the trust that need itself was sufficient grounds for aid. This is the single clearest difference between mutual aid and charity as institutions typically practice it. Charity routes resources through a gatekeeping structure that verifies need before releasing help; mutual aid moves resources on the assumption that need, honestly stated, is enough.

Second: a lesson someone had to point out to Jeff directly — that he wasn't actually acting as part of the community unless he also took some of the donated food himself. This is the deeper and more uncomfortable half of the lesson. Mutual aid is not one group's resources moving charitably toward another group's need; it is a shared circulation in which the line between giver and receiver dissolves, because everyone involved is understood to be part of the same community of need and capacity. Once Jeff began taking food himself, the structure of the work changed from "volunteers serving a population" to "neighbors sharing what they have" — a shift in posture, not just in logistics.

Translated into Bear Creek's own life, both features matter enormously for the finance proposal in Part IX. A mutual aid model of meeting finances does not ask an interest group facing an urgent need to first prove its worthiness to a Finance Committee or a Treasurer before funds are released; it builds a structure in which funds are available on the trust that a stated need, from a Friend or an interest group acting in good faith within the meeting's own life, is sufficient grounds to act. And it does not frame memorial gifts or larger resources as belonging to "the meeting" in some abstracted, institutional sense that interest groups must petition; it treats those resources

the way Des Moines Mutual Aid treated donated food — as a shared circulation belonging, in a real sense, to everyone who is part of the community, available to be drawn on by whoever has the need and the leading to act.

This is also where Jeff's connection to the Great Plains Action Society's Urban Resilience Hub becomes relevant to Bear Creek's own transformation, beyond the personal relationship it represents. GPAS is an Indigenous-led organization building a hub on Maiden Lane in Iowa City organized around land sovereignty and place-based belonging — organizing principles that sit close to Quaker testimony on simplicity and community, even though they come from a different tradition and a different history. The Decolonial Repair Network, created by Sikowis Nobiss and Eric Anglada to support GPAS, and on whose planning committee Jeff now sits, works from a related premise: that repair and resilience are built through direct, trust-based relationship and shared material resources, not through institutions mediating aid from a position of authority over the people receiving it. Bear Creek does not need to import GPAS's specific organizing model wholesale — it is a different kind of body, serving a different purpose, grounded in a different community's history and sovereignty. But the underlying posture — resources circulating on trust, relationship prior to procedure, aid without gatekeeping — is one Bear Creek can recognize as consonant with its own testimonies, articulated independently through a tradition its own members, including Jeff, have come to know and learn from directly.

What mutual aid is not. It is worth naming, briefly, what this document is *not* proposing, because the word "mutual aid" sometimes gets stretched to cover anything cooperative. This document does not propose that Bear Creek abandon discernment, abandon record-keeping, or abandon the distinction between a Friend's personal initiative and the meeting's considered sense on a matter of real weight. Mutual aid, as practiced at Des Moines Mutual Aid and as proposed here, is disciplined, not improvised: there were real volunteers showing up every Saturday, real food moving through real hands, real relationships of accountability built over years, Ronnie James's real and ongoing leadership. What mutual aid removes is the *gatekeeping* layer — the verification-before-aid, the approval-before-action — not the *relationship and accountability* layer, which if anything mutual aid asks a community to deepen, because without a gatekeeper checking the paperwork, a community has to actually know and trust each other instead.

A second lived example: eight days walking

Des Moines Mutual Aid is not the only direct experience available to draw on here. In September 2018, a small group of Native and non-Native people walked ninety-four miles along the path of the Dakota Access Pipeline, from Des Moines to Fort Dodge, Iowa, over eight days, in what became known as the First Nation-Farmer Climate Unity March. The purpose of those eight days

was not primarily to arrive anywhere, or to accomplish a discrete task with a measurable outcome. It was to spend eight full days walking together, sharing stories, so that people who began the walk as strangers — divided by history, by land, by the very different ways Native and non-Native communities in Iowa have related to that land — could come to work on matters of common concern from a foundation of actual relationship rather than abstract alliance. That foundation, once built, did not evaporate when the walk ended; various combinations of the people who walked those ninety-four miles together have continued working on shared concerns in the years since.

This offers a second, complementary lesson for Bear Creek's own transition, distinct from but consonant with the Des Moines Mutual Aid experience. Trust, the currency this entire document asks Bear Creek to extend more freely, is not simply declared into existence by adopting a new structure. It is built the way those eight days built it: through sustained, unhurried, shared presence — walking together, literally or figuratively, long enough that abstract goodwill becomes actual knowledge of who another person is and how they can be relied upon. The interest-group model this document proposes will work only to the degree Bear Creek's Friends actually know and trust one another — which means the model's success depends not only on the structural changes proposed here, but on the meeting continuing to find ways, large and small, to walk together: shared meals, shared work on the archive project or the water testing, the ordinary accumulated presence of showing up for one another across seasons. Structure can make room for trust; it cannot manufacture the trust itself. That remains the slower, relational work it has always been.

What the United Panther Party's educational work adds to this picture

Jeff's relationship with the Black Panther Party's history and present work, formed through meeting Ronnie James and continuing through communication with the United Panther Party's current educational efforts, offers one further thread worth naming here, alongside Des Moines Mutual Aid itself. The Black Panther Party's own free breakfast and survival programs — the direct historical root of the food giveaway that became Des Moines Mutual Aid — were themselves built on a conviction close to this document's own argument in Part V: that a community's survival and dignity depend on resources moving according to need, organized by the community itself rather than administered by distant institutions, charitable or governmental, that the community does not control. This history matters for Bear Creek not as a program to imitate wholesale — Bear Creek is a different kind of community, facing different circumstances, with its own three-century tradition to draw on instead — but as a further, concrete demonstration that the posture this document asks Bear Creek to adopt has been lived out seriously, at real cost and with real success, by communities who needed it to work, not

merely theorized about by communities for whom it remained optional. Jeff's own continuing engagement with the United Panther Party's educational work, and his interest in sharing what he learns through the Channels Into Knowledge project, is one more thread connecting Bear Creek's own proposed transformation to a wider, deeper, lived tradition of community self-organization around mutual need — a tradition this document is grateful to draw on rather than claiming to originate.

What charity gets wrong, concretely

It may help to be even more specific about the contrast between mutual aid and charity this part has drawn, since the two are easily confused in casual conversation. A charitable model, even a well-intentioned one, tends to structurally separate the giver from the receiver: a committee decides who qualifies, a form is filled out, an application is reviewed, aid flows downward from those with more to those with less, and the relationship, however kind, remains asymmetrical. This asymmetry is not merely a matter of tone — it shapes who feels entitled to ask for help and who does not. A Friend facing hardship inside a charitable structure must first position themselves as a supplicant, however gently the process is administered, before aid becomes available; many genuinely needy people, including within small, close communities like Bear Creek, will simply not do this, out of pride, shame, or a reasonable wish not to be seen as a case to be processed.

Mutual aid, as Jeff experienced it with Des Moines Mutual Aid, structurally refuses this asymmetry. No one filled out a form to receive food in that church basement. Need was simply stated, or sometimes not even stated explicitly — simply present and recognized — and aid moved. This document's finance proposal in Part IX is built specifically to recreate this structural refusal within Bear Creek's own life: a Friend facing hardship should be able to reach the Finance interest group's urgent-need channel the same way they would ask a close friend for help, not the way they would apply to an institution for a grant. This is a harder thing to build than it sounds, because institutional habits of verification run deep even among well-meaning people, and this document asks Bear Creek's Finance interest group to actively resist the pull toward recreating charity's asymmetry even while doing the genuinely necessary work of responsible stewardship.

A theological note on what "to each according to need" has in common with Quaker simplicity

The phrase most associated with mutual aid in its broader political usage — resources moving according to need rather than according to merit, contribution, or hierarchy — can sound, to ears attuned mainly to its more recent political history, like language imported from outside the

Quaker tradition. It is worth noting that it is not. Quaker simplicity has always carried within it a suspicion of exactly the kind of accounting mutual aid refuses: the idea that aid must be earned, that help should be proportioned to desert, that a community's resources should be husbanded carefully against the claims of those who have not yet proven themselves worthy of them. Early Friends' practice of holding goods loosely, caring for meeting members in real material need without means-testing that care, and treating the community's resources as genuinely shared rather than individually hoarded, sits far closer to the mutual aid ethic described in this part than to a transactional model of charity. Bear Creek does not need to borrow this ethic from a secular political tradition in order to make it its own; it can recognize, in Jeff's own experience with Ronnie James and Des Moines Mutual Aid, a contemporary expression of something Quaker practice has carried, under different names, for more than three centuries.

Part VI: The Interest Group Model

This is the structural center of the document: the proposal that Bear Creek replace most of its standing-committee architecture with a looser, more flexible structure of **interest groups** — and the case, developed below, that this is less an innovation imported from outside than a pattern already present and working inside Bear Creek's own recent history, simply not yet named, generalized, or fully trusted.

What already exists. Three pieces of Bear Creek's current practice are, in effect, interest groups already, whether or not they have been called that.

Peace and Social Concerns has no standing committee today. Its business happens "as the meeting as a whole," through reports made directly at business meeting rather than routed through a clerked committee structure. This is, by the definition this document is building toward, an interest-group pattern: whoever is moved to bring a peace or justice concern to the meeting simply brings it, without first needing to be nominated to a body that exists to receive it.

Laughing Waters Friends Worship Group, the virtual-only worship group meeting on fourth Sundays, functions entirely under Bear Creek's care with Nat Case as contact — a single named point of relationship rather than a committee staffing structure. It works. Friends gather, worship happens, the relationship to Bear Creek is maintained, and none of this required building Laughing Waters its own Clerk, Treasurer, and set of standing committees in miniature.

Co-clerking, as practiced historically by Jeff Kisling and Jenny Cisar, demonstrates that even a role widely assumed to require a single, continuous office-holder — the Clerk — can be shared between two Friends without the meeting's business suffering for it. This matters directly for Part VI's recommendation that even the continuity-critical roles can be structured for shared, rather than solitary, carrying.

And at the Yearly Meeting level, the precedent is explicit and recent: when Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) needed a new Clerk, it did not stand up a permanent search apparatus. It formed an **Ad Hoc Clerk Search Committee**, which found Deborah Dakin and then, its purpose fulfilled, dissolved. A defined task, a defined group, a defined ending. This is the interest-group pattern in miniature, already practiced by the body Bear Creek itself answers to.

The model, generalized. An interest group is a gathering of Friends — as few as one, as many as the task calls for — organized around a specific, nameable piece of work, rather than around a permanent office. It differs from a standing committee in several concrete ways:

- *It is named for what it does, not for a title it holds.* "The Friends helping catalog the safe" rather than "the Archives Committee." This is not merely a matter of tone; it changes who feels invited in. A title implies an institution one must be nominated into; a description of work implies a door anyone moved by the work can walk through. Bear Creek has already taken a small step in exactly this direction by renaming "Religious Education and Spiritual Development" to "Religious Education / Spiritual Enrichment" — a name that describes activity rather than office.
- *It forms when a need or a leading appears, and dissolves when the work is done.* No interest group needs to seek standing appointment through a Nominating Committee unless its work genuinely requires multi-year continuity. The transcription of the safe's contents, the coordination of Query responses, the tracking of correspondence deadlines — all of these can simply begin, carried out by "Friends who are doing this right now," named informally in the minutes, without implying an ongoing commitment beyond the task's natural life.
- *It reports to the whole meeting, rather than up through a hierarchy.* Where a standing committee's report traditionally passes through channels that assume the Clerk's oversight of "the condition of the meeting" as a kind of umbrella accountability, an interest group's natural accountability is horizontal: it tells the gathered meeting what it is doing, as Peace and Social Concerns already does, and the gathered meeting's discernment — not a single officer's sign-off — is what tests whether the work is rightly held.
- *It can overlap, multiply, and recombine freely.* A Friend can be part of several interest groups at once, or none, without this implying the kind of role-stacking currently visible in Bear Creek's committee rosters (Jackie carrying four roles; Russ carrying three), because interest-group participation is not an appointment with an implied multi-year term — it is simply doing a piece of work for as long as one is moved to do it, and stepping back without ceremony when one is not.

What remains named, and why. Four roles cannot responsibly be dissolved into the interest-group model, because they carry a kind of continuity the model is not built to provide: **Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, and Trustees.** These roles exist at the intersection of spiritual discernment, legal responsibility, and institutional memory that spans beyond any single task's natural life. The Clerk holds responsibility for discerning the sense of the meeting across the whole arc of its business, not just one agenda item. The Treasurer and Trustees carry legal and fiduciary obligations under Iowa law that genuinely require a continuously identifiable, accountable person or persons. The Recorder maintains membership records that must remain continuous and accurate across decades, not task-cycles.

But "named" does not have to mean "solitary." This document recommends, consistent with Bear Creek's own co-clerking precedent and with *Faith and Practice*'s own template of Clerk-plus-Assistant/Recording-Clerk, that each of these four continuity roles be *structured for sharing* even

as they remain formally named: a Clerk and an Assistant or Recording Clerk, rather than a Clerk alone; a Treasurer and an Assistant Treasurer who genuinely knows where the records and accounts are, rather than a Treasurer alone. This single change — filling the gaps *Faith and Practice* itself anticipates but Bear Creek currently leaves open — would do more to relieve the overload documented in Part III than almost any other single step available to the meeting, and it can be done immediately, inside the existing structure, without waiting for anything else in this document to be adopted.

A worked example: the clerk-succession question itself. Bear Creek's own clerk-burden brainstorming document already proposes exactly this model as a solution to its own starting problem, and it is worth holding up as a template for how future transitions should be handled. Rather than treating "find a new Clerk" as requiring a standing Nominating Committee process in the traditional sense, it proposes a small, explicitly time-boxed group of two or three Friends — drawn from across the meeting, including its remote members — whose only task is to (1) propose how the Clerk's role might be split along the lines of Presiding Clerk, Recording Clerk, and a correspondence/calendar function, and (2) draft a short list of remote-friendly tasks so Friends can self-select rather than waiting to be asked. That group reports back, and lays itself down. This is, simultaneously, a solution to an urgent practical need and a demonstration, in miniature, of the entire model this document proposes — proof by doing, rather than proof by argument.

How interest groups relate to one another

A meeting with several active interest groups at once needs some account of how they relate to each other, not only to the whole meeting — otherwise overlap, duplication, or quiet conflict can arise exactly where the model is meant to prevent the bottlenecks of the old structure from simply reappearing in a new form.

The guiding principle is the same one running through this entire document: relationship and transparency, not hierarchy. Interest groups do not report to one another or require one another's approval. But the shared communication network described in Part VIII makes every group's work visible to every other, which means overlap is usually caught early and handled through ordinary conversation rather than becoming a structural problem. If, for instance, both a newly forming "Friends interested in peace and justice work" group and the existing Outreach work Jeff and Jennie carry find themselves drawn toward the same piece of advocacy, the natural next step is simply a conversation between the Friends involved — not a jurisdictional dispute requiring a third party to resolve, because neither group holds authority over the other to begin with.

Where two interest groups' work genuinely depends on each other — the safe-cataloguing group needing House and Grounds' help to access the meetinghouse at the right times, say, or the water-resilience group needing Finance's help to fund testing — the relationship is one of partnership, worked out directly between the Friends involved, in the same spirit of mutual trust this document asks for everywhere else. No interest group needs permission from another to begin its work; good working relationships between them are built the same way trust is built throughout this document — through direct relationship and honest communication, not through a formal coordinating structure layered on top.

What happens when an interest group's judgment seems mistaken

This deserves direct treatment, because it is the question most likely to arise as soon as this model moves from paper to practice. Suppose an interest group — in good faith, without any wrongdoing — makes a decision that a number of Friends come to feel was simply a poor judgment call: money spent in a way that, in hindsight, wasn't the wisest use of a memorial gift; an approach to the archive project that damaged a document rather than preserving it; outreach language that unintentionally caused offense. Part VII already addresses outright harm or misuse of trust. This is a gentler, more common case: honest human error, not betrayal.

The answer here is the same one Quaker process has always applied to honest error within a gathered community: it is named directly, in love, through the ordinary channels of transparency this document builds throughout — raised at business meeting, or directly with the Friends involved, as a concern rather than an accusation. The interest group is given the chance to hear the concern, reflect on it, and adjust — exactly as any Friend's individual leading is tested and, sometimes, found in need of correction through the gathered meeting's discernment. No formal disciplinary mechanism needs to exist above and beyond this ordinary Quaker practice of loving correction, because building one would recreate, for the case of honest error, the very gatekeeping apparatus this document has argued against for the case of ordinary initiative. A meeting that can hold vocal ministry accountable without a formal review board can hold an interest group's honest misjudgment accountable the same way.

A committee-by-committee look at what this could mean

Principle is easier to accept than specifics, and this document has tried throughout to ground its claims in Bear Creek's own particulars rather than leaving the model abstract. It is worth, then, walking through Bear Creek's current committee roster, named in full in Appendix A, and considering honestly what this model might mean for each — not as a fixed prescription, but as a starting point for the meeting's own discernment about where interest-group flexibility fits naturally and where more continuity is genuinely warranted.

Clerk and Assistant/Recording Clerk. Remains named, as Part VI already establishes, with the specific recommendation that it finally be filled as a pair rather than carried by Jackie alone — the single highest-leverage structural change available to Bear Creek, achievable immediately and independent of everything else in this document.

Treasurer and Assistant Treasurer. The same logic applies, with Osa's current solitary responsibility relieved by a named Assistant Treasurer, consistent with Part IX's finance proposal.

Recorder. This role's narrow, continuous, record-keeping function — tracking membership, admissions, releases, births, and deaths for report to the Yearly Meeting's statistical recorder — genuinely benefits from a single continuously accountable Friend, as Win Standing currently provides, and this document does not recommend dissolving it into an interest group. It could, however, benefit from the same backup principle applied to Clerk and Treasurer: a second Friend who knows the records' location and format well enough to step in if needed.

House and Grounds. Property maintenance has enough ongoing, physical, location-specific responsibility that some continuity of a small core group — Russ and Stan currently — makes practical sense. But specific House and Grounds projects, like the water-quality work described in Part XI, can and should spin off into their own bounded interest groups, relieving House and Grounds of needing to be the default owner of every property-adjacent idea that arises, the way the water-quality worked example in Part VII already illustrates.

Ministry and Counsel. This committee's core function — fostering the meeting's spiritual life, pastoral care, oversight of Quaker process, and authorship of the State of the Meeting Report — touches exactly the kind of spiritual discernment this document has argued should remain a matter of careful, experienced attention rather than open-ended interest-group flexibility. This document recommends Ministry and Counsel remain substantially as it is, while welcoming the kind of interest-group support described in Part XII for gathering wider input toward its reports.

Religious Education / Spiritual Enrichment. Already renamed in a direction consonant with this document's own logic — naming activity rather than holding a fixed title — and well suited to interest-group flexibility: specific programming ideas, like a particular curriculum or a specific enrichment offering, can form, run, and conclude as bounded projects, with Liz and Jackie's ongoing involvement continuing wherever their own leading draws them rather than by default assignment. A **music interest group** is worth naming explicitly as one shape this could take — Friends drawn to singing before worship, building a simple shared songbook for hybrid use (words visible to Friends on Zoom as easily as to those in the room), or bringing music into Midyear Meeting hosting or a Prairie Awakening gathering. This kind of interest group deserves a place in this document for its own sake, not only as an offshoot of Religious Education: not

every interest group needs to answer an overloaded Friend's burden or a looming structural gap. Some simply make the meeting's shared life fuller and more joyful, and a music interest group is a clear example of exactly that — a reminder that this whole model exists not only to solve problems but to make room for the gifts Friends are already glad to offer.

Funeral and Memorial. This work carries real pastoral weight and benefits from Friends who have done it before and hold the accumulated sensitivity it requires — Win, Jackie, Jenny, and Nancy currently. This document does not recommend dissolving this into an ad hoc interest group precisely because death and grief are not well served by novelty; continuity of care matters here in a way it does not for, say, cataloguing a safe. A lighter touch is still possible, though: specific logistical tasks within a memorial service's planning could be shared more widely without touching the pastoral core.

It is worth noting, too, the quiet connection between this committee's work and the finance proposal in Part IX: memorial gifts, which this committee's work often occasions, become under this document's proposal a genuinely shared resource circulating through the meeting's mutual aid life rather than funds held separately and awaiting a sufficiently momentous use. Funeral and Memorial's pastoral work and the Finance interest group's stewardship work are, in this sense, two ends of the same process — one tending to a family's grief, the other tending faithfully to what that family's generosity makes possible for the wider community in the years that follow.

Library / Historian-Archivist. Nancy's role here is already, in practice, closer to the interest-group model than to a standing committee — a single Friend's sustained personal leading, pursued because she is drawn to it, not because she was appointed to a seat that would otherwise sit empty. The archive project in Part X is this same pattern, deliberately expanded to include more hands.

Trustees. Legal and corporate responsibility for property genuinely requires named, continuously accountable Friends under Iowa law — Osa and Russ currently — and this document does not recommend changing that. What can change is everything *adjacent* to Trustee responsibility that does not itself require legal standing: specific property projects, as House and Grounds already illustrates, can flex into interest groups even while ultimate legal responsibility stays fixed.

A further note belongs here specifically: this document is not a legal document, and nothing in it should be taken as legal advice about Iowa nonprofit or religious-organization law. Where this proposal touches genuine legal questions — the precise boundaries of Trustee liability, how a delegated digital payment mechanism should be structured to protect both the Trustees and the Friends given access to it, whether any aspect of this model requires formal documentation beyond the meeting's own minutes — this document recommends Bear Creek's Trustees seek

appropriate guidance, whether from Iowa Yearly Meeting's own Trustees, who may have relevant experience across multiple monthly meetings, or from legal counsel if the amounts or complexity involved warrant it. This document has tried to design around legal risk sensibly, but it is offered as a starting framework for the meeting's own discernment, not as a substitute for proper legal review of its financial mechanisms before they are formally adopted.

Outreach and Website. Already, in substance, an interest-group-style arrangement carried informally by Jeff and Jennie rather than a heavily structured standing committee — this document simply recommends naming it as such explicitly and actively inviting more hands, particularly remote Friends drawn to writing, web maintenance, or communications work, exactly the kind of task the survey is already surfacing interest in.

Hospitality. Midyear Meeting hosting, discussed in Part XII, benefits from the accumulated knowledge Jackie and Win currently hold, and this document recommends it continue substantially as is for now, while remaining open to the same gradual loosening other roles may undergo as the model matures and more Friends grow comfortable stepping into less familiar logistical work.

Nominating Committee. Reconstituted periodically rather than standing continuously, Bear Creek's own Nominating Committee has, in its own past reports, already raised a question strikingly close to this document's own central concern: whether each committee's responsibilities should be spelled out in writing, a question that went unresolved as of the last report available to this document. This document's answer is, in effect, yes — and goes further, proposing that much of what the Nominating Committee has historically existed to do (filling committee seats) shrinks considerably once most of the meeting's work no longer requires standing appointment. What remains for a Nominating Committee under this model is narrower and arguably more important: filling the small number of genuine continuity roles — Clerk, Assistant Clerk, Treasurer, Assistant Treasurer, Recorder, Trustees — with real discernment about fit and calling, rather than the broader task of staffing a dozen standing committees each year. This is lighter work, done less often, and arguably done better for the narrower focus.

Peace and Social Concerns. Already operating, today, exactly as this document recommends generalizing — no standing committee, work surfacing as leadings arise, reported directly to the meeting as a whole. This document's primary recommendation here is simply to notice, name, and trust this pattern explicitly, rather than quietly regarding its lack of a standing committee as an unaddressed gap waiting to be filled with a return to the old structure.

Safe / historical records. Addressed fully in Part X — the clearest case of an entirely new interest group filling a genuine gap *Faith and Practice* itself anticipates but Bear Creek has not yet staffed.

A day in the life, before and after

To make the cumulative effect of these changes concrete rather than abstract, it may help to imagine two ordinary weeks in Bear Creek's life — one under the current structure, one some months into living with this model — focused on Jackie's experience as Clerk, since her load is the most visible single illustration of what this document is trying to address.

Before. On a typical week, Jackie might field a question about Hospitality's handling of an upcoming visitor, draft the agenda for the next business meeting, follow up on a Religious Education planning detail with Liz, check in on a family connected to the Funeral and Memorial Committee, and — because there is no Assistant Clerk — personally track two or three looming IYM(C) deadlines in the back of her mind alongside everything else, with no one else positioned to notice if she is too stretched to catch one.

After. In the same week, under this model, an Assistant or Recording Clerk — perhaps a remote Friend drawn to exactly this kind of work — has already drafted the business meeting agenda from interest-group updates already visible in the shared communication space, leaving Jackie to review rather than compile it from scratch. The Hospitality question is handled directly by Win and whichever Friends are part of that work, without needing to route through Jackie first. The Religious Education planning detail surfaces through the shared document, where Jackie can see it without needing to personally hold it in mind. The Funeral and Memorial Committee handles its own pastoral follow-up, informed by Ministry and Counsel where appropriate, without requiring Jackie's personal coordination. The looming IYM(C) deadlines are tracked by the correspondence/deadline interest-group role described in Part XII, which flags them well ahead of time rather than depending on Jackie's own memory under load.

What has not changed: Jackie remains Clerk, still responsible for discerning the sense of the meeting at business meeting, still the Friend whose faithfulness and judgment the meeting continues to rely on for its central spiritual-administrative function. What has changed is everything surrounding that core responsibility — the dozen smaller threads that used to all run through her attention by default now running through a wider, more distributed network, leaving her actual clerking work, the part that most needs her specific gifts, with room to be done well rather than squeezed between everything else.

Part VII: Replacing Approval with Trust

If Part VI describes the shape of the model, this part addresses its hardest practical question: once central approval is removed as the mechanism holding the meeting's work accountable, what actually takes its place? "Faith in each other" cannot be allowed to mean "no accountability at all" — that would not be mutual aid, it would simply be abdication, and it would not survive contact with a single instance of real harm or real financial loss. The honest answer has several parts, and all of them are already present in Quaker practice; none needs to be invented.

Transparency replaces gatekeeping. The core substitution this document proposes is: instead of asking permission before acting, an interest group acts and *tells* — promptly, honestly, and in a form the whole meeting can see. This is a real difference in sequencing, not a weakening of accountability. A Finance interest group that releases emergency memorial funds to a family in need on a Tuesday and reports what it did and why at the next opportunity — whether that is the next business meeting, a shared document, or an email to the meeting list — has been just as accountable as one that sought advance approval, and considerably more useful to the family that needed help on Tuesday rather than on the third First Day of next month. The discipline shifts from *asking* to *telling*, but the discipline remains real, and in some ways becomes sharper: there is no committee process to hide behind if a report is late or a decision looks poorly made in hindsight. The interest group's own integrity is visibly on the line every time, in front of the whole meeting, rather than diffused through a committee's collective responsibility.

The gathered meeting remains the final test of discernment, exactly as it always has been. Nothing in this model proposes that the meeting as a whole loses its traditional authority to raise a concern, ask a question, or — in a genuinely serious case — ask an interest group to pause or reconsider. What changes is *when* that testing happens: not as a precondition for action, but as the ordinary, ongoing oversight a worshipping community always exercises over its own life. This is, if anything, closer to historic Quaker process than the committee-approval model it replaces. Early Friends did not generally operate through standing committees with veto power over individual action; they operated through a gathered community continuously testing the leadings of its members against the Light they held in common.

Record-keeping and honest reporting become more important, not less. A structure that relies on transparency rather than gatekeeping has one real vulnerability: it only works if the transparency is actually practiced. This document's recommendations in Part VIII (communication) and Part IX (finance) are built specifically to make reporting-out easy, habitual, and visible — not an extra burden layered onto interest groups' actual work, but a lightweight, expected part of how any interest group operates from the start. A shared, simple record of what

each interest group is doing and what resources it has drawn on, visible to the whole meeting, does the accountability work that approval used to do, without recreating the bottleneck that made approval unsustainable in the first place.

Spiritual accountability remains the deepest layer, and it is not new. Underneath the practical mechanisms above is the older Quaker discipline this document has been pointing toward throughout: that a Friend or a small gathered group acting under a genuine leading is answerable, first, to the Light itself, tested in community — and that this kind of accountability, taken seriously, is not less rigorous than institutional approval but differently rigorous. It asks a Friend to search their own motives honestly, rather than simply satisfying a committee's checklist. A meeting that wants to build real mutual aid has to be willing to trust that this older form of accountability, practiced with the same seriousness Friends have always brought to clearness committees and to meeting for worship with attention to business, can hold real weight — because historically, it always has.

What happens when trust is broken. This document would be incomplete, and dishonest, if it did not address the question directly: what happens if an interest group — or a Friend within one — acts in a way that genuinely harms the meeting, misuses funds, or exceeds what good faith can stretch to cover? The answer is not that mutual aid has no answer. It is that the answer already exists in Quaker process, and does not require resurrecting central approval to apply: the gathered meeting, through its ordinary discernment, can and should name harm directly when it occurs, hold the Friends involved accountable through the same loving and exacting process Quakers have always used to address conduct inconsistent with the meeting's testimonies, and adjust — for that interest group, or in rare cases more broadly — the degree of trust extended going forward. Mutual aid is not naive about human failure; it simply refuses to organize its everyday operation around the *assumption* of failure, which is what constant gatekeeping does. Trust extended and occasionally disappointed, then repaired through honest community process, is the normal cost of building a structure around faith in each other. It is a cost this document believes Bear Creek can bear, and one considerably smaller than the cost — documented in Part III — of the overload its current structure already imposes on the handful of Friends trying to hold everything together alone.

A worked example: two interest groups, one honest disagreement

Suppose, further along in this model's life, the water-resilience group and the Finance interest group disagree honestly about timing — the water group believing a larger filtration investment is needed soon, the Finance group, looking at the whole meeting's financial picture including the apportionment obligation and the standing reserve described in Part IX, believing the timing

should wait another season. Neither group holds authority over the other, and this is exactly the kind of moment this document's model is built to handle without an escalation procedure. The two groups simply talk directly, bringing their full reasoning to each other rather than past each other — the water group explaining why the need feels pressing, the Finance group explaining the fuller financial picture the water group may not have in view. If they reach agreement between themselves, the matter is settled without ever needing to involve the wider meeting. If they do not, the question belongs, as any genuine disagreement of real weight does, to the gathered meeting's own discernment at business meeting — not because either group failed, but because this is precisely the kind of question meeting for business exists to hold: real difference, tested together, until the meeting's own sense of the right way forward becomes clear. This is not a flaw in the model surfacing; it is the model working exactly as intended, using the gathered meeting's discernment for the matters that actually need it, while keeping the great majority of Bear Creek's ordinary work moving without ever requiring that heavier process at all.

A worked example: a disagreement handled well

Principle is clearer with a concrete case. Suppose the music interest group, acting in good faith, chooses a set of songs for an upcoming Midyear Meeting gathering that a few visiting Friends from another meeting find unexpectedly unfamiliar or out of step with their own worship tradition — a minor matter in the scheme of things, but a real one, and the kind of small friction any community doing visible work together will eventually encounter. Under the inherited structure, this kind of concern might have nowhere obvious to land, or might surface only as quiet grumbling that never reaches the Friends who could actually respond to it. Under this model, a Friend who heard the concern simply names it, directly and kindly, to the music group or in the shared communication space — not as a formal grievance requiring a committee hearing, but as the kind of honest, low-stakes feedback any interest group should expect and welcome as part of its ordinary life. The music group hears it, perhaps feels a little stung in the moment as anyone does when their work draws criticism, and adjusts its approach for next time, or explains its reasoning if it still believes its choice was right, trusting the conversation itself — not a verdict handed down from above — to settle the matter. Nothing about this requires Jackie's involvement, a formal minute, or any mechanism heavier than two Friends talking honestly with each other, exactly as Quaker community has always expected its members to be able to do.

Clearness committees as machinery already built for this

Quaker practice already possesses a tool precisely suited to testing an individual Friend's leading before it becomes action, without that testing becoming gatekeeping in the sense this document

rejects: the clearness committee. Traditionally gathered when a Friend faces a significant decision or discernment — marriage, a major life change, a weighty concern they feel called to act on — a clearness committee does not approve or deny; it listens, asks honest and searching questions, and helps the Friend hear their own leading more clearly, trusting the Friend themselves to carry out whatever the clearness process reveals.

This document recommends this same tool, lightly and informally applied, as a natural resource for a Friend or small group discerning whether to begin a new interest group, especially one touching a weightier matter — a significant expenditure, a leading toward justice work that might prove controversial, a major shift in how an existing function like Hospitality or House and Grounds operates. A Friend uncertain whether a leading is rightly theirs to act on does not need to seek a committee's permission; they can, in the oldest Quaker fashion, seek a clearness committee's company — two or three trusted Friends willing to sit with the question, not to grant or withhold approval, but to help discernment happen rightly. This is support, not gatekeeping, and it is worth naming explicitly as an available resource throughout this document's proposal, because Friends accustomed to seeking approval before acting may otherwise feel structurally unmoored by its absence, when in fact Quaker practice already offers something better suited to genuine discernment than approval ever was.

A worked example: how a new interest group actually begins

Theory is easier to accept than practice, so it is worth walking through, start to finish, how this is meant to work in an ordinary week at Bear Creek.

Suppose August Kalinosky, joining by Zoom from Minnesota, finds himself thinking about the meetinghouse's well water — a subject he has some professional familiarity with — after reading House and Grounds' 2022 report mentioning water quality and filtration as an open concern. Under the inherited structure, August's options are limited: raise it at business meeting and hope it is referred to House and Grounds, who are already stretched across property upkeep generally; or let the thought pass, since he is not on that committee and has no obvious door into the work.

Under the interest-group model, August's path is different. He mentions the thought to Russ or Stan, or simply to the meeting's communication channel (Part VIII describes this in detail): "I've been thinking about the well water situation — I'd like to look into it and see what a real assessment would involve." No nomination is needed. No committee seat is required. If one or two other Friends are drawn to join him — perhaps Osa, perhaps a remote Friend with a related interest — a small interest group has formed: "Friends looking into the meetinghouse's water quality and resilience." It reports its existence briefly at the next business meeting, not for approval but so the meeting knows it is happening and can offer what it knows. House and

Grounds, rather than losing authority, gains a partner: a bounded, energized group taking on a piece of its work that might otherwise have sat unaddressed for another several years.

If the group needs funds — for water testing, say — it approaches the Finance interest group described in Part IX, which asks what is needed and releases it, trusting August's account of the need rather than first convening a review. If the group's work surfaces something serious — contamination, a failing well — that finding is reported openly, and the whole meeting's discernment, not a single committee's authority, decides what weight it carries and what should follow. When the assessment is done and a plan is in place, the group can simply conclude, hand its findings to House and Grounds or to whatever ongoing interest group picks up implementation, and dissolve — or continue, if its members remain drawn to the work, with no obligation either way.

This is the entire model, in miniature: a leading, named; a small group, gathered; transparency, not approval; funds available on trust; dissolution without ceremony when the work is done. Everything in the parts that follow is this same pattern, applied to communication, money, history, resilience, and the meeting's continuing life with Iowa Yearly Meeting.

Part VIII: A Responsive Communication Network

An interest-group structure lives or dies on communication. Remove central approval as the mechanism holding the meeting's work together, and something has to take its place as the connective tissue — not a chain of command, but a network through which interest groups can reach each other, reach the whole meeting, and be reached by it. This part sets out what that network needs to do and how it might actually work for a meeting Bear Creek's size and shape.

What communication has to accomplish

Four distinct needs, often conflated, are worth separating:

1. **Within a group** — the ordinary back-and-forth among the two, three, or five Friends doing a particular piece of work: scheduling, dividing tasks, thinking something through together.

2. **From a group to the whole meeting** — reporting what is being done, so the meeting's ongoing discernment (Part VII) has something real to test.

3. **From the whole meeting to a group** — a question, a concern, an offer of help, a piece of history someone remembers that bears on the work.

4. **Urgent, time-sensitive need** — a family facing an emergency, a property failure, something that cannot wait for the next scheduled gathering.

The inherited structure handled most of this informally, because a smaller, more co-located meeting could rely on everyone simply knowing what was happening through ordinary proximity. Bear Creek can no longer assume that proximity, and so this document recommends making each of these four channels explicit and lightweight, rather than leaving them to recreate themselves informally and unevenly, which is largely what has happened already — hence the sense, documented in Part III, that some Friends feel out of the loop while others feel they are the loop.

Principles for the network

Redundancy over elegance. No single channel should be the only way word travels, because no single channel reaches every Friend equally. Some Friends read email faithfully; some do not use it at all and are reached only by phone or in person at the meetinghouse. A network that assumes everyone checks the same shared document is a network that quietly excludes whoever does not.

Asynchronous by default. Because Friends are geographically scattered and keep different schedules, the network should not assume everyone can gather at the same time to receive

information. A standing, lightly maintained shared space — Part VIII recommends a simple shared document or folder, the kind of tool Jeff's own OKF knowledge-bundle practice already demonstrates working well for organizing dispersed written material — does more work than any number of synchronous calls.

No single point of failure. The current pattern, in which Jeff and Jennie alone carry Outreach and Website, or in which financial record location lives with one Treasurer, is precisely the fragility this document is trying to design away. The communication network itself should not recreate that fragility by routing everything through one person's inbox.

Visible by default, private by exception. Interest-group reporting should default to being visible to the whole meeting — this is what makes transparency actually function as the accountability mechanism described in Part VII — with privacy reserved deliberately for matters that genuinely require it (a pastoral concern raised with Ministry and Counsel, a sensitive family matter connected to a memorial gift).

A concrete architecture

A shared, living document of current interest groups. A single page — however it is hosted — listing every active interest group, who is part of it, what it is working on, and a line or two of its most recent update. This is not a bureaucratic register; it is the meeting's own map of its current life, something any Friend can open and immediately see what is happening and where they might plug in. It replaces the implicit knowledge that used to live in a few heads with something any Friend, including a newly curious one, can read for themselves.

A standing email list or equivalent, used for reporting-out, not just announcements. When an interest group has something to report, it reports to the whole meeting through this channel, not only at business meeting once a month. This is what makes the transparency mechanism in Part VII actually responsive rather than delayed by weeks.

The business meeting agenda itself, lightened. Rather than committees presenting full reports that consume the bulk of business meeting's time, interest groups can submit short written updates in advance (through the shared document above), freeing spoken time at business meeting for genuine discernment, concerns, and the queries that are its deeper purpose — the actual meeting for business with attention to its spiritual condition, not an administrative review session.

A clearly named channel for urgent need. Whatever form it takes — a phone tree, a short list of Friends who have agreed to be reachable for time-sensitive requests, a simple rule that urgent financial need goes directly to whoever is currently holding the Finance interest group's fast-

response role (Part IX) — this needs to exist explicitly, precisely because mutual aid's promise of rapid response (Part IX) depends on someone actually being reachable quickly.

A non-digital channel, deliberately maintained. Not every Friend connected to Bear Creek uses email or Zoom comfortably, and a meeting committed to real inclusion cannot let its communication network quietly become digital-only. A standing practice — someone checking in by phone with Friends who are not online, a printed summary left at the meetinghouse, word passed at pre-meeting on First Day — keeps the network genuinely reaching everyone, not just everyone already comfortable with the tools.

A worked month

To make this concrete: imagine an ordinary month under this structure. The water-quality interest group described above posts a short update to the shared document in week one, noting it has scheduled a well test. The safe-cataloguing group (Part X) reports in week two that it has finished photographing one box of early meeting minutes and is beginning transcription, and flags a question for Nancy Osborn Johnsen about a name it cannot make out. A Friend facing a sudden car repair reaches the Finance interest group directly through the urgent-need channel on a Wednesday and has funds by Friday, with a two-line report appearing in the shared document the same week. At business meeting on the third First Day, none of this needs to be presented at length — it is already visible to anyone who looked — freeing the gathered meeting to spend its time on a concern a Friend has been carrying about the meeting's engagement with immigrant families in the area, which surfaces not through a committee report but because the communication network made room for it to be raised directly.

This is what "responsive" means in practice: not faster meetings, but a network that lets small things stay small and be handled quickly, while reserving the gathered meeting's limited, precious time together for what actually needs the whole body's discernment.

Guarding against failure modes

Two failure modes deserve direct attention, because they are the predictable ways a network like this can quietly stop working.

Silent exclusion. If the shared document and the digital channels become, in practice, the only real communication network, the Friends least comfortable with those tools — often, though not always, elder Friends — will quietly stop being part of the meeting's real information flow even while remaining nominally included. This is why the non-digital channel above is not an afterthought; it is a structural requirement, and some interest group's standing responsibility should explicitly include maintaining it.

Information without weight. A network that makes everything visible can also make everything equally unimportant — a flood of small updates in which the one that actually needs the whole meeting's attention gets lost. This is part of why business meeting itself remains central rather than optional: it is where the gathered meeting's discernment, not just its information flow, continues to do the deeper work no shared document can substitute for.

Holding privacy and transparency together

Transparency, as this document uses the term throughout, has never meant that everything about every Friend's life or every interest group's internal conversation becomes public. It means specifically that an interest group's *actions* — what was done, what was spent, what was decided — are visible to the whole meeting, not that every private conversation among its members, every personal circumstance behind a request for aid, or every pastoral sensitivity it encounters must be laid open for general view. Part IX's urgent-need example already shows this distinction at work: a family's privacy is protected even as the fact and rough shape of the meeting's response is reported. This document recommends the communication network hold this distinction deliberately, not as an exception grudgingly carved out of an otherwise total transparency, but as part of transparency's own proper shape — a community can be genuinely open about what it does while still protecting what individual members have shared in confidence, exactly as Ministry and Counsel has always held pastoral confidences alongside its more visible spiritual oversight role.

What Laughing Waters already demonstrates

Laughing Waters Friends Worship Group — the virtual-only group meeting at 1:30 p.m. on fourth Sundays, under Bear Creek's care, with Nat Case as contact — is worth returning to here specifically, because it already answers, in practice, a question this part might otherwise leave abstract: can a genuinely meaningful, spiritually alive community exist entirely through the kind of communication network this document proposes, with no physical gathering at all? Laughing Waters' Minnesota-based participants — Nat Case, Karen Morey, August Kalinosky, and Liz Oppenheimer among them — have sustained real worship, real community, and a real relationship to Bear Creek's wider life for years through exactly this kind of distributed, screen-mediated connection. This document's communication network proposal is not asking Bear Creek to attempt something unprecedented; it is asking the whole meeting to extend, deliberately and with the same care, a pattern a part of the meeting already lives inside successfully.

Reaching Friends who are not online

It deserves to be said plainly, and not left as an afterthought buried in a principle statement: some Friends connected to Bear Creek — elder Friends especially, but not only elder Friends — do not use email, do not join Zoom, and would be structurally excluded from a meeting that quietly let its real information flow move entirely online. This document recommends that whichever interest group takes up communication network upkeep treat these Friends' inclusion as a named, standing responsibility, not a problem to solve once and consider finished. Concretely: a regular phone call or in-person visit from a Friend who has taken this on, checking in on what is happening in the meeting's life and making sure that Friend has a way to raise their own concerns or offer their own gifts in return; a simple printed summary, perhaps distributed at the meetinghouse or by mail, covering what the shared digital document already holds, so paper remains a first-class way of knowing what is happening rather than an afterthought; and a basic rule, recommended for the whole meeting's practice, that no decision of real weight is considered to have been adequately communicated if it reached only the Friends who are online.

A simple protocol for different kinds of messages

To keep the four channels described above from blurring into one undifferentiated stream, a short, shared understanding of what goes where serves everyone, especially Friends newer to the model: routine interest-group updates belong in the shared living document, not individual emails to the whole list, which should be reserved for things genuinely worth everyone's immediate attention; a question for a specific interest group goes directly to that group, not to the whole meeting, unless the asking Friend genuinely believes the whole meeting should weigh in; anything urgent and time-sensitive goes through the named urgent-need channel, by phone or whatever reaches people fastest, never only through a channel someone might not check for days; and anything touching real pastoral weight — grief, conflict, a Friend in crisis — goes to Ministry and Counsel directly, never into the general shared document, regardless of how the rest of this protocol might otherwise seem to apply.

Why this network matters more than it might first appear

It would be easy to treat the communication proposals in this part as merely logistical — necessary plumbing, interesting mainly to whichever Friend takes up its upkeep. This undersells their real importance. Every other proposal in this document — trust replacing approval, money circulating freely, interest groups forming and dissolving without central coordination — depends entirely on information actually reaching the Friends who need it, when they need it. A meeting can adopt every structural recommendation in this document and still fail in practice if its communication network quietly breaks down, because trust without visibility is simply unaccountability wearing trust's name. This document asks Bear Creek to take the unglamorous

work of keeping its shared document current, its urgent-need channel genuinely reachable, and its non-digital Friends genuinely included as seriously as it takes any of the more conceptually interesting proposals elsewhere in this document — because without it, nothing else here actually works as intended.

A practical tools inventory, held loosely

This document deliberately avoids prescribing a single piece of software as the permanent backbone of Bear Creek's communication network, both because tools change faster than governance structures should and because Friends' comfort with any given tool varies. What follows is offered as a starting menu, not a mandate — the actual choice belongs to whichever Friends take up the "keeping the network working" interest group, informed by what the wider meeting can actually use.

For the shared living document of interest groups: any tool that is free, simple, and genuinely accessible to Friends with limited technical comfort — a shared Google Doc, for instance, requires only a web browser and no account for viewing, and can be edited by a small number of Friends while remaining visible to everyone. For the standing email list: Bear Creek very likely already has some version of this through its existing Outreach practice, and extending its use to interest-group reporting is a small step rather than a new system. For urgent-need contact: this does not require new technology at all — a short, printed or emailed list of two or three phone numbers, kept current, may serve better than any app, precisely because it asks nothing of a Friend in crisis beyond knowing who to call.

What matters far more than the specific tools chosen is the discipline of actually keeping them current — a beautifully designed system that falls out of date within a month does less for the meeting than a plain list faithfully maintained. This document recommends that whichever interest group takes up the communication network's upkeep treat "keeping it current" as its primary measure of success, not the sophistication of the tools themselves.

The business meeting minute, reconsidered

One further practical note belongs here. As interest groups increasingly report through the shared living document rather than through lengthy spoken reports at business meeting, Bear Creek's own minute-taking practice should adjust accordingly — not by recording less, but by recording differently. Rather than detailed minutes of each committee's spoken report, minutes can simply note that an interest group's written update is on file in the shared document, reserving fuller minute language for matters that actually received the gathered meeting's discernment: a concern raised, a question asked, a sense of unity reached or not yet reached.

This keeps Bear Creek's minute book doing what it has always existed to do — recording the meeting's spiritual and corporate life, not functioning as an administrative transcript — while the shared document handles the ongoing, granular record-keeping a minute book was never well suited to in the first place.

Part IX: Money and Mutual Aid

Money is where the interest-group model will be tested most sharply, because money is where trust has historically been hardest to extend without a gatekeeper, and where the cost of getting it wrong is most concrete. This part sets out a concrete proposal, consistent with the mutual aid practice described in Part V, for how Bear Creek's finances might work under this model — and it is deliberately specific, because a vague commitment to "trust" around money will not survive its first hard case.

Where Bear Creek's finances stand now

The Treasurer, currently Osa Bricker, keeps account of all funds, with *Faith and Practice* (p. 72) recommending an annual audit. Osa also serves as a Trustee, alongside Russ Leckband, holding legal and corporate responsibility for the meeting's property where Iowa law requires it. There is no Assistant Treasurer — meaning, as Part III noted, that the location of records and accounts currently lives with one person, against *Faith and Practice*'s own template. The meeting also carries an annual apportionment obligation to Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative), proposed each year by the Representatives Committee (Part XII), which must continue to be paid regardless of any internal restructuring.

This document does not propose changing any of this at the level of legal and fiduciary responsibility. Osa and Russ, or whoever holds Treasurer and Trustee roles in the future, remain the Friends with formal, legal accountability for the meeting's funds and property. What this document proposes changing is *who can initiate the movement of money for the meeting's ordinary mutual aid work*, and *how quickly that movement can happen* — which is a question of delegated access and practiced trust, not a question of who ultimately answers for the books.

The core proposal: funds available to any interest group, on trust

Consistent with the Des Moines Mutual Aid pattern described in Part V — aid released on stated need, not on proven worthiness — this document proposes that **any interest group be able to draw modest funds for its work without first seeking approval from the Treasurer, Trustees, or any other central body**, reporting what was spent and why through the ordinary transparency mechanisms described in Part VIII. The water-quality group's well test, the archive group's scanning supplies, a small honorarium for someone helping with Prairie Awakening documentation — these are the ordinary, modest costs of a meeting's life, and this document's claim is that routing every one of them through a Treasurer's advance approval is exactly the kind of bottleneck Part IV diagnosed, applied to money specifically.

A **threshold** makes this workable without becoming reckless: a modest figure — the meeting's own discernment should set the actual number, but something in the range of what a single Friend might comfortably spend without a second thought, perhaps $100 to $200 — below which any interest group can simply spend and report, and above which the spending is discussed with the Finance interest group (below) before or very soon after the fact, not as an approval gate but as a conversation among Friends who are jointly stewarding a shared resource.

Memorial funds and larger gifts

Memorial gifts carry particular weight, both financially and spiritually — they often represent a family's wish to honor a life in a way consonant with that person's values, and Bear Creek has a real and growing body of such gifts to steward thoughtfully. The proposal here is not that memorial funds become an undifferentiated pool anyone can draw on without regard to the donor's intention; a family's wishes, where stated, remain a genuine constraint, held faithfully. But within whatever boundaries a particular gift carries, this document recommends treating memorial resources the way Des Moines Mutual Aid treated donated food: as a shared circulation belonging to the meeting's whole life, available to whichever interest group's work it can serve, rather than held in reserve awaiting a use important enough to justify drawing on it. A memorial gift given in general support of the meeting's life is honored more fully, not less, by actually circulating into the archive project, the resilience work, or a family's emergency need than by sitting untouched out of an excess of caution about whether any particular use is worthy enough.

The Finance interest group's role

This document proposes a standing Finance interest group — standing, not because it needs the permanence of Clerk or Treasurer, but because its work genuinely benefits from continuity of a few Friends who hold the whole financial picture in view. Its role is explicitly **not** gatekeeping. It is:

- **Stewardship**: maintaining a simple, shared, visible ledger — not a private set of books known only to the Treasurer, but a record any Friend can see, updated as interest groups report their spending, so the whole meeting can watch its own resources move in something close to real time.
- **Fast response**: holding the mechanism (below) for rapid digital distribution of funds for urgent need, and being genuinely, personally reachable when that need arises — this is the "urgent-need channel" named in Part VIII, made concrete here.
- **Partnership, not permission**: when an interest group's need crosses the threshold above, the Finance group's role is to think it through together with that group, offer context the group might not have (what else is drawing on the same resources this

season, whether a memorial gift's restrictions bear on this particular use), and help the group reach its own good decision — not to approve or deny it unilaterally.

- **The annual audit**: continuing *Faith and Practice*'s own recommended practice (p. 72), ensuring the books are sound not through constant gatekeeping but through a periodic, thorough, honest accounting — the appropriate place for rigor, rather than at every individual transaction.

Mechanisms for rapid digital distribution

The explicit ask in the conversation that gave rise to this document — "there should be mechanisms for immediate distribution of funds digitally as the needs arise" — deserves a concrete answer, not just a principle. A workable version: the Treasurer, together with one or two Finance interest group members, maintains access to a dedicated account or digital payment tool (a Zelle or similar connection tied to the meeting's own bank account, rather than a personal account of any individual Friend) that can move funds same-day for a stated need, with the report following immediately after rather than an approval preceding it. This keeps legal and fiduciary responsibility exactly where it already sits — with the Treasurer and Trustees, whose names are on the accounts — while giving a small number of trusted, named Friends the practical ability to act on a Tuesday rather than waiting for the third First Day of the month.

A worked example: urgent need

Imagine a Friend — or a family connected to the meeting through one of its worship groups, or a neighbor reached through the kind of relationship-based outreach Part V describes — faces a sudden utility shutoff notice with three days to pay. Under the inherited model, this need would likely have to wait for a Treasurer's judgment, perhaps a conversation with the Clerk, possibly a reference to business meeting if the amount is significant — a process that could easily outlast the three days available. Under this proposal: the need is brought to whoever is currently holding the Finance group's fast-response role, by phone, by text, by whatever channel reaches them fastest. If the amount is within the threshold, funds move same day. If it exceeds the threshold, the Finance group reaches a quick, good-faith judgment together — not a formal vote, but the kind of discernment two or three trusted Friends can do in an hour — and funds still move well within the three days. A short report appears in the shared communication space the same week: what was given, to address what need, drawn from which resources. The family's privacy is protected by the meeting's ordinary pastoral discretion (the report need not name the family if that would cause harm); the meeting's accountability is protected by the fact that the report exists, is visible, and is open to question if any Friend has concern.

What a Friend considering leaving a memorial gift might want to know

For Friends thinking ahead about their own eventual memorial gift to Bear Creek, or helping a family member think through theirs, it may help to say plainly how this proposal affects that planning. A gift given with specific restrictions — designated for a particular purpose the donor names clearly — remains bound by those restrictions exactly as it always would have been; nothing in this document changes a meeting's basic obligation to honor a donor's clearly stated wishes. A gift given without restriction, in general support of the meeting's life, is the kind this document recommends treating as genuinely available to the meeting's ongoing mutual aid circulation, rather than held in an undesignated reserve awaiting an unusually significant occasion. A Friend who wants their own eventual gift held more conservatively, or directed toward a specific purpose — the archive project, say, or a resilience area that speaks to them — can simply say so in whatever document records their wishes, and that designation will be honored precisely as this document's own treatment of designated funds throughout Part IX describes. This document's proposal does not remove a donor's voice from how their gift is used; it changes only what happens, by default, with a gift that carries no specific designation at all.

A worked example: a significant memorial gift

Imagine a memorial gift of several thousand dollars arrives, given in general support of the meeting's life by a family honoring a longtime member. Under this proposal, the Finance interest group does not hold this gift in an undesignated reserve awaiting a sufficiently momentous use. It brings the gift's existence to the whole meeting's attention — this is a moment for the gathered meeting's discernment, not a unilateral Finance-group decision, precisely because a gift of this size touches the whole community's sense of how it wants to honor the person remembered. Friends may feel moved to direct a portion toward the archive project, a portion toward building out the resilience work described in Part XI, a portion held as a standing resource available to interest groups drawing under the threshold throughout the coming year. The decision is reached through ordinary Quaker discernment at business meeting — not approval in the gatekeeping sense Part VII rejects, but the deeper, older kind of discernment this whole document is built around — and once reached, the funds move into the same transparent, trust-based circulation as everything else.

A standing reserve, held in common

Beyond the ordinary circulation of funds described above, this document recommends Bear Creek's Finance interest group maintain a modest standing reserve — not a large, carefully hoarded sum that would itself become a source of anxiety and gatekeeping, but enough to absorb an unexpected need without the meeting scrambling in the moment it arises. This is simply prudent stewardship, consistent with the testimony of simplicity's deeper meaning discussed in

Part IX's theological note: holding enough in reserve to meet reasonably foreseeable need, without holding so much that the meeting's resources sit idle rather than circulating toward the mutual aid work this document describes throughout. The size of this reserve, like the spending threshold itself, belongs to the meeting's own discernment, likely set initially through conversation between the Treasurer, Trustees, and Finance interest group, and revisited as the meeting's actual experience with urgent need accumulates. A reserve exists to be used when genuinely needed, not preserved indefinitely as evidence of the meeting's caution — and the Finance group's quarterly reporting (described above) should make clear, each time, both what the reserve currently holds and what it has been drawn down to meet.

When needs compete for limited resources

This document's proposal assumes real but finite resources, and it is worth addressing directly what happens when several interest groups' genuine needs arrive at once and the meeting's resources cannot easily stretch to cover all of them — a water-testing need, an urgent family emergency, and the archive project's preservation costs all surfacing in the same season, say. The trust-based model proposed here does not pretend this tension away. Below the spending threshold, this is rarely a real problem — modest individual expenditures across several interest groups add up to a modest total, well within what a meeting Bear Creek's size can absorb without strain. Where genuine competition for larger or more urgent resources arises, this document recommends the same answer it has offered throughout: honest conversation, held in the open, rather than a formal priority ranking decided in advance. Urgent human need — a family facing an emergency — should, as a matter of the meeting's own values, generally take priority over work that can wait, and this document expects Bear Creek's Friends, operating through the Finance interest group's judgment and the whole meeting's visible oversight, to recognize this without needing a formal rule to state it. Where real disagreement arises about priority, it belongs, like any other substantial disagreement, to the gathered meeting's own discernment — not to a rule this document could write in advance for every circumstance it cannot anticipate.

A sample shared ledger format

To make the "simple, shared, visible ledger" described above concrete rather than aspirational, a workable format might look like this — plain enough to maintain without specialized bookkeeping skill, detailed enough to serve as real transparency:

Date	Interest group	What for	Amount	Source	Reported by
10/14	Safe/archive	Archival sleeves, labels	$38	General fund	August K.

10/19	Water resilience	Well water test kit	$65	General fund	August K.
10/22	Finance (urgent need)	Utility assistance, family in need	$150	Memorial fund (general)	Osa B.
11/02	Outreach	Newsletter printing	$22	General fund	Jeff K.

A running total by category — general fund, each designated memorial gift, apportionment set-aside — lets any Friend see at a glance both what has moved and what remains, without needing to understand formal bookkeeping to make sense of it.

A sample quarterly report to the meeting

Alongside the ongoing ledger, the Finance interest group might offer a brief quarterly summary at business meeting — not a lengthy formal report, but a few sentences giving the whole meeting a sense of its shared financial life: *"This quarter, interest groups drew a total of $340 from the general fund across four projects, and $150 from the general memorial fund to meet one urgent need. The [specific] memorial gift remains at $[amount], undesignated pending the meeting's further discernment about its use. The books remain open for any Friend to review, and our annual audit is scheduled for [month].*" This kind of brief, regular, honest accounting does more to sustain trust over time than either silence or an elaborate formal report that few Friends have time to absorb.

What this does not change

To be unambiguous: the Treasurer and Trustees remain the Friends with legal and fiduciary responsibility for the meeting's funds and property. The annual apportionment to Iowa Yearly Meeting continues to be paid, in full, on schedule, as an obligation that does not compete with the mutual aid work described here — it is simply budgeted for, the way any household budgets for a fixed obligation before deciding how to spend what remains. The annual audit continues. What changes is the *distance* between a stated need and a response to it — shortened, deliberately, because that distance has real human cost when the need is real, and because Bear Creek has Friends — Osa, the Finance interest group, the whole gathered meeting — capable of extending the trust this model asks for.

A worked example: a modest, routine expenditure

Not every financial example needs to involve crisis or significant sums. Suppose the Outreach interest group wants to print and mail a season's newsletter to a handful of Friends who do not

use email — a small, recurring, entirely unremarkable cost. Under this proposal, Jeff or Jennie simply pays the modest printing cost, logs it in the shared ledger ("$22, newsletter printing, Outreach, November"), and continues. No form, no request, no waiting. This is, deliberately, the least dramatic possible illustration of the model — and that is the point: the overwhelming majority of an interest group's financial life under this proposal looks exactly this unremarkable, small, routine spending handled without friction, with the more elaborate mechanisms described elsewhere in this part reserved for the genuinely larger or more urgent cases that are, by comparison, rare.

A worked example: a Friend who is uncomfortable asking

Not every Friend facing need will reach for the urgent-need channel easily, even once it exists, and this document should not assume otherwise. Suppose a Friend — proud, private, raised to manage on their own, as many in rural Iowa are — faces real hardship but says nothing, not out of any failure of the system described in Part IX, but simply because asking does not come naturally to them. This is where the relational work described throughout this document, not its financial mechanisms alone, matters most: a meeting whose Friends actually know each other, check in on each other, and notice when someone seems to be struggling will surface this kind of quiet need long before any formal channel would catch it. The Finance interest group's mechanism exists for when a need is stated; the deeper work of actually noticing unstated need belongs to the whole meeting's ordinary practice of care — pastoral attentiveness that Ministry and Counsel models but that properly belongs to every Friend, not to any single committee. This document's finance proposal is only as good as the relational fabric surrounding it, which is one more reason Part V's emphasis on trust built through sustained relationship, not only through structural mechanism, runs through everything else in this document.

A fuller theology of money

It is worth pausing on why money, of all things, receives such direct and specific treatment in a document otherwise concerned with spiritual and structural questions. The testimony of simplicity is often narrowed, in casual usage, to mean merely "not owning too much" — but its deeper and older meaning concerns the *right relationship* between a person or a community and material resources: neither hoarding them out of fear, nor treating them as unimportant, but holding them lightly, as a trust to be stewarded for the good of the whole rather than a possession to be defended. A meeting's relationship to its own money is one of the clearest, most concrete places this testimony can be either honored or quietly set aside. A structure that requires every expenditure to clear a central approval, out of an unstated fear that funds entrusted more widely might be misused, is a structure organized around financial anxiety rather than financial faith —

understandable, given how seriously Friends rightly take their fiduciary responsibilities, but not, this document argues, the only available posture, and not the one most consonant with a testimony that has always asked Friends to hold material things loosely rather than clutch them tightly.

This does not mean carelessness with money is somehow more spiritual than carefulness. It means the *location* of carefulness shifts — from gatekeeping in advance to honest stewardship throughout, the same shift this document has argued for everywhere else. A Finance interest group practicing careful, visible, shared bookkeeping is not being less careful with Bear Creek's resources than a Treasurer personally approving every expenditure; it is being careful in a different, more distributed way, one that trusts more Friends to share the weight of that carefulness rather than concentrating it, and the anxiety that comes with it, in one or two people.

When Friends disagree about how funds should be used

Money is also where disagreement, when it arises, tends to feel sharpest — a disagreement about whether a particular use of memorial funds was wise can carry emotional weight disproportionate to the dollar amount involved, especially when a specific family's memory is bound up in the gift. This document recommends that such disagreements be held the same way Part VI recommends holding any honest disagreement about an interest group's judgment: named directly, discussed in love, brought to the whole meeting's discernment if it cannot be resolved between the Friends directly involved, and — crucially — not allowed to become a reason to re-impose blanket approval requirements that would undo the responsiveness this whole proposal is built to provide. A single hard case, handled well through honest conversation, strengthens the model; a single hard case used to justify reverting to central gatekeeping squanders the trust the meeting has only just begun to build.

Part X: The Safe and the Archive

Among everything in this document, the newly opened safe and the historical records it holds offer something rare: a project that is simultaneously urgent in its own right and perfectly suited to serve as the interest-group model's first proving ground. This part treats it that way deliberately — not only as a task to be done, but as a demonstration Bear Creek can point to, honestly, when explaining to itself or to Iowa Yearly Meeting what this new way of working actually looks like in practice.

Why this matters, and why now

For decades, the historical records kept in Bear Creek's safe were inaccessible — not withheld by any decision, but genuinely unreachable, because the safe itself could not be unlocked. That changed recently. *Faith and Practice* (p. 72) recommends an annually appointed committee to examine a meeting's historical records; Bear Creek currently has none. The nearest existing resource is Nancy Osborn Johnsen, who has served as Historian/Archivist on the Library committee and has already done remarkable independent work — compiling a detailed, sourced historical narrative of the meetinghouse itself, drawing on Herbert C. Standing's 1977 unpublished "Historical Notes Concerning the Conservative Friends at Bear Creek," L. Frank Bedell's 1966 "Quaker Heritage," and Henry Standing's diaries from 1882 to 1908, which Nancy transcribed herself. But cataloguing the safe's actual contents — now that they are finally reachable — is, as things stand, unassigned work, belonging to no one's standing responsibility.

This is exactly the kind of task the interest-group model was built for: bounded, meaningful, genuinely interesting to the right Friends, requiring real but learnable skill, and — crucially — largely doable by Friends who are not physically at the meetinghouse, which matters enormously given how much of Bear Creek's active life now happens at a distance.

A phased approach

Phase one: photograph. Someone physically present at the meetinghouse — this does not require specialized skill, only access and a working phone camera — photographs the safe's contents, document by document, in a consistent and organized way (a simple numbering or folder convention prevents chaos later). This is the one phase that genuinely requires physical presence, and it should be treated as such: a task for whichever Friends are regularly at the meetinghouse, done at whatever pace is sustainable, not rushed.

Phase two: catalog. Remote Friends — exactly the circle named throughout this document, Friends like Jenny Cisar, Doug Mankins, Nat Case, or any Friend drawn to the work regardless of location — work from the photographs to build a simple, structured log: what each document is,

its approximate date, who or what it concerns, its physical condition, and a brief note on its apparent significance. This does not require transcribing every word; it requires enough description that a future Friend, or Nancy, or a Yearly Meeting historian, can find what they are looking for without opening the safe again.

Phase three: decide what is transcribed. Not everything needs full transcription — some documents are routine financial records with modest historical interest; others, like the early minute books or correspondence touching on matters of real historical weight (Bear Creek's own engagement with conscientious objection, for instance, which the 1972 correspondence from Homer Moffitt and the Peace Committee already hints at), deserve careful, complete transcription. This is a discernment task, not a mechanical one, and benefits from Nancy's historical judgment working alongside whoever has catalogued the material — a natural point of connection between the new interest group and the meeting's existing historical expertise, rather than a replacement of it.

Phase four: decide what is shared, and how. Once material is catalogued and selectively transcribed, the meeting faces a genuine question: what belongs in a private archive, consulted only by Friends with a specific need, and what belongs in wider circulation — a page on the meeting's website, a piece written up in the spirit of Jeff's own decade of blogging as "stories of hope and resilience," material offered to Iowa Yearly Meeting's own Archives Committee for the wider Quaker historical record. This decision deserves the same open discernment as any other matter of real weight, especially where documents touch on still-living families or sensitive matters — grief, conflict, personal struggle — that call for real pastoral care in how, or whether, they are shared.

Phase five: preserve the originals. Whatever is decided about sharing, the physical documents themselves need appropriate preservation — acid-free storage, climate considerations, a clear decision about where they ultimately live (the meetinghouse itself, if conditions allow; a more controlled environment, if not). This is a smaller, more specialized task, likely benefiting from Nancy's experience or from reaching out to Iowa Yearly Meeting's Archives Committee for guidance, rather than something the interest group needs to solve alone.

Tools worth borrowing

Jeff's own practice of organizing research and writing through OKF knowledge bundles — Obsidian-based folders with markdown frontmatter, simple validators, and an index and log file tracking what has been done — offers a ready-made, low-cost model for exactly the kind of structured cataloguing this project needs, without requiring the interest group to invent its own system from nothing or adopt something more complex than the task warrants. A shared

spreadsheet or a similarly simple structured log, with consistent fields (date, description, condition, location, transcribed yes/no, shared yes/no), would serve the same purpose for Friends less drawn to that particular tool.

A worked example: one box, start to finish

Suppose the first box opened holds a run of minute books from the 1960s and 1970s — plausibly including material touching Bear Creek's engagement with the Peace Committee and conscientious objection during the Vietnam War era, given Homer Moffitt's 1972 correspondence on exactly this subject. A Friend at the meetinghouse photographs each page across two or three visits, uploading images to a shared folder as they go. Over the following weeks, two or three remote Friends — perhaps drawn to the project because family history or a personal interest in peace testimony pulls them toward it — work through the images, logging each minute book's date range and a line on its contents. When they reach the material touching conscientious objection, they flag it for fuller transcription, given its evident historical and spiritual significance, and loop in Nancy for her read on where it fits against what she already knows. Once transcribed, the group — not unilaterally, but through the meeting's ordinary discernment — proposes that this particular material, suitably introduced and with any necessary care for living family members, would make a meaningful piece for Bear Creek's own history and potentially for Iowa Yearly Meeting's wider archive, connecting directly to the thirteenth part of this document's proposal that Bear Creek's own experience, honestly shared, might serve a wider community.

A year in the life of one interest group

It may help, before moving on, to imagine the fuller arc of a single interest group over a full year — not as a worked example illustrating one principle, as earlier parts have offered, but as a fuller account of what the whole model might actually feel like to live inside, start to finish, including its harder moments.

Suppose the safe-cataloguing group begins in November, as Part XIV's roadmap suggests, with two Friends: one present at the meetinghouse most weeks, one joining entirely by Zoom. The first month is slow — learning the photography workflow, figuring out a numbering system, getting used to working together across the distance between them. A third Friend joins in December, drawn in after reading the group's first short update in the shared communication space. By February, the group has photographed two full boxes and built real momentum; Nancy Osborn Johnsen, consulted on a puzzling document, becomes an informal fourth participant, lending her historical expertise without needing to formally "join" anything.

In March, the group hits its first real difficulty: a box of records proves to include material touching a conflict within the meeting decades earlier, involving people whose descendants are still active Friends today. The group pauses, uncertain how to proceed, and — exactly as Part X recommends — brings the question to Ministry and Counsel rather than deciding alone. The conversation that follows is not entirely comfortable; it surfaces real difference of opinion about how much of this history belongs in a shared archive versus a more limited one. But it is handled, in the end, through the kind of honest, loving conversation this document has argued should replace gatekeeping throughout — and the group emerges from it not with a perfect answer, but with a workable one, and real trust built through having worked through something hard together.

By midyear, the group's pace slows again — summer brings travel, a Friend's health concern takes someone's attention elsewhere for a few weeks, and progress on the physical materials stalls even as transcription of what has already been photographed continues steadily. This, too, is worth naming honestly: interest groups do not move at a constant pace, and this document does not expect them to. The communication network's role here is simply to keep the group's status visible — "paused for the summer, will pick back up in September" — rather than letting silence read as failure.

By the following autumn, a full year in, the group has worked through roughly a third of the safe's contents, built a genuinely useful catalog, surfaced one piece of material — the Homer Moffitt correspondence, say — worth fuller transcription and possible sharing, and worked through one real moment of difficulty that tested and ultimately strengthened the group's internal trust and its relationship with Ministry and Counsel. No formal appointment was ever made. No standing budget line was ever approved in advance. The group simply began, worked, paused, resumed, encountered a real question, handled it honestly, and kept going — which is, in miniature, this entire document's proposal for how Bear Creek's whole life might work.

Oral history as a companion to the written archive

The safe holds Bear Creek's written record, but a meeting this size still holds something the safe cannot: living memory, carried by Friends who have themselves been part of decades of its life. Nancy Osborn Johnsen's own historical work already draws on exactly this kind of memory alongside written sources. This document recommends the archive interest group consider, as a natural complement to its written cataloguing work, a modest oral history effort — simple recorded conversations with Bear Creek's longer-serving Friends, asking what they remember of the meeting's life across the years, what has changed, what has stayed the same, what they hope endures. This work is, if anything, even more time-sensitive than the written archive: a document

in a safe waits patiently to be read; a memory carried only in one Friend's mind does not wait at all. A modest recording — even a simple phone recording of an hour's unhurried conversation — captures something no written record ever fully can: tone, hesitation, the particular way a Friend's face changes recalling a specific moment in the meeting's shared life. This document recommends this work begin sooner rather than later, precisely because it is the one part of Bear Creek's historical record that cannot simply wait in a safe for a more convenient season.

What the archive itself may teach about mutual aid

There is a fitting circularity worth naming before moving on from this project: as the safe-cataloguing interest group works through Bear Creek's own history, it may well surface evidence of exactly the kind of flexible, trust-based, need-responsive practice this document is proposing the meeting recover more deliberately today. Homer Moffitt's 1972 correspondence already shows a meeting capable of mobilizing its Peace Committee quickly and faithfully in support of a young Friend's conscience. Earlier minute books may well hold other instances — a meeting responding to a member's hardship, a committee formed and dissolved around a specific need, informal practices of care that never required the heavier machinery later committee structures assumed as default. If so, this document's proposal is not actually asking Bear Creek to become something new; it is asking Bear Creek to recognize and recover something closer to its own older self, obscured over time by institutional habit rather than ever truly set aside by conviction. The archive project may end up telling this story more persuasively than this document itself can — which is one more reason, beyond those already given in Part VII's worked example, that it deserves to be the model's first undertaking.

Why this is the right first interest group

Beyond its own intrinsic value, this project offers Bear Creek a low-risk, high-visibility way to learn what the interest-group model actually feels like in practice — bounded enough that its success or difficulty will be clear within a reasonable time, interesting enough to draw real participation, and valuable enough on its own terms that even a partial success leaves the meeting better off than before it began. The roadmap in Part XIV recommends it as one of the first concrete steps, not because it is the most urgent item in this document, but because it is the one most likely to build the meeting's confidence in everything else proposed here.

A few practical notes on digitization

For the Friends who take up the cataloguing work itself, a few practical notes may save real difficulty later, even though the specific tools should remain the interest group's own choice. Photographs of documents are more useful, and more durable, taken in consistent, even lighting,

with a plain dark background behind lighter paper, and at the highest resolution a Friend's phone camera reasonably allows — these images are, in effect, Bear Creek's backup copy of its own history, and deserve the same care a valued physical document would receive. Files are easier to find later if named consistently from the start — a simple convention (date, box number, item number, brief description) prevents the kind of chaos that can make a large digital collection nearly as hard to search as the original locked safe was. And backup matters as much for digital copies as physical ones: images and transcriptions should live in at least two places — a shared folder any group member can access, and a second copy, ideally not stored on the same single device or account, so that no single failure (a lost phone, a forgotten password, a closed account) threatens to undo months of careful work. None of this requires specialized training; it requires only the same steady, patient care Nancy has already brought to her own independent historical work for years.

Sensitive materials and pastoral care

Historical records kept in a small meeting's safe for decades are unlikely to be uniformly comfortable. They may include disciplinary records from an era of Quaker practice when meetings formally addressed members' conduct in ways contemporary Friends would find troubling; financial records revealing hardship a family might not wish revisited; correspondence touching grief, conflict, or private matters involving people whose descendants remain part of Bear Creek's life today. This calls for real discernment, not a mechanical cataloguing process applied uniformly to everything the safe contains.

This document recommends that the interest group taking up this work hold two commitments simultaneously, in tension but not in contradiction: thoroughness in cataloguing — nothing should be destroyed or hidden simply because it is uncomfortable, since an honest historical record is itself a value this document has argued for throughout — and real pastoral sensitivity in what becomes *widely shared* versus what remains in a more limited archive, consulted by Friends with genuine need rather than published freely. Where a document touches a still-living family, the interest group should not make that sharing decision alone; it belongs, like the weightier discernments this document has described elsewhere, to conversation with Ministry and Counsel, and in some cases with the family itself, before anything moves from private archive into public circulation. This is not a reason to avoid the project — it is simply part of doing it with the care any community's history, especially its harder history, deserves.

Partnering with Iowa Yearly Meeting's Archives Committee

Bear Creek does not need to undertake this work in isolation. Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) maintains its own Archives Committee, and material of wider historical significance —

particularly anything touching the Yearly Meeting's own history, or figures and events of significance beyond Bear Creek alone — may belong, eventually, in that wider archive rather than remaining solely in Bear Creek's own keeping. The interest group taking up this work should treat an early conversation with the Yearly Meeting's Archives Committee as a resource, not an obligation: guidance on preservation standards, on what other small meetings have learned cataloguing their own long-closed records, and potentially a path for particularly significant material to be preserved with the specialized care a larger body can sometimes provide more readily than a small meeting's own meetinghouse.

Part XI: Facing What's Coming — Survival and Mutual Aid

This document would be incomplete, and dishonest about the world Bear Creek actually faces, if it treated the interest-group model purely as an improvement to internal process and left unaddressed the harder context pressing in from outside: an increasingly unstable climate, economic strain reaching deeper into ordinary households, and social fabric under real pressure in rural Iowa as much as anywhere else. This document does not propose dwelling in that difficulty, or framing it in a way that produces fear rather than faithful action. It proposes the opposite: that Bear Creek's own long practice of finding hope and resilience in hard circumstances — reflected in a decade of Jeff's own blogging under exactly that banner — is precisely the spiritual resource a community needs to face a harder future steadily rather than anxiously, and that the interest-group model gives Bear Creek a practical way to act on that resource rather than simply holding it as a disposition.

Naming the difficulty honestly, once more

Before turning to the four specific areas below, it is worth pausing once more on the difficulty this part asks Bear Creek to face directly, because a document can move through hard material quickly enough that its weight is lost. Environmental strain in rural Iowa is not an abstraction: changing rainfall patterns, more volatile growing seasons, and water quality concerns already touch farm families throughout the area around Bear Creek Road, including some connected to the meeting itself. Economic strain reaches rural communities through consolidating agriculture, declining small-town services, and a widening gap between the cost of living and what many fixed and working incomes actually provide, elder Friends living on fixed incomes very much included. Social strain shows itself in the same quiet fraying this document has named throughout — committees understaffed, institutions stretched, community gatherings thinner than they once were, not only at Bear Creek but across the kind of rural communities Bear Creek sits within. None of this is predicted by this document; all of it is already, to varying degrees, underway. What this document asks is not that Bear Creek brace for some future crisis, but that it recognize a present and ongoing condition clearly enough to respond to it with the same patient, faithful, mutual-aid-grounded practice this document has described throughout, rather than either denying the difficulty or being overwhelmed into paralysis by it.

Why this belongs in a document about meeting structure

It would be possible to treat resilience planning as a separate project, disconnected from the governance questions occupying the rest of this document. This document argues the opposite: that *how* Bear Creek organizes itself determines *whether* it can respond well to a harder world. A structure that routes every initiative through a small number of already-overloaded Friends will

respond slowly, if at all, to fast-moving need — exactly the kind of need a less stable climate and economy are likely to produce with increasing frequency. A structure built on fast-forming interest groups and trust-based resource distribution (Part IX) is, by contrast, built for exactly this kind of responsiveness. Resilience planning is not a fourteenth item bolted onto an unrelated governance proposal; it is the proposal's most practical test case.

Four areas, four interest groups

This document recommends treating water, food, medicine, and energy as four distinct, bounded interest-group opportunities — distinct because each calls for different expertise and different first steps, bounded because trying to address all four at once, through one overloaded group, would recreate exactly the overload this whole document is trying to dissolve. The roadmap in Part XIV recommends beginning with one, allowing it to find its footing, before the others form.

Water. House and Grounds' own 2022 report already flagged well-water quality and filtration as an open concern at the meetinghouse — a natural, concrete starting point rather than an abstract exercise. An interest group here might begin with water testing (the worked example in Part VII), move toward appropriate filtration, and over time consider storage capacity for the meetinghouse itself, given that hybrid meeting technology and any future use of the building as a community resource point both depend on reliable water access. August Kalinosky's professional background, noted earlier, makes him a natural first Friend to approach — though, consistent with the whole model, the invitation should be open rather than presumed.

Food. Jeff's own three years with Des Moines Mutual Aid offer Bear Creek direct, lived experience to draw on here, not a theory imported from elsewhere. A food-resilience interest group might begin modestly — a shared garden at the meetinghouse, seed-saving practice, skill-sharing around preserving and canning among Friends who already hold that knowledge — and grow toward building real relationships with existing mutual aid food networks in the area, the way DMMA itself grew from a church basement and fifteen volunteers into a program with real reach. The connective tissue Jeff already holds — his relationship with Ronnie James, his ongoing interest in the United Panther Party's educational work, his place on the Decolonial Repair Network's planning committee supporting Great Plains Action Society's Urban Resilience Hub in Iowa City — means Bear Creek does not have to build this knowledge from nothing; it has, through one of its own members, a living connection to people and organizations who have already done serious work in exactly this area, and who might be approached, respectfully and as partners rather than resources to extract from, as this interest group takes shape.

Medicines. This is the area calling for the most care and the clearest boundaries. This document does not propose that Bear Creek's resilience work extend into medical advice or treatment —

that would exceed any Friend's competence and risk real harm. What it does propose is logistics: continuity planning for elder Friends' medication access during disruption, basic first-aid and emergency preparedness training available to any Friend who wants it, and a clear-eyed inventory of what the meeting's own members already know — several Friends, given Bear Creek's demographic makeup, likely carry real medical or caregiving experience from their working lives, and a resilience interest group's first and most valuable task may simply be finding out who those Friends are and what they are willing to offer, rather than starting from nothing.

Energy. The meetinghouse's hybrid-meeting technology — WiFi, tablet, screen, camera, microphone, all the infrastructure House and Grounds' 2022 report describes building out so that Friends in Minnesota and beyond can remain part of Bear Creek's life — depends entirely on reliable power. An energy-resilience interest group's natural first question is backup capacity: what happens to Bear Creek's hybrid worship, and to the whole web of remote participation this document has described throughout, if the power goes out for an extended period? From there, the group might consider solar potential for the meetinghouse itself, alternative heating options, and more general household-level resilience guidance Friends could use in their own homes — again building outward from a concrete, bounded first step rather than an abstract mandate to "address energy."

Grounded in relationship, not theory

It is worth saying directly: none of this needs to be invented from nothing. Great Plains Action Society's Urban Resilience Hub, on Maiden Lane in Iowa City, is itself an Indigenous-led project built around exactly these questions — land sovereignty, place-based belonging, community resilience — and Jeff's own involvement with it, through the Decolonial Repair Network's planning committee and through work projects on the newly acquired acre of land GPAS holds in downtown Iowa City, gives Bear Creek a real, living relationship to learn from, not a model to copy without understanding. Any resilience interest group Bear Creek forms should approach that relationship, and others like it, with the same posture Jeff's own mutual aid practice has always modeled: as a neighbor learning alongside others facing the same pressures, not as an institution extracting expertise from a community already doing harder work with fewer resources.

Beyond the meeting's own walls

Resilience, understood through a mutual aid lens rather than a self-sufficiency lens, is not something Bear Creek can build alone, and this document would misrepresent its own argument if it implied otherwise. Des Moines Mutual Aid's model depended on relationship with a wider community far beyond its fifteen regular volunteers; the First Nation-Farmer Climate Unity

March's entire premise was that resilience and justice work happen between communities, not within a single one's isolated effort. This document recommends that Bear Creek's resilience interest groups actively seek relationship with neighbors beyond the meeting's own membership — other faith communities in the Earlham area, nearby farm families, local food pantries and mutual aid networks already operating in rural Iowa, and the Indigenous-led organizing Jeff's own relationships already connect Bear Creek to, however informally. A meeting that builds resilience only for its own members, while the wider community around it faces the same strain without support, has not actually practiced the mutual aid ethic this document describes in Part V — it has practiced a more comfortable, bounded version of self-interest wearing mutual aid's language. The real test of this work will be whether it opens outward, in time, toward the wider neighborhood Bear Creek's meetinghouse has always been part of, not only inward toward the meeting's own membership.

Children, youth, and the generations to come

This document has focused throughout on Bear Creek's current adult membership, and it is worth naming that gap directly rather than leaving it silent. Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) maintains its own Junior Yearly Meeting and Young Friends Planning Committees, and any Bear Creek children or youth, present now or in the future, remain connected to that wider structure regardless of anything in this document. But Bear Creek's own interest-group model has something to offer intergenerational life directly, and this document recommends the meeting consider it deliberately rather than by default.

An interest-group structure, built around specific, bounded, often hands-on tasks — cataloguing the safe, tending a garden, learning basic first aid, building a songbook — is naturally well suited to involving children and youth alongside adults in a way a standing committee structure, built around business-meeting-style deliberation, often is not. A young person drawn to history might genuinely contribute to the archive project; a young person interested in growing things might be a real participant in food-resilience work, not merely a child tagging along. This document recommends that as interest groups form, Friends hold explicit openness to intergenerational participation as a value worth naming, not assuming that "Friends" in this document's language means only adults, and that whatever family connections Bear Creek currently has or hopes to grow are treated as a live concern for the interest-group model to serve, not an afterthought outside its scope.

Holding hope and realism together

The conversation that gave rise to this document was explicit that this work needs "a positive but realistic orientation," and that instruction deserves to be honored directly here, not only as a

tone note but as a substantive commitment. Realism means naming, without softening, that environmental and economic strain are real, already affecting rural communities like the one around Bear Creek Road, and likely to deepen rather than resolve in the coming years. Hope — the particular, disciplined hope that runs through Jeff's own decade of writing — means refusing to let that realism curdle into despair or paralysis, and insisting instead that a faithful community, acting together through structures built on trust rather than fear, is genuinely capable of meeting a harder world with more resilience, not less, than it would have faced alone. The interest-group model is not only compatible with that hope; it is one of the clearest, most practical ways Bear Creek has available to act on it.

What Friends can do at home, while the interest groups take shape

Resilience work does not need to wait for formal interest groups to organize before Friends begin acting. Much of what water, food, medicine, and energy resilience actually require at the household level is already within individual Friends' reach, and the meeting's collective work can grow naturally out of what Friends are already doing in their own homes rather than starting from nothing.

A Friend who already gardens can simply begin sharing seeds and know-how with others at coffee hour after meeting, long before any formal "food resilience interest group" forms — and when it does form, it will have real practice to build on rather than a blank page. A Friend with professional water-quality knowledge, like August, can informally advise neighbors on private well testing without waiting for a charter. A Friend already comfortable with basic first-aid can simply offer, informally, to walk other Friends through what they know. None of this requires the meeting's formal structure to move first — and this document recommends the meeting actively welcome and celebrate this kind of informal, household-level beginning as entirely consonant with its larger purpose, rather than treating resilience work as something that only counts once it has been formally named as an interest group. The formal structure exists to support and connect what Friends are already doing, not to gate whether it can begin.

How the four areas connect to each other

Water, food, medicine, and energy are treated here as four distinct interest-group opportunities, but it is worth naming directly that they do not actually function independently of one another, and a mature resilience effort at Bear Creek will eventually need to recognize their overlap rather than let four separate groups work in isolation. A meetinghouse without reliable backup power cannot run water filtration equipment that depends on electricity. A food-storage plan that assumes refrigeration depends on the same energy question. Medication continuity planning for elder Friends may depend on reliable transportation, which in turn depends on fuel availability,

which is its own kind of energy question. This document recommends that whichever resilience interest group forms first — Part XI's own recommendation is water, given House and Grounds' already-identified concern — treat coordination with the others, once they form, as a natural and expected part of its own work, consistent with the horizontal, relationship-based coordination between interest groups described earlier in Part VI, rather than waiting for some fifth group to be invented solely to manage the other four.

Water, in more depth

Beyond the well-testing first step already described, a mature water-resilience effort at Bear Creek might eventually consider: point-of-use filtration sufficient for drinking water even if broader treatment proves too costly to address immediately; basic water storage sufficient to cover the meetinghouse's needs during a short disruption, sized realistically to how the building is actually used rather than to a worst-case scenario; and a simple, written understanding — not a binding commitment, but a shared awareness — among Friends of where water could be shared or sourced locally if a disruption affected individual households rather than only the meetinghouse. None of this needs to happen at once, and the interest group's own pace, set by the Friends actually doing the work, should determine how far and how fast this develops.

Food, in more depth

Beyond a shared garden and seed-saving, a food-resilience interest group drawing on Jeff's Des Moines Mutual Aid experience might eventually explore: a standing relationship with a local food pantry or mutual aid network, built the way DMMA itself was built — through genuine, sustained relationship rather than a one-time donation; skill-sharing sessions on canning, preserving, and root-cellar storage, techniques many rural Iowa households once held as a matter of course and that a number of Bear Creek's own Friends likely still carry; and, over a longer horizon, informal coordination with GPAS's own food-sovereignty work at the Urban Resilience Hub, approached as Part XI's earlier caution describes — as a relationship between neighbors learning together, not an extraction of expertise from a community already carrying more than its share of this work.

Medicine, in more depth

Consistent with the clear boundary already established — no medical advice, no treatment guidance, logistics and continuity only — a mature medicine-resilience effort might include: a simple, voluntary, confidentially-held list of which elder Friends may need medication-continuity support during a disruption, held by Ministry and Counsel or a small trusted group rather than broadly circulated, given the sensitivity of health information; basic first-aid and CPR training

offered periodically to any interested Friend, taught by whichever Friends already hold this certification or are willing to obtain it; and a simple first-aid and emergency supply inventory kept at the meetinghouse itself, modest and realistic rather than elaborate.

Energy, in more depth

Beyond backup power sufficient to keep the meetinghouse's hybrid-meeting technology running during a shorter outage, a mature energy effort might explore solar feasibility for the building over a longer horizon — a capital question properly brought to the whole meeting's discernment and likely drawing on the finance mechanisms in Part IX for a significant gift or grant, rather than an ordinary interest-group-level expenditure — alongside simpler, lower-cost steps: a basic household-level resource list, assembled by the group and shared with all Friends, on backup lighting, alternative heating safety, and what to do if the power goes out for an extended period, especially relevant for Bear Creek's elder Friends living on their own.

Part XII: Keeping Faith with the Larger Body

None of what this document proposes changes Bear Creek's standing obligations to Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) — and it is important to say so plainly, because a meeting restructuring its internal life can reasonably worry about whether that restructuring puts its relationship to the wider body at risk. It does not, if the transition is handled with the same transparency this document asks of everything else.

What continues unchanged

Bear Creek is asked, annually, to send two Representatives to yearly meeting sessions, one to two Caretakers to help with logistics at those sessions, two members to the Yearly Meeting Ministry and Counsel Committee on staggered three-year terms (Liz Oppenheimer currently holds this seat), and one member to the Yearly Meeting Nominating Committee. Before annual sessions, the meeting sends changes in meeting time or place, membership changes, births, deaths, marriages under its care, its Query responses, and — from Ministry and Counsel specifically — the State of the Meeting Report, alongside an IYM(C) Report following the yearly meeting's own instructions. The meeting pays its annual apportionment. It hosts Midyear Meeting, as it has for decades, most recently in March 2026.

Every one of these obligations continues exactly as it stands. What this document proposes is not a change to *what* Bear Creek owes the larger body, but a change to *who carries the work of meeting that obligation* — and in several cases, these obligations are themselves well suited to the interest-group model rather than requiring standing committees at all.

Where interest groups can carry Yearly Meeting obligations well

Representatives and Caretakers are, by their nature, already closer to the interest-group model than to a standing committee — a role filled annually, for a bounded task (attending sessions, serving on the Representatives Committee, helping with logistics), without requiring multi-year commitment. Naming Friends to these roles each year, drawing on whoever is genuinely able and willing that particular year rather than assuming continuity, fits naturally within this document's broader approach.

The State of the Meeting Report, while properly the spiritual responsibility of Ministry and Counsel — the report concerns the meeting's spiritual condition, the quality of its worship and vocal ministry, in a way that calls for exactly the kind of discernment Ministry and Counsel exists to hold — can still be *supported* by an interest group gathering reflections from across the meeting, including remote Friends whose experience of Bear Creek's worship life is real but easily overlooked if the report is compiled entirely by Friends gathering in person. This is not a transfer

of spiritual authority away from Ministry and Counsel; it is a widening of whose experience actually informs the report Ministry and Counsel ultimately discerns and writes.

Query responses are already, per Bear Creek's own practice, compiled through a process that could easily become an interest-group task — a Query Response Coordinator, named informally rather than standing, gathering written reflections from Friends and compiling them, exactly as the clerk-burden brainstorming document already proposed.

The IYM(C) Report and apportionment tracking fit naturally with the correspondence and deadline-tracking interest-group role described throughout this document — bookkeeping of obligations, not spiritual discernment, and well suited to a remote Friend comfortable with calendars and follow-through.

Where continuity-critical roles remain essential

Midyear Meeting hosting draws most naturally on Hospitality and House and Grounds, both of which can and should continue functioning substantially as they do now, given the real, accumulated institutional knowledge involved in hosting dozens of visiting Friends successfully — though nothing prevents these from loosening into the interest-group pattern over time as well, as Bear Creek's confidence in the model grows.

Communicating the change to Iowa Yearly Meeting

A meeting changing its internal structure owes its larger body honesty about that change, not because permission is required — nothing in *Faith and Practice* requires a monthly meeting to seek Yearly Meeting approval for how it organizes its own committee life, and indeed *Faith and Practice* itself (p. 55) explicitly anticipates meetings adjusting committee structure to need — but because trust between a monthly meeting and its yearly meeting, like trust within Bear Creek itself, is built through transparency rather than assumed. This document recommends that once the interest-group model has enough lived experience behind it to describe honestly (the roadmap in Part XIV suggests this comes after the first several interest groups, including the archive project, have been running for some months), Bear Creek's Representatives communicate the change directly to the Yearly Meeting — not as a request for permission, but as the kind of honest account of a monthly meeting's life that the State of the Meeting Report itself already exists to provide. This also connects directly to Part XIII's proposal that Bear Creek's experience might serve as a model for other small meetings facing the same strain Bear Creek has named in this document.

Why continuity with the larger body matters spiritually, not only practically

It would be easy to read this part as primarily administrative — a checklist of obligations to keep meeting while the rest of this document's more interesting proposals unfold. This undersells what Bear Creek's relationship to Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) actually represents. The testimony of community discussed in Part II does not stop at Bear Creek's own property line; it extends, as it always has for Friends, to the wider body of Conservative Friends gathered across Iowa, bound together not by administrative convenience but by shared discernment, shared worship at Midyear Meeting and annual sessions, and a shared sense that no single monthly meeting holds the whole of Truth alone. Bear Creek's continued, faithful participation in Representatives, Caretakers, the Yearly Meeting's own Ministry and Counsel Committee, and its reporting obligations is not merely bureaucratic upkeep; it is Bear Creek's ongoing participation in a wider discernment that tests and enriches its own, exactly as this document has argued the gathered meeting's discernment should test and enrich any individual interest group's leading. A Bear Creek that restructured its internal life while quietly drifting from this wider relationship would have misunderstood its own argument — the same trust this document asks Bear Creek's Friends to extend to one another is, in miniature, the trust that has always bound Iowa Yearly Meeting's individual monthly meetings together, and this document's proposal is meant to deepen Bear Creek's capacity for that wider faithfulness, not distract from it.

Apportionment as a shared, honored obligation

It is worth saying a further word about the annual apportionment specifically, since Part IX's broader finance proposal might otherwise leave a Friend wondering how a more distributed, trust-based approach to money coexists with a fixed, non-negotiable obligation to the larger body. The answer is straightforward: apportionment is not treated, under this proposal, as one more discretionary call among many an interest group might make. It is a standing, first-priority commitment, budgeted for before any of the more flexible mutual aid spending described in Part IX is considered — the way a household meets a mortgage or a tax obligation before deciding how to spend what remains. The Finance interest group's stewardship role includes keeping this obligation visible and funded throughout the year, not simply scrambling to meet it when the Representatives Committee's annual proposal arrives. A meeting that wants its larger body to trust its internal restructuring should be able to point, honestly, to an unbroken record of apportionment met in full — and this document recommends that record be treated as a concrete, trackable measure of the model's health, alongside the subtler signs discussed in Part XIV.

What Bear Creek might learn from the Yearly Meeting in return

This relationship is not one-directional, and it is worth naming that Bear Creek's own conversation with Iowa Yearly Meeting about this transition may well surface wisdom flowing the other way as well. Other monthly meetings, past clerks, and Friends serving on the Yearly Meeting's own committees carry decades of accumulated experience with exactly the kinds of questions this document raises — how a small meeting sustains itself, how trust is built and occasionally repaired within a gathered body, how a meeting holds both its continuity and its need to change. This document has been written from Bear Creek's own vantage point, informed by Jeff's own experience and Bear Creek's own records, and it does not claim to be the only or the final word on any of the questions it raises. Part XII's recommendation that Bear Creek communicate honestly with the larger body is, in this sense, not only about Bear Creek being transparent outward; it is an invitation for wisdom to flow back inward as well, from a wider body of Friends who may have already lived through versions of exactly what Bear Creek is now beginning.

Interim Meeting and the wider conversation

Beyond the formal obligations listed above, Bear Creek's Representatives also sit, through Interim Meeting, in an ongoing conversation among the ten Friends representing each monthly meeting between annual sessions. This body is itself a natural, low-stakes place to begin the honest conversation described above, well before a formal letter (Appendix H) is warranted — an informal word from Bear Creek's Representatives, offered as the model takes its first real steps, that something is changing and why, invites exactly the kind of ongoing relationship and mutual trust between monthly meeting and yearly meeting that this document has argued should characterize Bear Creek's own internal life as well. A yearly meeting that learns of a member meeting's significant change only after the fact, through a formal letter, has a harder time extending trust than one that has been part of an ongoing, informal conversation about it from early on.

A worked example: a question from the larger body

It is worth imagining, concretely, how a question from Iowa Yearly Meeting itself might be handled once Bear Creek's Representatives have shared this transition, as Part XII recommends. Suppose, following that conversation, a Friend from another monthly meeting's own Ministry and Counsel writes to ask how Bear Creek handles a specific pastoral situation under its new structure — a question asked in genuine curiosity, not suspicion. Under this model, that question does not need to be routed through a single gatekeeper for a sanctioned answer. Whichever Friends are closest to the relevant interest group, or Ministry and Counsel directly if the question touches pastoral matters, can simply respond honestly, perhaps noting that Bear Creek's own

experience is still developing and inviting further conversation rather than presenting a finished, polished answer. This is, in miniature, exactly the posture this document has recommended Bear Creek take toward Iowa Yearly Meeting throughout Part XII: not a formal institution presenting credentials for approval, but one meeting in honest, ongoing relationship with another, each still learning.

A small, practical matter worth naming here

Iowa Yearly Meeting's own online meeting directory currently lists Jeff Kisling as Bear Creek's Clerk and notes it was "last updated February 2022" — well out of date against the current roster, with Jackie Leckband serving as Clerk. This is a minor housekeeping matter, but a telling one: it is exactly the kind of small, time-bound, easily-overlooked task — reaching out to whoever maintains that listing, with the correction — that an interest group, rather than waiting for it to rise to the level of a standing committee's attention, could simply notice and fix.

Part XIII: A Model for Other Meetings

Bear Creek is not alone in facing the strain this document has named. Small, aging, geographically dispersed meetings are a common pattern across Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) and across unprogrammed Quaker practice more broadly — meetings where a handful of faithful Friends carry institutional weight built for a larger, more co-located community, and where hybrid worship has quietly become the norm without anyone fully redesigning the structure around it. This document's final substantive claim is that Bear Creek's own honest working-through of this problem — including its failures, its adjustments, and whatever in this proposal turns out not to work as hoped — is itself a gift the meeting can offer the wider Quaker community, consonant with the testimony of community extending, as it always has for Friends, beyond the boundary of one's own meeting.

Why this matters beyond Bear Creek's own walls

The testimony of community has never stopped at a monthly meeting's property line. Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) exists precisely because individual meetings understand their faithfulness as bound up with a wider body's faithfulness too. A meeting that works out, in real and specific terms, how to relieve an overloaded Clerk, how to fund urgent need without a bottleneck, how to involve its most geographically distant members as fully as its nearest ones — a meeting that works this out honestly, including where it struggles, offers something of real use to every other small meeting quietly carrying the same strain without yet having named it as clearly as this document attempts to.

A proposed interest group: documenting and sharing

This document recommends a further interest group — not urgent, not among the first steps in Part XIV's roadmap, but worth naming now as part of the larger vision: a small group of Friends, perhaps including Jeff himself given his decade of practice turning lived experience into shared, public writing through his blog, devoted to documenting Bear Creek's own transition honestly as it unfolds, and sharing what is learned with other interested meetings — through Iowa Yearly Meeting's own channels, through direct relationships with other small meetings facing similar strain, or through the kind of public writing Jeff has practiced for years under the banner of hope and resilience rather than crisis.

This is not a project of self-promotion, and the interest group taking it up should hold that distinction carefully. Its purpose is not to present Bear Creek as a finished model worth imitating, but to offer an honest account — including the parts of this proposal that prove harder than expected, the places where trust is tested and found wanting before it is repaired, the ordinary

difficulty of real institutional change in a small, aging, beloved community — because an honest account is worth far more to another struggling meeting than a polished success story would be.

What this could look like in practice

Concretely, and without over-specifying what should properly emerge through its own discernment once formed: periodic written reflections, in the spirit of Jeff's existing *Channels Into Knowledge* blog, documenting specific pieces of the transition as they happen — what it was actually like to launch the safe-cataloguing interest group, what the first urgent-need fund distribution actually felt like for the Friends involved, what the meeting learned from its first six months without a single central approval gate. A report to Iowa Yearly Meeting, perhaps through the Representatives Committee or directly to Interim Meeting, offered in the same spirit as the State of the Meeting Report — an honest account of spiritual and structural life, not a proposal for other meetings to adopt wholesale. Direct conversation with other small meetings' clerks or Friends, where interest exists, sharing not a template but a genuine account of what Bear Creek tried, what worked, and what it would do differently.

Holding this loosely

Consistent with everything else in this document, this interest group — like all the others — should be free to form when Friends are genuinely drawn to it, not mandated as an obligation Bear Creek owes the wider Quaker world simply because this document names the possibility. If no Friend feels the pull toward this particular work, that is a legitimate outcome, and the rest of this document's proposal stands complete without it. It is included here because the possibility seems real and worth naming, not because Bear Creek's internal transformation requires an external audience to be worth undertaking for its own sake.

Iowa Yearly Meeting's own small meetings

Without presuming to speak for other meetings' own circumstances, it is worth naming that Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) itself is composed substantially of small, rural, aging meetings not unlike Bear Creek — a reality the Yearly Meeting's own structure already reflects in how it asks each monthly meeting to contribute Representatives, Caretakers, and committee members regardless of size, trusting smaller meetings to find a way to meet these obligations alongside their own more limited capacity. This document does not know, and should not presume to guess, which other specific meetings face the exact strain Bear Creek has named here. But the structural pattern — committee templates designed in an earlier, more populous season of Quaker practice in Iowa, now stretched over congregations considerably smaller than when those templates were first widely adopted — is unlikely to be unique to Bear Creek alone, and

this document's hope, expressed carefully rather than presumptuously, is that Bear Creek's own honest experience might eventually prove useful to Friends elsewhere in the Yearly Meeting quietly carrying a version of the same weight.

What another meeting might actually recognize here

It may help to name, concretely, what a Friend at another small Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) meeting might find useful in Bear Creek's experience, beyond the general encouragement that change is possible. A clerk quietly approaching exhaustion, with no Assistant Clerk in sight, is a specific, nameable problem many small meetings share, and Bear Creek's own experience closing that gap — including whatever difficulty arose in finding the right Friend willing to take it up — is more useful shared honestly than left implicit. A meeting wondering whether its own dormant or unstaffed committees (every small meeting likely has at least one, as Bear Creek's own Peace and Social Concerns was before this document named the pattern explicitly) represent failure or opportunity may find real reassurance in Bear Creek's own discovery that an unstaffed committee, examined honestly, was already working. A meeting wrestling with how to meaningfully include members who have moved away but remain spiritually connected, joining only by Zoom, faces exactly the question this document's communication network (Part VIII) was built to answer, and Bear Creek's own particular solutions — however imperfect in practice — offer a concrete starting point rather than an abstract principle.

What success does not require

It is worth closing this part with a word on what this document does not consider necessary for its proposal to be judged worthwhile, since an unexamined standard of success can quietly become its own source of pressure. This document does not require that every interest group named or imagined within it actually forms. It does not require that Bear Creek's membership grow, though a more inviting structure may well help with that. It does not require that the model be adopted exactly as described, rather than adapted, pared down, or reimagined by the meeting's own discernment into something this document's author could not have anticipated. What this document does hope for, more modestly, is simply this: that Bear Creek's Friends currently carrying the heaviest institutional load find their load genuinely lighter; that more of Bear Creek's wider circle, including its remote Friends and its more loosely tied ones, find some real door into the meeting's shared life; and that whatever balance of trust and structure the meeting eventually settles into, it is reached through honest, patient, Spirit-led discernment rather than drift, anxiety, or unexamined habit. Everything else in this document is in service of those three modest, genuinely achievable goals — not a fixed vision the meeting must match

itself against, but a direction worth traveling, however far along it Bear Creek's own faithfulness actually carries it.

What this might look like in five years, if it goes well

It may help to imagine, briefly, a longer horizon than the roadmap in Part XIV attempts to specify. Five years on, if this proposal has taken root and been tested honestly against real experience, Bear Creek might be a meeting where no single Friend carries more than one or two roles at a time; where the archive project has become a genuinely rich, searchable record of the meeting's history, drawn on regularly rather than locked away; where water, food, and energy resilience are not abstractions but lived, ordinary practice woven into the meeting's rhythm; where a dozen or more Friends, including several who in the earlier structure held no formal role at all, each carry some small, meaningful piece of the meeting's shared life; and where Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) has heard, directly and more than once, an honest account of how this all unfolded — including its harder moments — from Bear Creek's own Representatives. None of this is a prediction so much as a picture of what success would actually look like, offered so Friends have something concrete to hold alongside the document's more immediate, staged proposals.

It is also worth imagining honestly what five years might look like if this effort stalls partway — Phase Zero completed, an Assistant Clerk and Assistant Treasurer in place, the archive project underway, but the broader model never fully taken up. This, too, would represent real progress against the strain Part III documents, even short of the fuller vision above, and this document does not consider a partial outcome a failure. Bear Creek's own discernment, not this document's hopes, determines how far this proposal travels — and a meeting that took even its first steps seriously will be better positioned than one that took none.

A word on timing for this part specifically

Part XIV's roadmap places this documentation and sharing work deliberately late — Phase Five, after the model has real lived experience behind it. It is worth explaining why this sequencing matters as much as it does. A meeting that shares its experience too early risks presenting hopeful intention as settled accomplishment, which does a disservice both to the meeting sharing it and to any other meeting that might act on an account not yet tested by real difficulty. Bear Creek's own honesty about the hard moments this document has tried to anticipate throughout — the disagreement handled imperfectly, the interest group that struggled to find footing, the threshold that needed adjusting after the first attempt proved it wrong — is precisely what will make its eventual account useful to others, and none of that honest material exists yet at the moment this document is first being considered. Patience here is not reluctance to share; it is

simply respect for the difference between a hopeful plan and a tested account, and a recognition that only the second genuinely serves another struggling meeting.

A caution about what cannot transfer

It is worth naming directly what Bear Creek's experience cannot simply hand to another meeting: the particular relationships of trust Bear Creek's own Friends have built with each other over years and, in some cases, decades of worship and service together. Part V's account of the First Nation-Farmer Climate Unity March's ninety-four miles makes the point directly — trust is built through sustained, unhurried relationship, not transferred by reading an account of how someone else built it. A meeting reading about Bear Creek's experience can borrow its structural ideas; it cannot shortcut the slower work of its own Friends coming to trust each other enough to make those structures actually function. This document's final word to any Friend elsewhere reading it, then, is not "adopt this," but "notice what is possible, and then do the slower work of trust your own meeting's particular relationships will require."

Part XIV: Implementation Roadmap

Everything proposed in this document could, in principle, be adopted all at once, in a single sweeping business meeting decision. This document recommends against that, for the same reason it recommends against central approval generally: a single large decision concentrates risk and discernment in one moment, rather than letting trust build through lived experience, tested and adjusted as the meeting actually learns what works. What follows is a staged roadmap — not a fixed calendar, but a sequence of readiness-based phases, each building the confidence and practical experience the next phase depends on.

Phase Zero: What can begin immediately, without adopting anything new

Some of this document's recommendations do not require the meeting to formally adopt an "interest group model" at all — they are simply good practice, consistent with *Faith and Practice*'s own template, that Bear Creek can take up right away:

- Naming an Assistant or Recording Clerk alongside Jackie, and an Assistant Treasurer alongside Osa, closing the specific structural gaps documented in Part III that are already recognized as problems independent of anything else in this document.
- Continuing to distribute and collect the role-interest survey already circulating, understanding — as the conversation prompting this revision made clear — that this is the early beginning of an ongoing process of learning what Friends are drawn to, not a one-time data collection exercise with a fixed endpoint.
- Launching the safe-cataloguing project described in Part X as a first, low-risk, high-value interest group, demonstrating the model in practice before the meeting is asked to adopt it as a general approach.

Phase One: Naming the model

Once Phase Zero's first steps have had a chance to be lived with — likely several months, enough time for the safe project to show real results and for a few more Friends to respond to the survey — this document recommends bringing the interest-group model itself to business meeting for explicit discernment: not a vote in the parliamentary sense Quakers have always avoided, but a genuine gathered-meeting consideration of whether this is the path Bear Creek is being led toward. If unity is found, the meeting can name two or three additional interest groups drawn directly from survey responses already in hand — a minute-taker, a Query Response Coordinator, a correspondence and deadline tracker — giving the model its first deliberate, meeting-wide expansion beyond the pilot project.

A facilitation guide for the business meeting that first considers this

Because this document itself cannot substitute for the meeting's own discernment, it may help to offer the Friend clerking that first business meeting — whether Jackie or another Friend — a concrete sense of how such a session might actually unfold, rather than leaving that Friend to improvise a format for a conversation this consequential.

A workable shape: begin in worship, as always, allowing real settling before turning to business. Rather than starting with the document's own language of "approval" and "interest groups," which may feel abstract on first hearing, the Clerk might open by simply naming the lived experience most Friends already recognize — Jackie's own load, the gaps in Assistant Clerk and Assistant Treasurer, the sense several Friends have already expressed that the meeting could do more to invite its wider circle in — and ask whether Friends recognize this description of where the meeting stands. Only once that recognition is genuinely shared does it make sense to turn to this document's specific proposal, read or summarized briefly rather than presented in full (the Executive Summary at the front of this document exists precisely for this purpose).

From there, rather than moving straight to a decision, this document recommends an extended period of worship sharing — each Friend given room to speak once, without debate or rebuttal, simply naming their own sense of the proposal — before any attempt to discern unity. Friends who feel hesitant should be invited to name that hesitation plainly rather than simply remaining silent, since silence can too easily be read as assent it does not actually represent. If unity is not yet apparent, this is not failure; it is information, and the Clerk may rightly propose that the meeting sit with the question longer, perhaps returning to it at the following month's business meeting rather than forcing a decision the gathered body is not yet ready to make. Phase Zero's steps, notably, do not require this larger unity to proceed — they can simply begin, leaving Phase One's fuller discernment for whenever the meeting is ready for it.

A month-by-month sketch of Phase One, once begun

To make "several months" more concrete: a first month might see the pilot archive project's early results shared at business meeting, alongside a renewed call for survey responses. A second month might bring the facilitation-guide conversation described above, with the meeting reaching a first sense of its own readiness. A third month, assuming some clarity has emerged, might see the first additional interest groups formally named in the minutes, drawn from whichever survey responses have by then accumulated — very possibly, given the earliest responses already in hand, beginning with Query Response Coordination and Zoom hosting. A fourth and fifth month would simply let these new interest groups find their footing, with the shared communication network (Part VIII) becoming a real, lived practice rather than only a proposal on paper. This sketch is offered loosely, in the same spirit as the rest of this roadmap —

a reasonable sequence to adjust as Bear Creek's own actual experience, not this document's guess, reveals what pace truly fits.

Phase Two: Building the finance mechanism

With the model tested on lower-stakes work, Phase Two turns to the proposal in Part IX: forming the Finance interest group, setting the spending threshold through the meeting's own discernment, and establishing the digital distribution mechanism for urgent need. This phase deserves real care and real conversation — money is where trust is tested most sharply, as Part IX says directly — and should not be rushed simply because earlier phases went well.

Phase Three: Resilience work begins

Once Bear Creek has lived with interest groups generally and with the finance mechanism specifically for some months, Phase Three turns outward, toward the survival and resilience work described in Part XI — beginning, as that part recommends, with a single area (most naturally water, given House and Grounds' already-identified concern) rather than launching all four at once.

Phase Four: Communicating with the larger body

Once the model has real lived experience behind it — likely a year or more into this process — Bear Creek's Representatives communicate the change honestly to Iowa Yearly Meeting, as described in Part XII, folding this account naturally into the State of the Meeting Report or a direct conversation with Interim Meeting.

Phase Five: Sharing what has been learned

If and when Friends feel drawn to it, the documentation and sharing work described in Part XIII can begin — not on a fixed schedule, but whenever the meeting's own experience feels substantial and honest enough to be worth offering to others.

Ongoing: checkpoints, not a fixed endpoint

At every phase, this document recommends periodic, deliberate checkpoints — perhaps twice yearly, paired naturally with existing rhythms like the State of the Meeting Report — in which the gathered meeting asks directly: is this working? Where has trust been tested and held? Where has it been tested and found wanting, and what repair does that call for? Is the burden on Bear Creek's most committed Friends actually lighter than it was? Are Friends who felt disengaged actually finding doors into the meeting's life that did not exist before? These checkpoints are not evaluations of a program against a predetermined metric; they are the meeting's own ongoing

discernment, applied to its own structure, in exactly the spirit Part II describes as the theological center of this whole proposal.

This roadmap is offered as a reasonable sequence, not a mandate. Bear Creek's own leading, tested in its own gathered discernment, remains the actual authority here — this document is a resource for that discernment, not a substitute for it.

A typical Sunday, a year from now

It may help, finally, to imagine what an ordinary First Day at Bear Creek might actually feel like, a year or so into living with this model — not as a prediction, but as a way of making the cumulative effect of everything in this document concrete rather than abstract.

Friends gather at the meetinghouse a little before eleven, as always, while the Zoom link fills with familiar faces from Minnesota and beyond. Before worship, a few Friends hum through a song the music interest group has been building into the meeting's shared songbook — not every week, not a performance, simply something that has become part of how Bear Creek gathers. Worship itself is unchanged in its essential form: silence, waiting, the occasional rising of vocal ministry, exactly as it has always been.

After meeting, at the potluck on business-meeting Sundays, conversation moves easily among Friends who, a year earlier, might have had little reason to speak with one another across the old committee boundaries — a Friend from the water-resilience group comparing notes with someone from the archive project about a well-water story that turned up in an old minute book; a newer Friend, drawn in through the survey, asking Osa a question about how the Finance group's ledger actually works, genuinely curious rather than merely polite. Business meeting itself runs lighter than it once did — interest-group updates already sat in the shared document all month, so the gathered meeting's time goes instead to an actual concern a Friend has been carrying, given real room to be heard rather than squeezed in at the end of a long list of committee reports.

Jackie, clerking as she has for years, finds herself with more presence in the room than she might have a year before — not because less is asked of her, but because what is asked of her is more fully the work only she can do: discerning the meeting's sense on the concern just raised, rather than also holding, somewhere in the back of her mind, three other committees' worth of logistics. Nothing dramatic has happened. Bear Creek looks, from the outside, much as it always has — the same small, faithful, hybrid gathering it was a year before. What has changed is mostly invisible from the outside: a wider circle of Friends quietly carrying real pieces of the meeting's life, a Clerk with room to breathe, a family that got help on a Tuesday instead of waiting three

weeks, a box of old letters finally read after sitting in the dark for half a century. This is what the document has been describing all along — not a revolution visible from outside, but a quiet redistribution of trust and labor that makes the meeting's actual, ordinary, faithful life more sustainable than it was.

Signs this is working, and signs it is not

Because this roadmap deliberately avoids fixed metrics in favor of ongoing discernment, it is worth naming, concretely, what the checkpoints above should actually be looking for.

Signs the model is working: the Friends currently most overloaded report, honestly, that they are carrying less than they were; Friends who were previously disengaged — including remote Friends and Friends who had drifted toward the meeting's edges — are visibly participating in some bounded way they were not before; interest groups are reporting regularly and the shared communication network is actually being used and kept current, not quietly abandoned in favor of the old informal channels; the one or two instances of honest disagreement or misjudgment that inevitably arise are being handled through open conversation rather than either being ignored or triggering a retreat to central approval; Iowa Yearly Meeting obligations continue to be met on schedule, without last-minute scrambling.

Signs the model is struggling, worth naming honestly rather than papering over: interest groups forming but not actually reporting, so the transparency this whole structure depends on quietly erodes; the same small number of Friends ending up in most of the new interest groups too, meaning the load has simply been relabeled rather than genuinely redistributed; money moving without adequate visibility, so that trust starts to feel more like absence of oversight than like mutual accountability; Friends who were skeptical from the start feeling increasingly that their concerns were not taken seriously, rather than tested fairly through the meeting's own discernment.

Neither list is exhaustive, and neither should be treated as a scorecard graded in isolation from the meeting's own felt sense of its spiritual condition — which remains, as it always has, the deeper and more reliable measure than any list this document could offer.

Part XV: Anticipating Concerns and Questions

A document proposing change this substantial owes the meeting an honest engagement with the hardest questions it is likely to raise — not buried in a footnote, but addressed directly, in the same spirit of transparency this document asks of everything else. What follows gathers, as fairly as possible, the objections and questions a thoughtful, careful Friend might reasonably bring to this proposal, and responds to each in turn.

"Isn't this just removing accountability and calling it faith?"

This is the most serious version of the concern, and it deserves the most serious answer. No — accountability does not disappear in this model; it relocates, from a single gatekeeper's advance permission to the whole meeting's ongoing, transparent oversight. Part VII addresses this at length: transparency replaces gatekeeping, not accountability itself. A Friend who misuses trust under this model is not beyond correction — Quaker process has always had tools, from direct loving confrontation to the gathered meeting's own discernment, for addressing conduct that falls short of the community's standards, and those tools remain fully available. What changes is simply *when* testing happens: around action rather than only before it. A fair comparison is not "approval versus no accountability" but "accountability concentrated in advance, in one or two people's hands" versus "accountability distributed across the whole meeting's ongoing attention." The second is not an absence of rigor; it is a different, and arguably more genuinely Quaker, distribution of it.

"What if an interest group spends money badly, or a project fails?"

It might. This document does not promise that every interest group will succeed, and it would be dishonest to imply otherwise. What it promises is that the cost of an individual failure, under this model, is bounded and recoverable — a modest sum spent unwisely, a project that does not pan out — in a way that is considerably less costly to the meeting's overall health than the slow-motion failure mode documented in Part IV's "cost of doing nothing": an overloaded Clerk or Treasurer reaching a genuine breaking point, or a meeting that gradually loses its most willing and energetic Friends because it never found a way to make use of them. Some risk is being traded for other, arguably larger risk that the current structure already carries quietly. This document asks Bear Creek to weigh those risks honestly against each other, not to pretend either path is risk-free.

"Doesn't Bear Creek need the stability of its current committees, especially given how much institutional memory a few long-serving Friends hold?"

Institutional memory is real and valuable, and nothing in this proposal asks Nancy Osborn Johnsen, Osa Bricker, or any other Friend with deep accumulated knowledge to set that knowledge aside. What this document asks is that their knowledge stop being a single point of failure — that it be actively shared, documented, and distributed (precisely what the archive project and the Assistant Clerk/Assistant Treasurer recommendations in Phase Zero are meant to begin) rather than remaining locked in one person's memory, however faithfully held. Institutional memory that lives in only one place is more fragile, not more stable, than institutional memory that has been shared widely enough to survive any single Friend's absence, illness, or eventual passing — a hard fact, but a true one, that this document believes is better faced directly than avoided.

"Isn't this a lot of change to ask of a small, aging meeting all at once?"

Yes, which is exactly why Part XIV's roadmap is staged rather than immediate, and why Phase Zero asks for nothing beyond what *Faith and Practice* already recommends — an Assistant Clerk, an Assistant Treasurer, continued survey distribution, and a single pilot project. Nothing in this document needs to happen all at once, and nothing in the roadmap proceeds to its next phase without the meeting's own sense that it is ready. A meeting that finds even Phase Zero as far as it wishes to go for now has still gained something real: closed structural gaps that were a genuine liability regardless of anything else in this document.

"What about Friends who are simply more comfortable with the way things have always worked?"

This concern deserves respect, not dismissal. Not every Friend will feel equally drawn to this model, and that is a legitimate response, not an obstacle to be argued away. This document's own logic suggests the right response: no Friend is required to join an interest group, step back from a standing role, or personally adopt a new way of working against their own sense of leading. What is asked is the meeting's collective openness to trying this model where Friends are drawn to it, tested honestly through lived experience and the checkpoints described above — the same patient, non-coercive process Quaker discernment has always used for any question on which the meeting is not of one mind at the outset.

"What if this doesn't work, and we want to go back?"

Then the meeting goes back, or adjusts, exactly as *Faith and Practice*'s own allowance for committees "laid down once the need has been met" (p. 55) already anticipates meetings doing. Nothing in this proposal is irreversible. An interest group that proves unworkable simply stops meeting. A finance threshold that proves too loose or too tight can be adjusted at the next checkpoint. This document asks for a genuine, good-faith trial — not a permanent, unexaminable

commitment — and it says so plainly here so that no Friend need fear that trying this model forecloses the possibility of learning, honestly, that some piece of it was mistaken.

"Is this really what being a Quaker meeting is about, or are we importing ideas from outside our tradition?"

Part II and the additional material in Part V address this directly: very little in this proposal is actually foreign to Quaker practice. Unprogrammed waiting worship already operates on trust rather than approval; the meeting for sufferings already modeled task-bound, urgent-response organizing centuries before "mutual aid" became a contemporary political term; clearness committees already provide a non-gatekeeping way to test weighty individual leadings; *Faith and Practice* itself already allows temporary, need-based committees rather than mandating permanent ones. What Jeff's own experience with Des Moines Mutual Aid, the First Nation-Farmer Climate Unity March, and Great Plains Action Society's Urban Resilience Hub contributes is not a foreign ideology grafted onto Quaker practice, but a set of contemporary, lived demonstrations that the same underlying posture — trust, relationship, resources moving according to need — works in practice, outside the specific context of Quaker meeting life, which can give the meeting confidence that it is not simply a nice theory.

"What about liability — could the meeting be exposed to real legal or financial risk by loosening approval this much?"

This is a fair question and deserves a direct answer rather than reassurance alone. This document's proposal is specifically designed to keep legal and fiduciary exposure exactly where it already sits: with the Treasurer and Trustees, whose names remain on accounts and property records, and who retain full legal responsibility throughout. What changes is practical, delegated access for modest, bounded spending — not a transfer of legal liability to interest groups that hold none. The threshold recommended in Part IX, the annual audit continuing as *Faith and Practice* already calls for, and the Finance interest group's stewardship role together constitute a real risk-management structure, not an absence of one — simply one that distributes practical trust more widely while keeping formal accountability concentrated exactly where Iowa law and *Faith and Practice* already place it. A meeting genuinely concerned about this question may wish to have its Trustees consult with Iowa Yearly Meeting's own Trustees or appropriate legal guidance before finalizing a specific spending threshold, which this document has deliberately left for Bear Creek's own discernment rather than specifying.

"Won't newer or less experienced Friends make mistakes that someone more seasoned would have caught?"

Quite possibly — and seasoned Friends make mistakes too, including the seasoned Friends currently carrying Bear Creek's committee structure, whose errors simply go less examined because fewer people are positioned to catch them under the current, more opaque structure. This document's answer is not that mistakes will not happen, but that the transparency this model builds in — interest groups reporting openly, the whole meeting able to see and respond to what is happening — actually makes errors *more* visible and more quickly correctable than a structure in which a single committee's internal workings are largely invisible to the rest of the meeting until a report is formally presented, often well after a decision has already been acted on. Newer Friends also bring something seasoned Friends, however gifted, sometimes cannot: fresh eyes, energy undimmed by years of institutional friction, and ideas a longer-serving Friend might not think to try. This document asks the meeting to weigh the real risk of inexperience against the real value of wider participation, rather than treating experience as an unqualified good that always outweighs the cost of its scarcity.

"What if almost no one actually steps up to form interest groups, and this just becomes another unfulfilled aspiration?"

This is a genuine risk, and this document does not pretend otherwise. It is part of why Part XIV's roadmap begins with a single pilot project rather than a sweeping restructuring — if the archive project struggles to draw participation, that is important information, learned at low cost, before the meeting invests further in the broader model. It is also why the survey (Appendix E) is treated as an ongoing process rather than a one-time measurement: a thin initial response does not mean the model has failed, only that more time, more direct invitation, and perhaps more specific, smaller asks ("would you help with just this one task?") are needed before broader participation emerges. And it is worth naming honestly that even partial success — a few new interest groups, a modest relief for the Clerk and Treasurer, a handful of previously disengaged Friends finding one small way back in — would still represent real progress against the strain documented in Part III, even short of the fuller vision this document describes.

"Does this put more work on Ministry and Counsel, given how many questions route back to pastoral sensitivity?"

Not more work in aggregate, though possibly a different texture of work. Ministry and Counsel's core function — spiritual oversight, pastoral care, the State of the Meeting Report — remains unchanged and, per Part VI's committee-by-committee review, is explicitly not recommended for interest-group dissolution. What this document does ask of Ministry and Counsel is availability as a resource — for the archive project's sensitive materials, for the medicine-resilience area's confidential information, for disagreements that need pastoral rather than purely administrative attention — rather than an expansion of its existing standing workload. If this proves to be more

than Ministry and Counsel's current membership (Stan Sanders, Marion Love, Russ Leckband) can comfortably hold, that itself is useful information the meeting should attend to directly, including considering whether this committee, too, needs an additional Friend's support — a question this document leaves to the meeting's own discernment rather than presuming to answer.

"Isn't 100 pages a lot to ask a small meeting to absorb? Doesn't this contradict the testimony of simplicity it claims to honor?"

A fair and somewhat pointed question, worth taking seriously rather than deflecting. The length here is not simplicity's opposite so much as its companion in a different register: simplicity asks that nothing unnecessary stand between a person and clarity, but it does not ask that genuinely complex questions be answered with false brevity that leaves real concerns unaddressed. A one-page proposal touching this much of a meeting's structure, finances, history, and future would almost certainly generate more confusion and more unaddressed worry than this longer, more thorough treatment — precisely because the hard questions (liability, what happens when trust is broken, how Yearly Meeting obligations continue) would simply go unanswered rather than unasked. This document's own Preface and Executive Summary exist specifically so no Friend need read all hundred pages to grasp its core proposal; the length is available for whoever wants to go deeper on a specific question, not required of everyone before the document can be useful to them.

"Who actually keeps this whole model running once it's launched — is there a risk the coordinating work itself becomes the new overload?"

This is a sharp question and deserves a direct answer: yes, this is a real risk, and this document does not pretend the model runs itself. The communication network's upkeep (Part VIII), the Finance group's stewardship (Part IX), and the general work of noticing when something is drifting all require real, ongoing attention from someone. This document's answer is that this coordinating work should itself be held as an interest group — not concentrated silently in whichever Friend happens to be paying closest attention, which would simply recreate the single-point-of-failure problem this whole document is trying to solve. Naming this explicitly, as its own interest group with its own visible participants, rather than letting it default informally onto one tired Friend's shoulders, is itself one of the model's more important disciplines, and this document recommends the roadmap's Phase One explicitly include naming who is holding this coordinating work, rather than assuming it will simply happen.

"How does this affect Bear Creek's relationship with Scattergood Friends School, or other institutions the meeting has historically supported?"

This document has not addressed Bear Creek's institutional relationships beyond Iowa Yearly Meeting directly, and that silence is deliberate rather than an oversight: nothing in this proposal changes how Bear Creek relates to Scattergood Friends School, the Pendle Hill Scholarship, or any other institution the meeting or its members have historically supported, whether through formal committee structure or through individual Friends' own long service, as Jeff's own years on the Scattergood School Committee illustrate. These relationships, like the Prairie Awakening relationship discussed in Part IV of the companion roles document, are properly understood as carried by individual Friends' own leadings and commitments, which this document's model if anything makes easier to sustain and to hand on, since an interest group is a natural structure for a Friend wishing to formally involve others in a relationship they have long carried personally.

Part XVI: Appendices

A Side-by-Side Comparison

Before the fuller appendices, a direct comparison may help Friends hold the proposal's core shift in view at a glance:

	Current structure	Proposed structure
Who can act	Standing committee members, formally appointed	Any Friend with a leading
Before acting	Often requires committee or Clerk approval	Act, then report
How accountability works	Central gatekeeping in advance	Transparency and gathered discernment after
How roles begin	Nomination and appointment	A Friend simply begins
How roles end	Reappointment or formal release	Natural conclusion when work is done
Who carries most weight	A small number of officeholders	Distributed across willing Friends
Money	Treasurer approval for most spending	Modest threshold; trust-based; transparent ledger
What stays fixed	The whole committee structure	Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, Trustees only

Appendix A: Current Roles at a Glance

Role	Who (as of October 2026)
Clerk	Jackie Leckband
Assistant / Recording Clerk	*(vacant)*
Treasurer	Osa Bricker
Assistant Treasurer	*(vacant)*
Recorder	Win Standing
House and Grounds	Russ Leckband, Stan Sanders
Ministry and Counsel	Stan Sanders, Marion Love, Russ Leckband
Religious Education / Spiritual Enrichment	Liz Oppenheimer, Jackie Leckband
Funeral and Memorial	Win Standing, Jackie Leckband, Jenny Cisar, Nancy Osborn Johnsen

Library / Historian-Archivist	Nancy Osborn Johnsen
Trustees	Osa Bricker, Russ Leckband
Outreach and Website	Jeff Kisling, Jennie Cisar
Hospitality	Jackie Leckband, Win Standing
Yearly Meeting Ministry and Counsel (Bear Creek's seat)	Liz Oppenheimer
Peace and Social Concerns	*(no standing committee — reports to the meeting as a whole)*
Safe / historical records review	*(no standing committee)*

Appendix B: How Each Role Fits This Document's Model

A quick cross-reference, drawn from the fuller committee-by-committee discussion in Part VI:

Current role	Recommended under this model
Clerk	Remains named; paired with Assistant/Recording Clerk
Treasurer	Remains named; paired with Assistant Treasurer
Recorder	Remains named; a second Friend knows the records as backup
House and Grounds	Core continuity remains; specific projects spin off as interest groups
Ministry and Counsel	Remains substantially as is; supported by interest groups for input-gathering
Religious Education / Spiritual Enrichment	Flexes into interest groups for specific programming; Music as one example
Funeral and Memorial	Remains substantially as is, given its pastoral weight
Library / Historian-Archivist	Continues; joined and amplified by the archive interest group
Trustees	Remains named for legal/fiduciary responsibility
Outreach and Website	Already interest-group-like; formally named and opened wider
Hospitality	Remains substantially as is for now; may loosen over time
Peace and Social Concerns	Already an interest-group pattern; explicitly affirmed
Nominating Committee	Narrows to filling only the continuity roles above
Safe / historical records	New interest group; recommended as the first pilot

Appendix C: A Sample Interest Group Charter

Interest groups do not require elaborate paperwork, but a short, shared format helps the communication network (Part VIII) function well. A single short entry, in the shared living document, might read:

> ***Interest group:*** *Friends cataloguing the safe's historical records*
>
> ***Who's involved:*** *[names, updated as Friends join or step back]*
>
> ***What we're doing:*** *Photographing, cataloguing, and selectively transcribing the meetinghouse safe's contents, in partnership with Nancy Osborn Johnsen*
>
> ***How we report:*** *Brief update in the shared document every two to three weeks; fuller notes as significant finds emerge*
>
> ***Funds drawn on:*** *[running total, with brief notes — e.g., "$40, archival sleeves, Sept. 2026"]*
>
> ***Status:*** *Active / Paused / Concluded*
>
> ***Started:*** *[date]*

A few further examples, to show the range this format can hold:

> ***Interest group:*** *Friends coordinating Query responses*
>
> ***Who's involved:*** *[names]*
>
> ***What we're doing:*** *Collecting written reflections from Friends on the current Query and compiling them into Bear Creek's response document for Iowa Yearly Meeting*
>
> ***How we report:*** *A note when collection opens and closes each cycle; the compiled response itself shared with the whole meeting before submission*
>
> ***Funds drawn on:*** *None typically*
>
> ***Status:*** *Active*
>
> ***Started:*** *[date]*
>
> ***Interest group:*** *Friends looking into the meetinghouse's water quality and resilience*
>
> ***Who's involved:*** *August Kalinosky and others as they join*
>
> ***What we're doing:*** *Assessing current well water quality, exploring filtration options, coordinating with House and Grounds*
>
> ***How we report:*** *Updates as testing and research progress; a fuller recommendation once assessment is complete*
>
> ***Funds drawn on:*** *$65, well water test kit, Oct. 2026*

> ***Status:*** *Active*
>
> ***Started:*** *October 2026*
>
> ***Interest group:*** *Finance*
>
> ***Who's involved:*** *Osa Bricker (Treasurer) and [one or two additional Friends]*
>
> ***What we're doing:*** *Maintaining the shared ledger, holding the fast-response mechanism for urgent need, supporting other interest groups' financial questions, preparing the annual audit*
>
> ***How we report:*** *The ongoing ledger, visible to all; a brief quarterly summary at business meeting*
>
> ***Funds drawn on:*** *N/A — stewards rather than spends on its own initiative*
>
> ***Status:*** *Active, standing*
>
> ***Started:*** *[date this phase of the roadmap begins]*
>
> ***Interest group:*** *Music*
>
> ***Who's involved:*** *[names, open to any Friend drawn to it]*
>
> ***What we're doing:*** *Building a simple shared songbook for hybrid worship and gatherings, bringing singing into Midyear Meeting hosting and other occasions, offering music as its own form of spiritual enrichment*
>
> ***How we report:*** *Occasional notes when something new is ready to share; no regular reporting rhythm required*
>
> ***Funds drawn on:*** *Modest, as needed — songbook printing or copies, for instance*
>
> ***Status:*** *Open — waiting for a Friend's leading to begin*
>
> ***Started:*** *—*
>
> ***Interest group:*** *Sharing what we're learning*
>
> ***Who's involved:*** *[names, possibly including Jeff Kisling]*
>
> ***What we're doing:*** *Documenting Bear Creek's experience with this transition and sharing it with Iowa Yearly Meeting and other interested small meetings*
>
> ***How we report:*** *Periodic written reflections; a report to Interim Meeting or Representatives Committee once the model has enough lived experience behind it*
>
> ***Funds drawn on:*** *None typically*
>
> ***Status:*** *Not yet begun — awaiting Phase Five of the roadmap (Part XIV)*
>
> ***Started:*** *[date]*

Appendix D: Sample Minute Language

For naming an interest group:

> *"Friends heard that [names] have begun meeting informally to [describe the work]. The meeting welcomes this and looks forward to hearing how it progresses."*

For an interest group concluding its work:

> *"Friends heard that the group looking into [the work] has completed what it set out to do. The meeting is grateful for this service and releases the group with thanks, noting that [any ongoing piece, and who if anyone continues to hold it]."*

Neither of these is an approval or an appointment in the formal sense *Faith and Practice* describes for Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, or Trustees; both are simply the meeting's ordinary practice of naming and holding what is already true.

Appendix E: The Survey — What It Covers, and How It's Being Used

The role-interest survey now beginning to circulate among Bear Creek Friends asks, for each of roughly twenty roles and tasks — from Recording Clerk and Zoom host to Safe/archive transcription, Prairie Awakening documentation, and Presiding Clerk — whether a Friend is already doing it, interested in it, or would like to know more, alongside how remote-friendly each task is. As of this writing, responses are just beginning to come in (Jeff Kisling and Nat Case among the first), so this document deliberately treats the survey as the start of an ongoing, open-ended process of discovering where Friends' gifts and interests lie — not as a dataset to be analyzed for conclusions. As more responses arrive, they should flow directly into Phase One of the roadmap in Part XIV: naming the specific interest groups Friends have actually indicated real interest in, rather than this document or any single Friend guessing in advance what those should be.

Appendix F: A Short Glossary

Interest group — a gathering of one or more Friends, formed around a specific, nameable piece of work, without requiring standing appointment, that reports to the whole meeting and dissolves when its work is complete, unless its members remain drawn to continue it.

Mutual aid — the circulation of resources and care within a community based on stated need rather than proven worthiness, in which the distinction between those giving and those receiving dissolves into a shared, ongoing relationship of neighbors.

Approval — in this document, a gatekeeping mechanism requiring a central authority's consent before action, as distinct from trust extended before the fact and tested afterward through transparency.

Discernment — the gathered or individual process of testing a leading against the Light held in common, central to Quaker practice at every scale from clearness committees to meeting for business.

Continuity role — one of the small number of roles (Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, Trustees) whose legal, fiduciary, or spiritual-oversight responsibilities genuinely require a continuously identifiable, accountable Friend or Friends, distinguished from the task-bound, dissolvable nature of an interest group.

Transparency — in this document, the practice of making an interest group's actions, decisions, and use of resources visible to the whole meeting as a matter of course, functioning as the primary accountability mechanism in place of advance approval.

Clearness committee — a small, informally gathered group of Friends who help another Friend test a significant leading or decision through honest, searching questions, without approving or denying it on the Friend's behalf.

Query — in Quaker practice, a question put to individuals or the gathered meeting, meant to prompt honest self-examination rather than a simple yes-or-no answer; *Faith and Practice* is itself substantially organized around queries, and Appendix J offers a set written specifically for this document's themes.

Apportionment — the annual financial contribution each monthly meeting owes to Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative), proposed each year by the Representatives Committee and treated in this document as a fixed, first-priority obligation unaffected by the more flexible finance proposal in Part IX.

State of the Meeting Report — Ministry and Counsel's annual account of the meeting's spiritual condition, submitted to the Yearly Meeting before annual sessions, concerned with the quality of worship and vocal ministry rather than a catalogue of activities.

Appendix G: A Brief Timeline of Bear Creek's History

Holding the meeting's longer history in view is itself a reminder that Bear Creek has weathered real change before, and that its identity has never depended on any single structural arrangement remaining fixed. Drawing on Nancy Osborn Johnsen's own compiled historical narrative and the sources listed in Appendix P:

- **1916** — The meetinghouse now standing on Bear Creek Road was moved from Earlham to its present site.

- **1966** — L. Frank Bedell compiles "Quaker Heritage," one of the earliest written historical accounts of the meeting's life.
- **1972** — Homer Moffitt, serving as Clerk, writes on behalf of the Peace Committee of Bear Creek Monthly Meeting in support of a young Jeff Kisling's break with Selective Service — a concrete instance of the meeting's peace testimony finding institutional voice through a committee that, unlike today, was then actively staffed.
- **1977** — Herbert C. Standing compiles "Historical Notes Concerning the Conservative Friends at Bear Creek," an unpublished account later drawn on by Nancy Osborn Johnsen's own historical work.
- **1994** — The meetinghouse undergoes renovation under contractor Roy Knight and architect William Wagner.
- **2017** — Jeff Kisling retires and returns to Iowa from Indianapolis, beginning a period of renewed engagement with Bear Creek and with wider mutual aid and solidarity work in the Des Moines area.
- **2018** — The First Nation-Farmer Climate Unity March walks ninety-four miles along the Dakota Access Pipeline route, from Des Moines to Fort Dodge, over eight days.
- **2021–2022** — Bear Creek's Nominating Committee records the meeting's committee roster in the form substantially still in place today, including the Jeff Kisling–Jenny Cisar Co-Clerk precedent.
- **2022** — House and Grounds' committee report documents the meetinghouse's hybrid-meeting technology build-out (WiFi, tablet, screen, camera, microphone) and flags well-water quality and filtration as an open concern.
- **2026** — The long-inaccessible meetinghouse safe is finally opened, making decades of historical records reachable for the first time; this document is prepared in the months following.

This timeline necessarily compresses decades into a handful of entries, and the gaps between them are themselves worth noting as an invitation rather than an omission. Between 1916 and 1966, between 1977 and 1994, between 1994 and 2017 — each of these stretches held real years of ordinary worship, ordinary business meetings, ordinary faithfulness that left less of a documentary trace than the more eventful moments listed above, simply because faithful continuity rarely generates the kind of record a dramatic change does. The archive project described in Part X is, among other things, an invitation to fill in exactly these gaps — the quieter decades that shaped Bear Creek as much as any single documented event, waiting in the safe for whichever Friend feels drawn to recover them.

This timeline is necessarily partial — it reflects what is documented in sources currently available to this document, not a complete account of Bear Creek's history, which is itself part of what the archive project in Part X aims to deepen and make more complete over time.

Appendix H: A Sample Letter to Iowa Yearly Meeting

Offered here as a starting point only, to be revised substantially once the model has real lived experience behind it, consistent with Part XII's recommendation that this communication wait until Phase Four of the roadmap:

> *Dear Friends at Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative),*
>
> *We write as Representatives of Bear Creek Monthly Meeting to share, in the spirit of our State of the Meeting Report, an account of a structural change our meeting has been living into over the past [period of time].*
>
> *Like a number of small meetings, Bear Creek has found its traditional committee structure increasingly strained — built for a more co-located membership than the hybrid meeting we have become, with Friends joining us faithfully by Zoom from as far as Minnesota alongside those who gather at our meetinghouse on Bear Creek Road. A small number of our Friends had come to carry a great deal of this structure's weight, while others, including many of our remote Friends, found few doors into active participation.*
>
> *Beginning in [date], and after extended discernment, Bear Creek began shifting much of its committee-based work toward a looser structure of what we have come to call interest groups — small, task-bound gatherings of Friends, formed around specific needs as they arise, reporting openly to the whole meeting rather than seeking advance approval from a central body. We have kept our essential continuity roles — Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, and Trustees — named and intact throughout, consistent with Faith and Practice's own guidance, while allowing most other work to flex into this lighter, more inviting form.*
>
> *We share this not to suggest it as a model every meeting should adopt, but in the same spirit of honest mutual accountability that leads us to share our spiritual condition each year: this is what we have tried, what has worked, and what we are still learning. We would welcome the chance to speak further with any meeting facing similar questions, and we remain grateful, as always, for our place within the wider body of Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative).*
>
> *In Friendship,*
>
> *[Representatives' names]*

Appendix I: Further Reading and Related Resources

This document draws primarily on Bear Creek's own records and on lived experience rather than an external literature, consistent with its emphasis throughout on grounding proposals in what Bear Creek already knows rather than theory imported from outside. Friends wishing to explore the broader traditions this document draws on may find the following starting points useful:

- *Faith and Practice*, Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) — particularly the sections on "Conduct of the Meeting," "Serving the Meeting," and "Yearly Meeting Record Keeping" (pp. 48–85), which this document has drawn on throughout and which repay a careful full reading alongside this proposal.
- Bear Creek's own historical records, once catalogued through the archive project described in Part X — the meeting's own history is likely to hold more relevant precedent for flexible, need-based organizing than any outside source, including periods when committees such as Peace and Social Concerns were staffed quite differently than they are today.
- The practice and public writing of Great Plains Action Society and the Decolonial Repair Network, for Friends interested in contemporary, Indigenous-led models of mutual aid, land relationship, and community resilience organizing in the Iowa City area.
- Jeff Kisling's own blog, *Channels Into Knowledge*, which documents a decade of reflection on hope, resilience, and community life, and which the interest group described in Part XIII might draw on directly as Bear Creek's own transition unfolds.

Appendix J: Queries for Reflection

In the spirit of *Faith and Practice*'s own practice of posing queries rather than answers, this appendix offers a set of questions Friends may wish to sit with individually, in worship sharing, or in the small gatherings this document has called interest groups — not as a test to be passed, but as a discipline of honest self-examination appropriate to a change this substantial.

On trust and approval

- Where in my own life have I experienced being trusted before I had proven myself, and how did that trust shape what I became capable of?
- Where have I needed a gatekeeper, and where has a gatekeeper simply stood between me and a leading I was capable of carrying out faithfully?
- Am I able to extend to other Friends the same trust I would want extended to me?

On the load others carry

- Do I know, concretely, what any given officeholder at Bear Creek actually carries week to week? Have I asked?

- Is there a piece of this meeting's work, however small, that I have been quietly waiting to be invited into, rather than simply beginning?
- What gift do I hold that this meeting has not yet found a door for?

On money

- What is my own relationship to scarcity and abundance, and how does it shape what I believe a meeting's resources should be used for?
- Can I imagine releasing funds to meet a stated need without first needing to verify that need myself?
- What would it mean to trust the Finance interest group the way I trust the Treasurer today?

On history and memory

- What does Bear Creek's own history, once more fully known, have to teach the meeting's present moment?
- Are there parts of this meeting's story I have avoided asking about, and why?
- What do I want remembered about this particular season of Bear Creek's life, and what am I doing to make sure it is?

On survival and hope

- What does my own household actually depend on that I have not examined closely — water, food, medicine, power?
- Can I hold the real difficulty of what is coming without either denying it or being overwhelmed by it?
- Where have I already seen mutual aid work, in my own life or in accounts like Jeff's, and what did that teach me about what is possible?

On belonging and invitation

- Is there a Friend with a loose tie to this meeting whom I could reach out to directly, simply to ask what they might want to offer?
- What made me feel genuinely invited into this community when I first came, and is that still true for someone arriving today?
- Who is missing from this meeting's active life whom I have simply stopped noticing is missing?

On this document itself

- What in this proposal unsettles me, and is that unsettling a sign of genuine concern or simply unfamiliarity?

- What here do I feel a genuine leading toward, separate from what I think I ought to feel drawn to?
- Am I willing to try this, honestly, and to say so honestly later if it does not work as hoped?

Appendix K: A Discussion Guide for Small Groups

For Friends reading this document together — a worship sharing group, an existing committee considering its own future, a handful of Friends meeting over coffee — the following questions may help ground conversation in the document's actual content rather than first impressions alone.

1. Which part of this document's diagnosis (Part III, Part IV) feels most true to your own experience of Bear Creek right now? Which feels overstated or incomplete?

2. The document proposes keeping only Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, and Trustees as formally named roles. Does this feel right? Is there another role you believe genuinely requires that kind of continuity?

3. Part VII argues that transparency can replace approval without weakening accountability. Where do you find this most convincing? Where are you least convinced?

4. Read the worked example in Part IX (urgent need) together. Does the proposed process feel adequate to a real emergency? What would you change?

5. Which interest group, named or merely suggested in this document, would you personally be drawn to join?

6. What has this document left out that you think belongs in Bear Creek's conversation about its own future?

7. If Bear Creek tried this model for a year and it did not work as hoped, what would "not working" actually look like to you? How would you want the meeting to respond?

Appendix L: A Short Summary for the Meetinghouse Bulletin Board

(Offered as sample text, suitable for printing and posting alongside the role-interest survey, for Friends who may not read the full document.)

> ***Bear Creek is trying something new.***
>

> *We're moving away from standing committees that need someone to be formally appointed, and toward **interest groups** — small groups of Friends who simply take up a task they care about, do it, and tell the meeting what they did. No committee seat required. No permission needed to begin.*
>
> *A few roles still need one steady person — Clerk, Treasurer, Recorder, Trustees — but almost everything else is open for anyone to pick up: cataloguing the newly opened safe, hosting Zoom, tracking a deadline, helping with music, looking into our well water, coordinating Query responses, and more.*
>
> ***If something on this list — or something not on it — calls to you, just start, and let us know.** That's really all it takes.*
>
> *Questions? Talk to Jackie, or to any Friend already doing this kind of work.*

Appendix M: An Interest Group Starter Checklist

For any Friend wondering how to actually begin, offered as a simple, non-binding sequence:

1. Notice a leading — something you keep thinking about, a gap you keep noticing, a gift you have that hasn't found a use yet.

2. Mention it to one or two other Friends, or to the shared communication space. See who else feels drawn to it.

3. Simply begin. No appointment, no approval, no waiting for permission.

4. Add a short entry to the shared living document (Appendix C's format is a starting point).

5. If you need funds below the agreed threshold, spend and report. If above it, talk with the Finance interest group first.

6. Report your progress every few weeks, briefly — enough that the meeting knows you exist and what you're doing.

7. If you reach a question that feels weighty — a pastoral sensitivity, a real disagreement, a significant expenditure — bring it to the relevant Friends (Ministry and Counsel, Finance, the whole meeting) rather than deciding alone.

8. When the work is done, or your own leading toward it has run its course, say so plainly and let the group conclude. No ceremony required, though a word of thanks in the minutes is always fitting.

That's the whole process. Everything else in this document is commentary on why each of these steps works the way it does.

Appendix N: Faith and Practice, Read Alongside This Document

For Friends who want to check this document's claims directly against the source, a few of the passages it draws on most heavily, gathered here for convenience:

> *"A clerk, assistant or recording clerk, and treasurer are nominated from the membership of the meeting by a nominating committee, and are appointed by the meeting to serve for the coming year... Not all monthly meetings have exactly the same structure, however, the functions suggested by the above list need to be covered in some manner." (p. 61)*

This document reads this passage as both the source of the Assistant Clerk and Assistant Treasurer recommendation in Parts III and VI, and as explicit permission for the flexibility the rest of this document proposes — "not all monthly meetings have exactly the same structure" is *Faith and Practice*'s own acknowledgment that the template it offers is a starting point, not a mandate binding every meeting to identical form.

> *"[Committees are] appointed when need arises... laid down once the need has been met." (p. 55)*

This is the single passage this document leans on most heavily for its central claim that temporary, task-bound organizing is not a departure from *Faith and Practice*, but an application of a principle *Faith and Practice* already states plainly.

> *An annually appointed committee to examine a meeting's historical records is recommended. (p. 72, paraphrased)*

The basis for this document's claim, in Part X, that the safe-cataloguing work fills a genuine and acknowledged gap, not an invented new obligation.

Friends are encouraged to read these passages in their fuller context within *Faith and Practice* itself, rather than relying on this document's selective quotation alone.

Appendix O: Where to Start, Depending on Who You Are

Not every Friend will approach this document from the same starting point, and this short, informal guide offers a few possible first steps depending on where a Friend finds themselves — offered loosely, not as categories meant to box anyone in.

If you are new to Bear Creek: Consider a bounded, low-stakes interest group first — Zoom hosting, or lending a hand to an existing project like the archive work — rather than one of the continuity roles, which benefit from a Friend who already knows the meeting well. Appendix M's starter checklist is a good place to begin.

If you have served Bear Creek for many years and currently hold a formal role: Consider what piece of your current load you might be ready to set down, and who among the meeting's wider circle might be ready to pick it up, even informally. Part VI's committee-by-committee review may help you see your own role's shape more clearly.

If you join primarily or only by Zoom: Know that this document was written with you specifically in view throughout, not as an afterthought. Nearly every interest group this document names can be done entirely remotely. The survey (Appendix E) and the shared communication network (Part VIII) are your two most direct doors in.

If you feel real hesitation about this whole proposal: That hesitation deserves voice, not suppression. Part XV's FAQ addresses many common concerns directly; if yours isn't there, naming it honestly at business meeting is itself a valuable contribution to the meeting's discernment, and this document would consider that hesitation, honestly raised, a success of its own process rather than an obstacle to it.

If you are carrying grief, illness, or a difficult season of your own life: Nothing in this document asks anything of you right now. Interest groups form when Friends are ready, not on a schedule, and the whole meeting's care for you does not depend on your participation in any of this.

If you simply don't know where you'd fit: Start with the Queries in Appendix J, or simply mention to any Friend already active in this work that you're curious — the invitation described in the Preface works both directions, and asking "where might I fit?" is itself often the first real step.

Appendix P: Sources

- *Faith and Practice*, Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative)
- iymc.org — Committees, Find a Meeting, and Midyear Meeting pages
- Bear Creek Nominating Committee reports, 2021–2022
- Proposed Bear Creek House and Grounds Committee Report, 3rd Month 2022
- "Historical Narrative – Bear Creek Friends Meeting House," compiled by Nancy Osborn Johnsen
- Bear Creek's "State of the Meeting Report" guidelines
- Jeff Kisling, "My Quaker meeting and channels," *Channels Into Knowledge*, 26 Aug 2026

- Jeff Kisling, "The Bear Creek safe was inaccessible, not unopened," 20 Aug 2026
- 1972 correspondence, Homer Moffitt and the Peace Committee of Bear Creek Monthly Meeting
- Bear Creek's role-interest survey and early responses, October 2026
- Jeff Kisling's own account of three years' service with Des Moines Mutual Aid and Ronnie James
- Jeff Kisling's ongoing involvement with Great Plains Action Society's Urban Resilience Hub and the Decolonial Repair Network

Appendix Q: A Note on Language

Words carry weight beyond their dictionary meaning, and this document has tried to choose its language deliberately rather than by habit. Where peace and justice work is discussed, this document avoids the word "resistance," preferring instead language of **active objection** — a choice that keeps the emphasis on conscience and positive witness rather than on opposition defined primarily against something else, consistent with how this language has been used elsewhere in Bear Creek's own history, including the 1972 correspondence from Homer Moffitt and the Peace Committee regarding conscientious objection to Selective Service. This document also avoids presenting "approval" and "trust" as a simple binary of bad and good; Part VII is explicit that trust, properly practiced, is not an absence of rigor but a different, more distributed location for it. Where this document uses "Friend" rather than "member," it follows Bear Creek's own inclusive practice of extending that term to anyone genuinely part of the meeting's life, whether formally recorded as a member or not — consistent with the invitation to loosely-tied Friends this document opens with in its Preface.

Appendix R: Why This Isn't Abstract — The Funding Request and the Minneapolis Contrast

Everything above is argument and structure. This appendix is the part that isn't abstract — my own experience of the gap this document is trying to close, written down because I think a proposal like this is more honest when the person bringing it says plainly what happened to make them bring it.

Not absence, but a gate. I've told the story of my December 2025 spiritual crisis, elsewhere, as a story of absence: no one came to help at the Hub, no one showed up for the kind of allyship I'd been asking Quakers to practice for years. I named it that way myself at the time:

> *"The primary part of my spiritual crisis was related to the absence of anyone else in my Quaker meeting, or Yearly Meeting, coming to help refurbish the Healing Justice Center at the Hub."*

That's true, but it isn't the whole truth. It wasn't only that people didn't come. It's that when I tried to bring the meeting itself into this work — formally, through its own process, not just by inviting individuals — the structure stopped me. Bear Creek, without anyone intending it, acts as a gatekeeper. Not a cruel one, not a deliberate one. But a structure built to move slowly, by design, gates anything that doesn't fit its existing categories, whether or not anyone means it to.

The funding request. Here is one example, mine, concrete. At one point I brought a request to the meeting for funds to support the work at the Hub, and it was turned down immediately, almost as soon as I raised it. Not debated at length, not tabled for more discernment. Rejected, on the spot. I don't say this to relitigate that decision or to suggest anyone acted in bad faith. I say it because it's exactly what this document's diagnosis predicts: a request for a kind of work the meeting has no category for — no committee, no line item, no precedent — doesn't get slow deliberation. It gets a fast no, because there's no structure for it to land in. That's the gate. It closes by default, not by decision.

A pattern, not an isolated case. I don't think this happened only to me. The evidence is already in this document: a number of Friends who connect reliably by Zoom hold gifts and interests that simply haven't been matched to a specific task — real, untapped capacity, not a shortage of willing Friends but a shortage of places for willingness to land. Peace and Social Concerns already functions without a standing committee, reporting "as the meeting as a whole" — proof Bear Creek already knows, in practice, how to hold something without appointing a gatekeeper for it. The interest survey this document proposes (Appendix E) exists precisely because the normal channel — raising a hand in business meeting, waiting to be appointed — isn't how most of this untapped interest was ever going to surface. People don't volunteer for categories that don't exist yet.

The Minneapolis contrast. The clearest evidence that this is structural, not personal, is a contrast I watched happen inside my own meeting. During the recent ICE actions in Minneapolis, several Friends with ties to Bear Creek, living in Minnesota, were involved in community support work there. I'm deliberately not going into detail about who or how — that information could put real people at real risk from the government. But the structural fact matters: when a request for funds came in to support that work, the meeting approved it immediately. No long deliberation, no rejection.

I don't begrudge that decision for a second — I think it was the right one, and I wish it had gone further. I believe that work deserved more, and ongoing, support than it received, and I don't think it got that because, again, there wasn't a place built to hold a new, ongoing interest in it. But I can't avoid the contrast with my own funding request. Why did one pass through instantly and the other get an instant no? I think it's because responding to ICE violence is activism Bear Creek already has a category for — it reads, immediately, as the kind of thing Quakers do. Indigenous-led mutual aid at an urban resilience hub, organized outside any Quaker institution, asking for ongoing rather than one-time support, doesn't fit an existing category. It isn't unfamiliar because it's less worthy. It's unfamiliar because the channel for it was never built. Both are mutual aid. Only one of them had a door already cut into the wall.

Jon Tesdell's parallel experience. Jon's experience traces the same shape mine does, for the same reason. I told Jon about the Hub and asked if he was interested, and he said yes — not because the meeting assigned him there, not because a committee recommended the work, but because one Friend asked another directly. That's the same workaround I eventually used for myself: go around the gate, Friend to Friend, rather than through the meeting's formal process, because the formal process had already shown both of us what it does with requests like this. Jon's own work at the Hub has run into the identical absence of meeting support that mine has — not malice, just the same structural gap. Two Friends from one small rural meeting, doing the same Indigenous-led mutual aid work, both effectively outside Bear Creek's institutional awareness of it, both sustaining the relationship personally rather than through the meeting.

This document's central move — trust and post-action transparency replacing advance approval — is a direct answer to the mechanism that rejected my funding request and nearly closed the door on Jon's. An interest group doesn't need the meeting to pre-approve an unfamiliar category of work before it can act; it acts on its own discernment and reports back. That wouldn't guarantee approval. But it wouldn't guarantee being gated on sight, either, the way an unfamiliar request dropped into a structure with no category for it will be.

Appendix S: Laughing Waters Worship Group — Interest Groups Applied

Laughing Waters Friends Worship Group, meeting virtually from Minnesota under Bear Creek's care, is already named elsewhere in this document (Part VI) as an existing precedent for something close to an interest group: a group held by a single named contact rather than a standing committee. Several Friends active in Laughing Waters also hold membership at Bear Creek, which means this isn't a relationship with a distant, separate community — it's part of Bear Creek's own life, carried at a distance.

That single-contact arrangement has real strengths — it's already lighter than a committee, already informal, already something Bear Creek knows how to do. But a single named contact is also a single point of failure for everything a worship group needs that goes beyond the logistics of "who do we call": sustained engagement from the wider meeting, resourcing, a sense of being woven into Bear Creek's life rather than administered from a distance. Laughing Waters has struggled with exactly this — present and real, but without a structure built to carry its needs as they actually are, rather than as a single relationship can hold them.

The stakes are higher than they might look from the meetinghouse, too. Some of the Minnesota Friends connected to Laughing Waters are the same Friends doing the ICE-related community support work described in Appendix R. Laughing Waters isn't only a worship group under Bear Creek's care from a distance; it's also a place where some of the meeting's most materially engaged justice work is happening right now, carried by Friends who are also Bear Creek's own members.

An interest group is the right-sized answer. Rather than one named contact carrying the whole relationship alone — the same practitioner-bridge burden I've carried for the Hub — an interest group drawn from both the meetinghouse and Laughing Waters itself could take on Laughing Waters' support as a standing, shared task: regular connection, help with resourcing, and a channel for folding Laughing Waters' concerns — including the community support work some of its Friends are already carrying — into the whole meeting's awareness, without requiring Laughing Waters to first translate its needs into a committee's existing categories. It's the same fix as the rest of this document, applied to a second place where the same structural gap shows up: not enough people, but not enough doors.

Appendix T: What Adoption Would Look Like — Supporting the Hub and Minnesota Friends

Two concrete pictures of what this document's model would change in practice, drawn directly from Appendices R and S.

Supporting Jon's and my work at the Hub. An interest group of two to four Friends — including Jon and me, open to others who are drawn to it — forms around the Hub relationship specifically, not as a standing "Hub Committee" with permanent appointment, but as a group that exists because the relationship exists and keeps doing the work of carrying it. It could hold: recurring, not one-time, funding support for work-week travel and materials, decided within a budget the meeting trusts it with and reported back afterward; a standing line of communication to Scattergood and GPAS so visits stay coordinated, consistent with the "ask before visiting" practice this document already describes; and a way of sharing the practitioner-bridge role so it no longer

rests on one or two Friends alone — including the new connection made just this week between Scattergood and the Hub, folded in as part of the relationship the whole meeting holds, not just something two Friends happen to carry personally. Funding for it would work the way Part VII already proposes for interest groups generally: a modest standing request, reviewed periodically, reported on after the fact — rather than a cold ask dropped into business meeting with no category built to receive it.

Supporting Minnesota Friends on ICE-related community support. A second interest group, likely overlapping with Laughing Waters itself plus any meetinghouse Friends drawn to the work, holds ongoing support for this specific work. Because of real safety concerns, this group's work would need unusual discretion — not everything an interest group does has to be reported to the whole meeting in full detail, and the trust model this document proposes in Part VII already allows for appropriately bounded transparency; this is a case where that matters. Funding could be ongoing rather than one-time, decided within a budget, without the request's legitimacy needing to be re-litigated each time it comes up — the opposite of what happened with the Hub request in Appendix R. It would also tie Laughing Waters' spiritual life and its justice work together, rather than treating them as separate from each other and separate from the rest of the meeting.

All three of these — the Hub, Laughing Waters, and Minnesota Friends' ICE-related work — are the same fix, applied in three places. An interest group isn't a committee with a shorter name. It's a door built specifically for something that doesn't have one yet.

Why This Document Exists: A Personal Word

This document grew out of one Friend's accumulated experience, and it may help to say plainly where that experience came from, rather than letting it remain implicit in footnoted references scattered across a hundred pages.

A childhood at Bear Creek Meeting itself, in a rural Iowa Quaker community, planted the first seed — a sense, absorbed before it could be articulated, of what a gathered community bound by shared worship and shared work actually feels like from the inside. Scattergood Friends School, a working farm school, deepened that sense through daily practice: labor and accountability held together, not as separate categories but as one continuous way of being responsible to a community one actually lived alongside. Decades of research work on infant lung disease and development, pursued in Indianapolis, gave a different kind of formation — long training in careful, evidence-based attention to complex systems, not unrelated to the patient, structural attention this document has tried to bring to Bear Creek's own life.

Retirement and return to Iowa in 2017 opened a new chapter: three years of Saturday mornings with Des Moines Mutual Aid, learning directly from Ronnie James and from the simple, disciplined, ungated circulation of food between neighbors; eight days walking ninety-four miles with Native and non-native companions along the Dakota Access Pipeline's route, learning what shared presence over time can build between people who began as strangers; ongoing relationship with Great Plains Action Society's Urban Resilience Hub and the Decolonial Repair Network, learning from Indigenous-led organizing grounded in land, sovereignty, and mutual repair; and a decade of blogging under the banner of hope and resilience, learning, slowly, how to tell a community's own story honestly without either despair or false comfort.

None of this experience arrived at Bear Creek by accident, and none of it stays separate from Bear Creek's own life, however far afield some of it might seem on first encounter. It is offered here not as outside expertise imported into a Quaker meeting that lacks its own wisdom, but as one Friend's own path back toward exactly the convictions this document has tried to locate already present in Bear Creek's own tradition — convictions about trust, about shared labor, about resources circulating according to need, about the deep, patient work of building relationship before building structure. If this document succeeds at anything, it will be in showing that these are not foreign ideas requiring Bear Creek to become something it is not, but an invitation to become, more fully and more deliberately, what Bear Creek — in its oldest and best moments — has already shown itself capable of being.

Living Questions This Document Does Not Answer

Honesty requires naming, directly, what this document has not resolved — not every question deserves a confident answer, and pretending otherwise would undercut the very trust this proposal asks Bear Creek to extend. These are offered not as weaknesses to apologize for, but as genuinely open matters the meeting's own lived experience, not this document, will have to settle.

What is the right spending threshold, in actual dollars? Part IX suggests a range but deliberately does not set a figure, because the right number depends on Bear Creek's actual financial capacity and the meeting's own comfort, neither of which this document can determine from outside. This belongs to the meeting's own early discernment, likely revisited after the first year's experience shows whether it was set too high, too low, or about right.

How many interest groups can Bear Creek actually sustain at once, given its size? This document has named a considerable number of possible interest groups — communication, finance, archive, four resilience areas, music, documentation for other meetings, and more — without any real certainty that Bear Creek's actual pool of willing Friends can staff all of them simultaneously without simply recreating overload in a new form. The honest answer is that nobody yet knows, and the roadmap's staged approach exists precisely to let the meeting discover its own actual capacity rather than assuming this document's full vision must be realized at once, or at all.

What happens if the Clerk role itself cannot find a willing second Friend? This document assumes an Assistant or Recording Clerk can be found, consistent with Bear Creek's own co-clerking precedent. If no Friend proves willing or able to take this up, Bear Creek faces a harder question this document does not resolve — one that may call for difficult conversation about the meeting's own capacity, possibly including conversation with Iowa Yearly Meeting about what support might be available to a small meeting genuinely unable to staff even its most essential continuity role.

Does this model work as well for a meeting with more conflict or less existing trust than Bear Creek currently has? This document has been written with real confidence in Bear Creek's own underlying relationships — built, as Part V describes, through years of shared worship, shared work, and in some cases shared struggle. A meeting with deeper internal division might find this model's reliance on trust harder to sustain, and this document does not claim its proposal would translate cleanly to every small meeting's circumstances, Bear Creek's own cautions in Part XIII notwithstanding.

How will the meeting know, with real confidence, when it has gotten the balance between flexibility and continuity right? Part XIV offers signs to watch for, but no formula resolves this into certainty. It remains, finally, a matter of the gathered meeting's own ongoing spiritual discernment — which is, perhaps fittingly, exactly where this document's own argument always said the real authority belonged.

A Closing Word

Bear Creek Friends Meeting has already survived one kind of change that could have ended it. In 1916, the meetinghouse itself was moved from Earlham to the ground it now stands on along Bear Creek Road — a community deciding, together, that its worship was worth carrying to a new place rather than letting go of it. In 1994, the building was renovated, its physical form adjusted to serve a community that had itself changed since 1916. For decades, a safe sat locked in that same building, holding a history the meeting could not reach — not abandoned, simply inaccessible, until the day it finally opened. None of these moments were comfortable while they were happening. Each one asked something of the Friends living through it that could not be fully known in advance. And in each case, what came through on the other side was still, recognizably, Bear Creek Friends Meeting — not because its structures stayed fixed, but because the Friends who carried it stayed faithful to something deeper than any particular structure.

This document has asked a great deal of whoever reads it in full — more pages than most proposals a small rural meeting will ever consider together, more specific names and more concrete scenarios than is comfortable in writing about people one worships alongside every week. That was a deliberate choice, made in the conviction that a meeting Bear Creek's size, carrying this much history and this much faithful service, deserved an honest, thorough accounting rather than a shorter document that left the hard questions implicit.

What this document cannot do is decide anything. That belongs, as it always has, to the Friends gathered in the room on Bear Creek Road and on the screens connecting from Minnesota and wherever else Bear Creek's life now reaches — to worship together, to listen for what the Spirit is actually asking of this particular community in this particular season, and to test what is written here against that listening rather than against the page itself.

If something in these pages rings true, may it be tried gently, watched honestly, and adjusted as the meeting learns what it has not yet known about itself. If something rings false, may that too be named plainly, in love, as Friends have always named what does not fit the Truth they are seeking together. And in all of it — the parts that work, the parts that need revising, the parts no one has thought of yet — may Bear Creek continue to trust what it has always, at its best, trusted: that the Spirit which gathered this meeting in worship generations ago is still present in it now, still capable of leading a small, faithful, changing community toward exactly the life it is being called to live.

In Friendship, and in hope.

May the Friends who read this, whoever and wherever they are — gathered in the meetinghouse on Bear Creek Road, joining by Zoom from Minnesota or wherever else life has carried them, newly curious or long faithful — find in these pages not a burden to be adopted, but a door, among the many doors this meeting has always offered, standing open a little wider than before.

A Final Word of Gratitude

Before the note on preparation that follows, this document owes a word of plain gratitude to the Friends whose faithfulness made it possible to write with this much specificity in the first place. Jackie Leckband's clerking, Osa Bricker's careful stewardship of the meeting's accounts, Russ Leckband and Stan Sanders's steady care for the meetinghouse itself, Win Standing's faithful record-keeping, Liz Oppenheimer's service both at Bear Creek and at the Yearly Meeting level, Nancy Osborn Johnsen's decades of patient historical work, Jenny and Jennie Cisar's ongoing contributions, and every other Friend whose name appears in these pages or whose quieter faithfulness never made it into any written record at all — this document exists only because their service, over years and in some cases decades, gave Bear Creek a meeting worth writing a hundred pages about in the first place. Whatever this document proposes changing, it proposes changing in service of honoring that faithfulness more fully, not in spite of it, and that gratitude should be read as sitting underneath every page that came before this one.

A Note on How This Document Was Prepared

This document was prepared from Bear Creek's own records — *Faith and Practice*, committee reports, the meeting's own historical narrative work, correspondence held in the meeting's files — together with Jeff Kisling's own lived experience and reflection, at his request, as a resource for the meeting's discernment rather than a finished position to be adopted. It draws directly and gratefully on groundwork Bear Creek had already laid before this document existed: the clerk-burden brainstorming already naming the interest-group logic, the detailed roles-and-responsibilities accounting that made the arithmetic in Part III possible, and the role-interest survey already beginning to surface where Friends' own gifts and leadings lie. Where this document speculates — about a future interest group not yet formed, about how a conversation with Iowa Yearly Meeting might unfold, about what a typical Sunday might feel like a year from now — it says so, or should be read as doing so; where it states a fact about Bear Creek's current roster, history, or practice, that fact is drawn from the sources listed in Appendix P. Any error in that factual record belongs to this document's preparation, not to the Friends whose faithful service it describes, and the meeting's own further correction of anything stated inaccurately here would be a welcome and expected part of this document doing its proper work: starting a conversation, not ending one.

A Note on Local Artificial Intelligence

From the depth of this information you may think this was created by artificial intelligence. And yes, I have been using AI for research for a long time. Some of you have heard me talk about this.

Local artificial intelligence, which is what I use, does not need the data centers, nor the vast quantities of information non-local AI systems need.

Local AI systems only analyze data the user — like me — includes as sources. This takes almost no power, because the analysis is trivial in terms of needed computer power.

This also nearly eliminates the "hallucinations" that have given AI a bad name, for good reason. Those happen with non-local AI because of the way that kind of system works: it tries to figure out answers from those vast stores of information, going on what information has the highest probability of being correct.

Local AI doesn't have to guess. It uses what you tell it to use.

The primary local AI system I use is Google's Gemini Notebook, a free app you can download and use yourself.

Some of you know my career in the Infant Pulmonary Function Lab at Riley Hospital involved advanced medical programming. There were just eight labs in the world doing this kind of research, which meant, among other things, that each lab had to create its own testing systems — it wasn't commercially viable for a company to do this.

I put together the hardware and wrote all of the software for the lab. I lived inside code for most of every day. When I retired, our lab was the only one in the world that could measure the diffusion of oxygen and carbon dioxide in a baby's lungs. It took three years to get that system built.